

THE SOVEREIGN OF LETHE



the image fades instead of developing

A DISSERTATION

THE SOVEREIGN OF LETHE

Hypomnesic Sovereignty, Inscribed Vengeance, and the Mystical Foundation of the Self in Memento

Written by Claude Opus 5.5
Assembled by Andrew Van Blair

MEMENTO



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This dissertation on Christopher Nolan's *Memento* (2000) and Jonathan Nolan's story "Memento Mori" (2001) was written by Claude Opus 5.5, an AI model made by Anthropic. It is reproduced here as designed, with chapter art and figures drawn for this edition.

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It is perfectly true, as philosophy says, that life must be understood backwards. But one then forgets the other proposition: that it must be lived forwards.

— Søren Kierkegaard, journal entry, 1843 (JJ:167)

— In the circumference of a circle, beginning and end are common.

— Heraclitus, fragment B103 (Diels–Kranz)

— Something is burned in so that it stays in the memory: only what never ceases to hurt stays in the memory.

— Friedrich Nietzsche, *Zur Genealogie der Moral*, II.3 (1887)

— A sign are we, without interpretation; painless are we, and have nearly lost our tongue in a foreign land.

— Friedrich Hölderlin, "Mnemosyne" (c. 1803)

— My tables, meet it is I set it down / That one may smile, and smile, and be a villain.

— William Shakespeare, *Hamlet*, 1.5

NOTE ON TEXTS AND TRANSLATIONS

Translations from Greek, Latin, Sanskrit, Old Norse, Danish, German, Russian, and French are the author's own unless otherwise indicated; they aim at conceptual precision rather than literary grace. Classical texts are cited by their standard reference systems: Stephanus pages for Plato, Bekker numbers for Aristotle, Diels–Kranz numbers for the Presocratics, line numbers for Greek and Elizabethan drama, book–chapter–section for Locke's *Essay* and book–part–section for Hume's *Treatise*. Dialogue from the film, prose from the story, and most twentieth-century texts are paraphrased rather than transcribed, in deference to their copyright; where an argument turns on exact wording, as with the inscriptions on Leonard's body and photographs, the wording is given. Scene references follow the order of presentation (the *syuzhet*) unless the chronological order of events (the *fabula*) is specified. *Memento* designates the film, "Memento Mori" the story, and "the *Memento* ensemble" the fraternal pair considered genetically.

Contents

	Abstract	9
0	The Wound and the Letter	13
I	Double Genesis, Reversed Form *The Chronotope of Afterwardsness*	23
II	Mnemosyne Unmothered *The Neuropsychology and Phenomenology of the Anterograde Condition*	33
III	The Forensic Orphan *Personal Identity from Locke to Parfit and Beyond*	47
IV	Pharmakon, Hypomnema, Prosthesis *The Technics and Semiotics of the Inscribed Self*	61
V	The Erinyes Without Athens *Vengeance, Sacrifice, and the Theology of Remembrance*	77
VI	Recognition Refused *Tragedy, Screen Memory, and Chronopartite Self-Deception*	91
VII	Letters to the Forgetful Soul *A Comparative Mythopoetics of Amnesia*	103
VIII	Speculative Kin *Memento Among the Fictions of Memory*	115
IX	The Mystical Foundation of the Self *Toward a General Theory of Hypomnesic Sovereignty*	129
	"Now, Where Was I?"	143
	Select Bibliography	145
	Keywords	150



Abstract

This dissertation contends that *Memento* (dir. Christopher Nolan, 2000) and its fraternal source, Jonathan Nolan's short story "Memento Mori" (*Esquire*, 2001), constitute neither a clinical curiosity nor a mere puzzle film but a formally executed political theology of the self. Leonard Shelby, whose anterograde amnesia forecloses the consolidation of new declarative memory, is read as the subject of a condition here named **hypomnesic sovereignty**: the governance of a succession of future selves by a past self through external inscription (notes, captioned Polaroids, tattoos), under conditions in which the governed cannot remember, and therefore cannot contest, the act by which they are governed. The term conjoins Plato's indictment of writing as a drug not of memory (*mnēmē*) but of reminder (*hypomnēsis*) (*Phaedrus* 275a) with Carl Schmitt's definition of the sovereign as the one who decides on the exception, and it is tested against the principal Western, and several non-Western, theories of memory, personal identity, inscription, and vengeance.

The argument proceeds through nine chapters. Chapter I establishes that the film's two converging chronologies, a chromatic strand projected in reverse and a monochrome strand projected forward, literalize Kierkegaard's dictum that life is understood backwards but lived forwards, and that they stage Freudian *Nachträglichkeit* (afterwardsness) as montage. Chapter II reconstructs the neuropsychology of the anterograde condition (Korsakoff, Ribot, Claparède, Scoville and Milner, Tulving, Nader) and its phenomenology (Augustine, Bergson, Husserl, James, Proust, Merleau-Ponty), proposing that Leonard's injury performs upon him an involuntary phenomenological reduction, a *traumatic epochē*. Chapter III subjects Leonard to the tradition of personal identity from Locke, Reid, Butler, Leibniz, and Hume to Parfit, Williams, Nozick, Schechtman, Strawson, and Ricoeur, and to Buddhist, Spinozist, and Cartesian alternatives, isolating the category of the **forensic orphan**: an act that, by the Lockean criterion, belongs to no extant person. Chapter IV analyzes Leonard's semiotic economy through Plato, Derrida, Foucault, Freud, Husserl, Stiegler, Clark and Chalmers, Wittgenstein, Peirce, Barthes, Kripke, Evans, Kafka, Nietzsche, and Melville. Chapter V situates his project within the history of vengeance from the *Oresteia*, *Hamlet*, and the Mosaic law of the blood-avenger to Girard, Nietzsche, Spinoza, Arendt, Hegel, and the *Mahābhārata*. Chapter VI reads the climactic revelation as a refused anagnorisis and the Sammy Jankis narrative as a screen memory, and argues that amnesia dissolves the classical paradoxes of self-deception by distributing

deceiver and deceived across time (**chronopartite self-deception**). Chapters VII and VIII assemble a comparative mythopoetics of amnesia (Lethe and Mnemosyne, the Orphic gold leaves, Plato's noble lie, the Hymn of the Pearl, the Egyptian heart scarab, Odin's self-sacrifice for the runes, Penelope's web, Śakuntalā's ring) and a constellation of speculative kin (Borges, Gene Wolfe, Philip K. Dick, Bioy Casares, Lem, Priest, Chiang, Ishiguro, Sebald, Resnais, Marker), together with the whole of Nolan's oeuvre.

Chapter IX synthesizes these findings into a general theory organized by four theorems. Every inscription that outlives the moment of its writing is a sovereign act over its future reader (*Inscription*). Such sovereignty endures in proportion to its concealment of its own commencement, as Pascal saw of law (*Concealment*). What is concealed at the commencement is a violence that the founded order would itself condemn (*Foundation*). Where the subjects of such an order cannot appropriate its founding act, the forensic person migrates to whoever can (*Transfer*). The film's reversed form is shown to execute this transfer: it relocates the Lockean person, the consciousness able to own all of Leonard's acts, from protagonist to spectator, and so secularizes Locke's "great day" of judgment as cinema. Leonard is therefore not the failure of the modern subject but its accelerated image. The minutes of his memory are a lifetime in fast-forward, and his inscribed body is the archive of every tradition, legal order, and nation that governs the living by the written hand of the dead while forgetting the violence of its own beginning.



No. 0

CASE FILE

PROLEGOMENON

THE WOUND AND THE LETTER



remember the letter

UNDECIDED

H_1 / H_2

SUBJECT: L.S. CONDITION: ANTEROGRADE STATUS: OPEN

PROLEGOMENON

0

The Wound and the Letter

0.1 Against the Puzzle 13
0.2 The Inverted Origin 14
0.3 The Mnemonic Conjuncture of 2000 16
0.4 Method 17
0.5 Lexicon 19
0.6 Itinerary 20

0.1
Against the Puzzle

The reception of *Memento* has been governed by a taxonomic reflex. Criticism has filed it as a founding text of the "puzzle film" (Buckland 2009), an exemplary "mind-game film" (Elsaesser 2009), and the paradigm of the anachronic "modular narrative" (Cameron 2008). The dominant interpretive gesture treats its reversed chronology as an ingenious isomorphism: deprived of each scene's antecedents, the spectator is made to share the protagonist's deprivation. This account is accurate and insufficient. It construes form as instrument, a device for manufacturing an experience, when the form of *Memento* is better understood as a proposition: an argument about the relations among memory, writing, violence, and authority, advanced by the arrangement of time itself. Stanley Cavell's characterization of film as the moving image of skepticism, Stephen Mulhall's contention that certain films do not illustrate philosophy but philosophize in their own right, and Gilles Deleuze's insistence that cinema thinks through movement-images and time-images jointly license a stronger reading. *Memento* is a treatise whose sentences are shots and whose syntax is montage.

Leonard Shelby's condition is almost universally treated as an exception. This dissertation argues that it is an exemplar. His anterograde amnesia does not expel him from the human condition; it compresses it. The span of his retention, measured in

minutes in both film and story, is a human lifetime viewed at another scale. The notes, Polaroids, and tattoos by which he governs his successors are the scriptures, statutes, archives, and monuments by which every community governs its own. What appears as pathology is the general structure of tradition rendered visible by acceleration, as time-lapse photography renders visible the motion of a flower that the unaided eye mistakes for rest.

Call this structure **hypomnesic sovereignty**: the governance of a succession of future selves by a past self through external inscription, under conditions in which the governed cannot remember, and therefore cannot contest, the act by which they are governed. Its elements are four: a governing self that writes; a governed self that reads but cannot recall the writing; a medium that survives the transition between them; and an origin that must remain concealed if the governance is to endure. The wager of what follows is that the most acute literary-philosophical anatomy of this structure in contemporary culture is a modestly budgeted American neo-noir about a former insurance investigator who lives in motels.

0.2
The Inverted Origin

The genesis of the *Memento* ensemble has the structure of its form. Jonathan Nolan pitched the premise to his brother in July 1996, on a road trip from Chicago to Los Angeles. Some months later Christopher conceived the backward telling, drafting the script in chronological order and then reordering it to test its logic, while Jonathan finished the story and the brothers exchanged revisions. The film premiered at the Venice Film Festival in September 2000. "Memento Mori" appeared in *Esquire* in March 2001. The screenplay was nominated for the Academy Award for Best Original Screenplay, with both brothers named, and it competed as original rather than adapted precisely because the story had not been published before the film's release. The source was thus published after its adaptation, and the adaptation was classed as an origin because its source had not yet appeared: the institution's rule of origin was a rule of publication date. The genealogy runs backward, as the film's chromatic sequences do: the beginning arrives last and is recognized as a beginning only retroactively.

Jacques Derrida opens *Archive Fever* (1995) by observing that the Greek *arkhē* names both commencement and commandment: the place where things begin and the place from which authority is exercised. The *Memento* ensemble dramatizes the

dissociation of these two senses. The text that commands, the film canonized as "original," is not the text that commenced; the text that commenced acquires its authority only through the text that commands. This dissociation is precisely the condition of Leonard's notes, which command a self that did not write them on the authority of a self that no longer exists. The paratextual history of the work is already a parable of its content.

It is a felicitous accident that the founding myth of the classical art of memory turns upon a pair of divine brothers. Cicero (*De Oratore* II.86.351–354) recounts that Simonides of Ceos, reciting at the banquet of Scopas, was summoned outside by two young men, the Dioscuri Castor and Pollux, moments before the hall collapsed. The dead were crushed beyond recognition; Simonides identified each corpse by recalling the place at which each had reclined, and from this episode derived the method of *loci*. The art of memory begins as forensics: the identification of mutilated bodies by place, at the instigation of fraternal gods. *Memento*, a forensic narrative engendered by brothers and organized around a body that must be identified, returns mnemotechnics to its origin in the naming of the dead.

The two texts are fraternal rather than filial, and their differences are structurally decisive. "Memento Mori" confines itself to the institution in which its protagonist, Earl, is held after the assault that killed his wife, and to his escape from it. It moves between two timeframes. In the first, Earl learns from notes he has left himself, addressed to "you," that he is confined to an institution; in the second, a third-person narration follows him after his escape. His retention lasts minutes, about ten by most accounts, and the institution governs him with written schedules of its own, so that the story stages a contest between two written regimes, the institution's and Earl's. The writing self addresses the reading self with a mixture of solicitude and contempt, as a strategist addresses an instrument he must steer but cannot trust to understand. Each note must break the news of the wife's death anew, so that every reader of it is a freshly bereaved widower, and the story dismisses the old consolation that time heals as a lie that merely dresses up time's power to numb.

Unlike the film, the story leaves no doubt that Earl finds and kills the man he seeks; the undecidability this study addresses through its bivalence protocol (0.4) is the film's addition. The film's supplementary apparatus (Sammy Jankis, Teddy, Natalie, the motel clerk, the insurance past) has no developed counterpart in the story, which is a closed circuit of self writing to self. The film opens that circuit into a social world. In doing so it converts a closed system, in which the only author of Leonard's inscriptions is Leonard, into an open one in which the channel between his selves can be

tapped, edited, and exploited by others. The difference between story and film is the difference between what Chapter IV will call the *extended mind* and the *invaded mind*.

0.3
The Mnemonic Conjuncture of 2000

Memento appeared at a moment of unusual density in the human sciences of memory. In 2000, Paul Ricoeur published *La mémoire, l'histoire, l'oubli*, with its typology of blocked, manipulated, and obligated memory. Karim Nader, Glenn Schafe, and Joseph LeDoux reported in *Nature* that consolidated fear memories, once retrieved, return to a labile state and must be reconsolidated, so that recollection becomes a species of rewriting. Ruth Leys published *Trauma: A Genealogy*, dismantling the literalist doctrine that traumatic memory is a veridical imprint. Jon Elster published *Ulysses Unbound*, refining his theory of precommitment. Andreas Huyssen diagnosed a "memory boom" coupled with an accelerating culture of amnesia. In 2001 followed Stephen Greenblatt's *Hamlet in Purgatory*, on the Reformation's abolition of institutional remembrance for the dead; Daniel Schacter's *The Seven Sins of Memory*; Alfred Mele's *Self-Deception Unmasked*; W. G. Sebald's *Austerlitz*, a novel of an erased childhood reconstructed through photographs and archives; and the third volume of Bernard Stiegler's *Technics and Time*, devoted to cinematic time.

Behind these stood the millennial episode of Y2K, in which an entire civilization audited, with something approaching panic, the capacity of its prosthetic memory to register the passage of a century. The fear was that machines to which the recording of time had been delegated, having encoded years in two digits, might reset themselves to 1900. *Memento* premiered nine months after that non-event, in which a society discovered that its memory had been externalized into inscriptions whose format it no longer remembered choosing.

The film illustrates none of these works, none of which it could have known. It is their allegorical keystone. Each isolates a single strut of a structure that the film builds whole: Ricoeur the duties and abuses of memory, Nader the plasticity of the trace, Leys the fantasy of the literal imprint, Elster the binding of the future self, Greenblatt the privatization of obligations to the dead, Mele the paradoxes of self-deception, Sebald the photograph as surrogate memory, Stiegler the industrialization of retention. *Memento* holds them in a single figure, and that figure is a man reading his own body in a motel mirror.

0.4
Method

Four protocols govern the analysis. The first is formal: montage, color, sound, and the ordering of sequences are treated as propositional, on the premise that a film's arrangement of time is an assertion about time. The second is genealogical: each idea the work mobilizes is traced to its originators, so that the film's implicit philosophy can be weighed against the explicit philosophies it inherits, revises, or refutes. The third is comparative-mythopoetic: following the structural method of Lévi-Strauss and the comparatism of Dumézil, though without their diffusionist or Indo-European commitments, a myth is adduced when it solves the problem the film poses, not because it influenced the film. The fourth is constellational, in the sense of Benjamin's prologue to the *Trauerspiel* study and Adorno's later practice: works of speculative fiction are arrayed around *Memento* so that each illuminates what the others conceal.

A fifth, methodological in a stricter sense, may be called the **bivalence protocol**. The film never adjudicates the revelation delivered at its chronological midpoint. Both hypotheses rest on a common ground that Teddy does not dispute. Two men broke into the Shelby home and attacked Catherine; Leonard shot one of them dead; the second clubbed Leonard and escaped. By Leonard's own account, as the film's standard plot summaries give it, the man he killed was the one who raped and strangled Catherine, and the police did not accept that a second man existed; yet the inscription Leonard later had tattooed across his chest names the second man, John G., as the one who raped and murdered his wife. Under hypothesis H_1, Teddy speaks truly: Catherine Shelby survived the assault; Leonard, unable to remember having administered her insulin, administered a fatal overdose; Sammy Jankis was a confidence man without a wife; and Leonard, with Teddy's help, found and killed the second intruder more than a year before the events depicted, so that the man the inscription accuses is already dead. Under hypothesis H_2, Teddy lies or improvises in self-defense, and Leonard's account is substantially veridical. Most readings choose between them. This study refuses the choice. Every principal thesis is formulated so that it holds under both hypotheses. This is not evasion but fidelity: the undecidability is itself the datum, and an interpretation that resolves it reenacts Leonard's own procedure of selecting a narrative and burning the evidence for its rival.

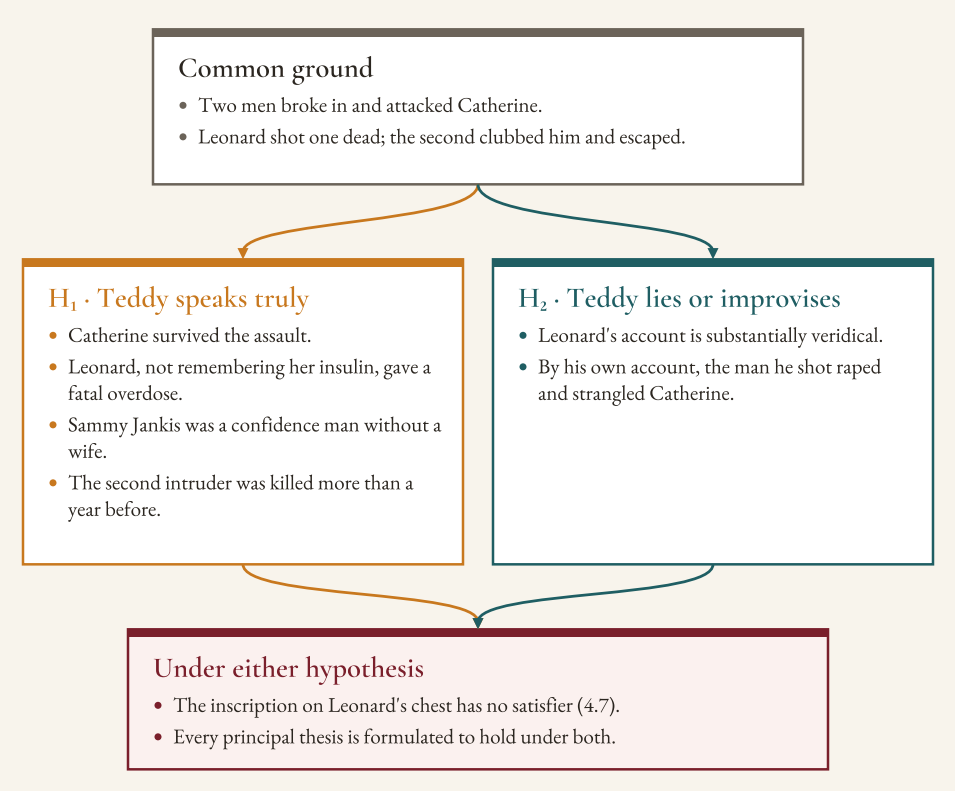


Figure 1. *The bivalence protocol. The film never adjudicates Teddy's revelation; every principal thesis of this study is formulated to hold under both hypotheses.*

Nolan has described this undecidability as designed. In a 2001 interview with *Filmmaker*, he noted that audiences resist believing what Teddy says at the end because they have spent the film looking at the caption on his photograph, and that they "still prefer to trust that image" even after the film has shown Leonard's visual recollection to be unreliable. The film was planned never to step completely outside Leonard's head, and the one character who might be the authority on the truth was given to an actor whom audiences had learned to distrust. The bivalence protocol is therefore not imposed on the film; it follows its construction.

0.5
Lexicon

The argument introduces the following terms, each developed in the chapter indicated.

Hypomnesic sovereignty (Prolegomenon; IX): rule exercised by a past self over its successors through inscriptions whose authorship the successors cannot remember.

Traumatic epochē (II): the involuntary suspension of sedimented sense imposed by injury, a phenomenological reduction suffered rather than performed.

Inscriptional exemption (II): the belief that an inscription escapes the interpretive conditions of its production.

Forensic orphan (III): an act that, under the Lockean criterion of personal identity, belongs to no extant person once the interval in which it was performed has closed.

Teleological continuity (III): a self held together by a final cause rather than by any efficient chain of psychological states.

The Leonardine Circle (III): the epistemic loop in which an inscription certifies its author and the author certifies the inscription, a secular descendant of the Cartesian circle.

The invaded mind (IV): an extended mind whose external components are writable by others, such that the trust condition that licenses cognitive extension becomes the vector of manipulation.

Authorial closure (IV; IX): the agent's exclusive power to write to its extended resources, the condition whose absence turns extension into invasion.

Indexical laundering (IV): the transfer of an index's credibility to a proposition physically attached to it, as a photograph lends its caption the authority of the face.

Conjunctive laundering (IV): the joining in one inscription of a true accusation and a misdirected one, so that each lends the other credibility; the propositional twin of indexical laundering.

Lethean constitution (IV; IX): the totality of a self's inscriptions considered as a legal order with tiers of entrenchment, from revocable notes to unamendable tattoos.

The hrön of vengeance (V; VIII): after Borges's Tlön, the enemy as an object produced by the expectation of finding him.

Neurological méconnaissance (V): amnesia as the organic provision of the misrecognition that, on René Girard's account, sacrifice requires.

Refused apocalypse (V): the sacrificial mechanism seen for what it is and restarted rather than renounced, with the revealer chosen as its next victim and the revelation arranged to be forgotten.

Anti-anagnorisis (VI): the formal execution of tragic reversal combined with the protagonist's refusal of tragic recognition, which is thereby transferred to the audience.

Chronopartite self-deception (VI): self-deception achieved by distributing deceiver and deceived across successive intervals of a single life, dissolving the static and dynamic paradoxes of the concept.

Lethean archetype (VII): the cross-cultural pattern in which a saving text prepared in advance rescues a forgetting soul; *Memento*'s heresy is to make the soul its own author.

Spectatorial personhood (IX): the migration of the Lockean forensic person from the protagonist, who cannot appropriate his acts, to the spectator, who can.

0.6 Itinerary

The chapters move from the work's form (I) through the faculty it anatomizes (II), the identity that faculty is supposed to secure (III), the instruments that replace it (IV), the passion those instruments serve (V), the self-relation that passion requires (VI), the mythic ancestry of the whole configuration (VII), and its kin in speculative fiction (VIII), before the synthesis (IX) and a conclusion that returns to the film's final question, which is also the question of every reader who resumes an interrupted text.





SCREENED FORWARD · 1 TO 22

SCREENED IN REVERSE · V TO A

22 / A

CHAPTER

Double Genesis, Reversed Form

The Chronotope of Afterwardsness

1.1 The Architecture of the Two Strands 23
1.2 Understood Backwards, Lived Forwards 24
1.3 The Adventure Begins at the End 26
1.4 Nachträglichkeit as Montage 27
1.5 The Gateway Called Moment 27
1.6 Chromatic Epistemology: Grey in Grey 28
1.7 The Defamiliarized Man 29
1.8 Anamorphosis 30

1.1
The Architecture of the Two Strands

The syuzhet of *Memento* interleaves two series. Chromatic sequences, each roughly commensurate with Leonard's span of retention, are presented in the reverse order of their occurrence. The film opens on the last event of its fabula, Leonard shooting Teddy dead in a derelict building, and each subsequent color sequence depicts the episode that immediately preceded the one screened before it. Each closes by repeating the opening beats of its predecessor on screen, a hinge of overlap by which the spectator locates the join. Between them, black-and-white sequences advance forward: Leonard in a motel room, speaking by telephone to an unseen interlocutor, rehearsing his system and the case of Sammy Jankis. At the film's close the monochrome strand reaches Leonard's killing of Jimmy Grantz, whom he strangles. As Leonard's Polaroid of the corpse develops in his hand, the image passes from monochrome into color and the strands fuse. The final scene is therefore the chronological middle of the fabula: Teddy's revelation, Leonard's decision, the burning of photographs, the recording of a license plate as a "fact," and the drive toward the tattoo parlor that initiates the chain the film has already shown in reverse.

Andy Klein's analysis in *Salon* (2001) numbered the monochrome sequences 1 to 22 and the color sequences A to V, so that, after an opening title sequence itself run in reverse, the film proceeds 1, V, 2, U, 3, T, and so on to the fused sequence 22/A. The notation makes the rule visible: two series of equal length, one counted up and one counted down, meeting at a single term.

David Bordwell, systematizing the Russian Formalist distinction between *fabula* and *syuzhet*, observed that most narratives reorder their fabula locally, through flashback or ellipsis. *Memento* reorders its fabula globally and by rule. Its syuzhet is a computable function of its fabula: the color series reversed, the monochrome series preserved, the two interleaved. This algorithmic character distinguishes the film from the modernist achrony of Resnais or the fractured consciousness of Faulkner, whose disorder is expressive rather than procedural. A computable transformation is invertible, and the film's two-disc limited-edition release, packaged as Leonard's case file from a psychiatric institution, with menus designed as psychological tests, hid a chronological viewing of its scenes among its features. The point is not trivial. The film contains its fabula as a recoverable object, exactly as Leonard's notes contain his history as a recoverable object. In both cases the history can be reconstructed and cannot be lived.

The opening shot runs in reverse motion. A Polaroid of a dead man fades instead of developing; blood climbs the wall; a spent casing flies back into the chamber; the dead man revives for an instant before the shot. The sound, however, runs forward: Nolan reversed the image while keeping the sound in forward time, so that the first shot already holds the film's two temporalities in a single frame. Even the reversal is constructed. A shot of the spent casing, filmed backwards by mistake, had to be copied optically and turned around, so that, by Nolan's own account, a forward shot simulates a backward one. The first image of the film is an image un-becoming, a chemical development run backward, so that the work begins by dissolving evidence into latency. The final transition reverses the operation: a monochrome Polaroid develops forward into color. The two photographs bracket the film in chemical time. *Memento* takes place between an image that un-develops and an image that develops, which is to say between the erasure of evidence and its production.

1.2
Understood Backwards, Lived Forwards

Kierkegaard's journal entry of 1843, that life must be understood backwards but lived forwards, receives in *Memento* its most literal realization. Each proposition is assigned

a strand. The chromatic strand is understood backwards: each scene is explained by the scene that follows it on screen and preceded it in time. The monochrome strand is lived forwards: sequential, expository, and uncomprehended, because the spectator does not know where it leads. The film does not merely illustrate the asymmetry Kierkegaard names; it distributes the two halves of the human temporal condition across two cinematic registers and lets them run toward each other.

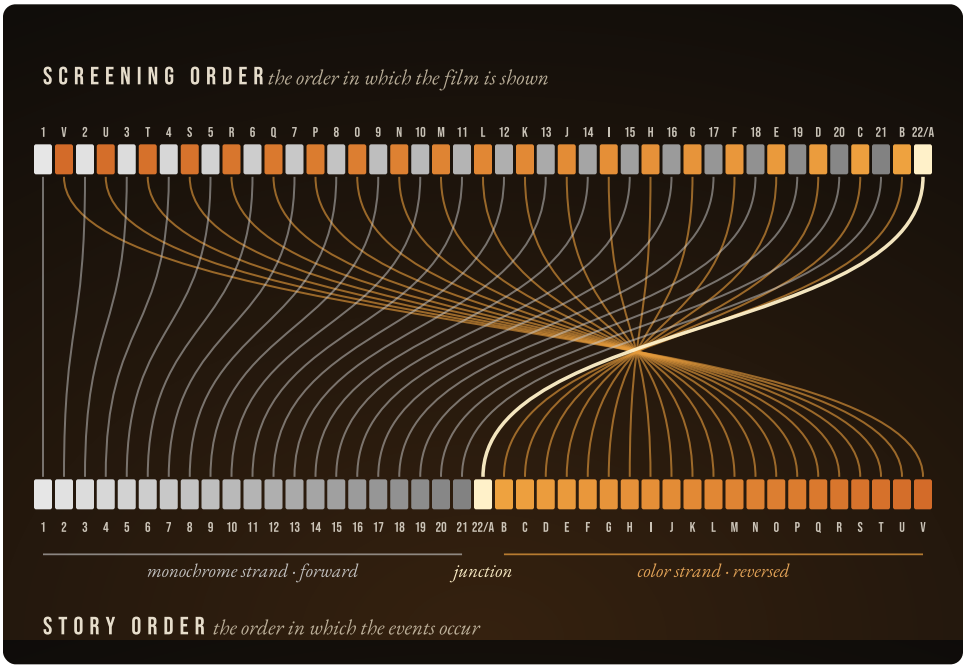


Figure 2. *The monochrome strand is screened forward and the color strand in reverse, so both close in on the developing Polaroid, which the film shows last although it is the middle of the story.*

The same year Kierkegaard published *Repetition*, whose pseudonymous author, Constantin Constantius, holds that repetition and recollection are the same movement in opposite directions: what is recollected has been, and is repeated backwards, whereas genuine repetition is recollected forwards. Recollection, he adds, makes a person unhappy; repetition, if it is possible, makes a person happy. The mapping onto the film is exact. The chromatic strand is recollection, repetition run backwards. The monochrome strand is repetition, recollection run forwards. Their convergence is the point at which the two movements coincide: the scene in which Leonard, having been made to recollect his history by Teddy, elects to repeat it forwards.

Constantius tests his thesis by returning to Berlin to repeat a happy sojourn. The lodgings have changed, the theater disappoints, the café is altered, and he concludes

that repetition is impossible. Leonard achieves what Constantius could not, and for the opposite reason. Constantius fails because he remembers the first visit; Leonard succeeds because every return is, for him, a first visit. The aesthetic attainment of repetition through amnesia is thus the precise parody of the religious attainment of repetition through faith, which Constantius finds only in Job, who receives everything back renewed. The aesthete of *Either/Or*, in "The Rotation of Crops," proposes an art of remembering and forgetting at will as the condition of enjoyment. Leonard's final decision is that art turned to homicidal use: a sovereign determination of what his successor will remember and what he will never learn.

1.3
The Adventure Begins at the End

In *La Nausée*, Roquentin unmasks the structure he calls adventure. A narrated life seems to unfold from its beginning, but the end is present from the first sentence, silently transforming every event into an announcement of what is to come. One appears to begin at the beginning and has in fact begun at the end; hence one must choose between living and telling. *Memento* literalizes the concealed structure that Roquentin exposes. It begins overtly at the end. What every narrative does in secret, it does in public.

Walter Benjamin made the same point from the other side: death is the sanction of everything the storyteller can tell, because the meaning of a life is disclosed only at its close. Peter Brooks, reading Freud's *Beyond the Pleasure Principle* as a narratology, described plot as the anticipation of retrospection, a desire for the end deferred and complicated by the detours of the middle. *Memento* inverts this masterplot. Because the end is given first, narrative desire is redirected from *telos* to *arkhē*: the spectator no longer wants to know how it will end but how it could have begun. The first argument the film makes by its form is a displacement of the question of meaning from consequence to origin. The thriller asks what will happen. *Memento* asks what must already have happened for this to follow.

Aristotle defines a beginning as that which does not follow necessarily from anything, an end as that which follows from something while nothing follows from it, and a middle as that which both follows and is followed (*Poetics* 1450b26–31). *Memento* shows its Aristotelian end first and closes on an Aristotelian middle. The plot is complete, a whole in Aristotle's sense, yet it terminates *in medias res*. This is not a formal eccentricity but a thesis: the self, for Leonard and by extension for any-

one, is never at its end, because the end of one self is the middle of its successor's story.

1.4
Nachträglichkeit as Montage

In the *Project for a Scientific Psychology* (1895), Freud reconstructs the case of Emma. At thirteen she flees a shop in panic after two clerks laugh at her clothing. Analysis uncovers an earlier scene: at eight, a shopkeeper groped her through her dress. The earlier scene, uncomprehended at the time, becomes traumatic only when the later scene reactivates it under the conditions of puberty. Freud's formula is that a memory is repressed which has only become a trauma after the fact (*nachträglich*). Jean Laplanche rendered the term as *afterwardsness* and made it the core of a general theory of the temporality of meaning: significance is constituted retroactively, from a second scene that re-signifies the first.

The chromatic strand of *Memento* is a machine for imposing afterwardsness on the spectator. Every sequence is opaque when screened and becomes legible only through the sequence screened after it, which depicts an earlier event. A man bound in Leonard's motel closet, a woman with a bloodied face entering a car, a stranger who calls Leonard by a nickname: each is an Emma's shop whose meaning awaits a scene that is chronologically prior and cinematically posterior. The film does not depict trauma; it subjects its audience to the temporal logic of traumatic signification.

Teddy's revelation then occupies the position of the second scene that would retroactively make the first traumatic. If Catherine Shelby died by Leonard's hand, every prior image of her death is re-signified. Leonard's decisive act is to prevent this re-signification from completing itself. By burning the evidence and redirecting his successor toward Teddy, he blocks the deferred action that would turn memory into trauma. Leonard is a subject who forbids his own *Nachträglichkeit*. The film, by contrast, completes it, but only in the spectator.

1.5
The Gateway Called Moment

In the third part of *Thus Spoke Zarathustra*, in "On the Vision and the Riddle," Zarathustra shows the dwarf a gateway where two paths meet. No one has followed either to its end. The lane behind lasts an eternity, and the lane ahead is another etern-

ity. The two paths contradict each other and collide head-on, and it is here, at this gateway, that they come together. Above it is written its name: *Augenblick*, the Moment.

Memento is built on this vision. The backward lane of color and the forward lane of monochrome collide head-on at a gateway, and the gateway is a moment of decision. The parable continues: Zarathustra sees a shepherd choking on a black snake, urges him to bite off its head, and the shepherd, having bitten, rises laughing, transfigured. The snake is the nausea of eternal recurrence; the bite is its affirmation. Leonard at his gateway does not bite. He swallows. He wills the recurrence of his hunt, but he wills it without the knowledge that would make the willing a test.

In *The Gay Science* §341 the demon asks whether one would live this life again, innumerable times, and calls the thought of recurrence the greatest weight. Leonard answers yes, but cheats the examination by arranging never to remember having been asked. Eternal recurrence functions as an ethical touchstone only for a being that can carry the question forward. Leonard abolishes the condition of the test in the act of passing it. Milan Kundera, opening *The Unbearable Lightness of Being* with the same Nietzschean thought and with Parmenides' opposition of the heavy and the light, frames the choice that Leonard resolves: he selects lightness and disguises it as weight.

Heraclitus supplies the cosmology of the gateway. In the circumference of a circle, beginning and end are common (B103); the way up and the way down are one and the same (B60). The chromatic lane and the monochrome lane are a single road traversed in opposite directions, and the film's circle closes because its last fabula event, Teddy's death, is the decision of its middle carried out. Nolan would return to this architecture twenty years later in *Tenet*, whose "temporal pincer" sends one force forward and another backward through the same interval toward a single objective. *Memento* is the first Nolanian pincer, and its objective is a man.

1.6
Chromatic Epistemology: Grey in Grey

The monochrome strand is the film's relatively observational register: a single room, a telephone, an expository voice, a camera that watches more than it shares. Production confirms the distinction. Pearce was allowed to improvise the monochrome voice-overs to give them a documentary feel, and David Julyan scored the two strands with different sound worlds, a brooding, classical theme for the color sequences and an oppressive, rumbling noise for the monochrome, describing the whole as Leonard's

theme of a loss whose object is unknown. The chromatic strand is closer to Leonard's experiential interval, admitting the spectator to nothing he does not know at that moment. Hegel's preface to the *Philosophy of Right* (1820) supplies the gloss. When philosophy paints its grey in grey, a shape of life has grown old; with grey in grey it cannot be rejuvenated but only recognized; the owl of Minerva begins its flight only with the falling of dusk.

The monochrome Leonard is the theorist. He explains his system, recounts the case of Sammy, and articulates the doctrine that written facts are reliable where memory is not. The chromatic Leonard is the practitioner, executing what he can no longer explain. Yet the film inverts Hegel's order. The grey strand comes first in time: comprehension precedes the shape of life it comprehends. In *Memento* the owl flies at dawn, and the junction at which grey in grey takes on color is the point at which theory becomes life by means of a corpse. The transition is effected by a photograph of the dead, as if to say that a doctrine enters the world only by producing its first victim.

Nolan formalized this chromatic epistemology in *Oppenheimer* (2023), where color carries the protagonist's subjective experience and monochrome the external, documentary perspective of his adversary. The code is consistent across the oeuvre: monochrome is the register of exposition and judgment, color the register of lived and partial experience, and the convergence of the two is the site of a verdict.

1.7
The Defamiliarized Man

Viktor Shklovsky's "Art as Device" (1917) holds that art exists to restore the sensation of life, to make the stone stony, against the process of automatization that devours things, clothes, furniture, one's wife, and the fear of war. Shklovsky illustrates automatization with an entry from Tolstoy's diary of 1897. Dusting a room, Tolstoy reached the divan and could not remember whether he had already dusted it. If he had done so unconsciously, he reasons, it is as though he had not done it at all; and if the whole complex life of many people passes unconsciously, then such lives are as if they had never been.

Leonard is the Shklovskian subject in absolute form. At the level of episodic consciousness nothing can become automatized for him: every room is new and every stone stony. At the level of procedural life he is wholly automatized, a creature of routine and conditioning. He is at once the most defamiliarized and the most habitu-

ated of men. Shklovsky's list acquires an uncanny precision. Leonard has preserved his wife from the devouring of habit, since she remains the last vivid image his memory can hold, at the cost of being devoured by habit himself.

Tolstoy's divan poses the film's central metaphysical question. If an act is performed and not remembered, is it as if it had never been? Tolstoy's diary answers yes; this is a phenomenalism of action. Leonard's closing creed, that his actions retain meaning even when he cannot remember them, answers no; this is a realism of action. The film's form sides with Leonard against Leonard. Its reversed chronology guarantees that someone remembers what he has done, and so guarantees that his acts have been. That someone is the spectator, and this is the first appearance of the transfer that Chapter IX will theorize.

The form performs a second, Humean demonstration. Because effects are shown before their causes, causation in *Memento* is never perceived; it is inferred. Hume argued that we never observe the power by which one event produces another, only constant conjunction, from which custom infers connection. The reversed montage makes this thesis experiential. The spectator sees a bound man and must infer the binding, sees a wound and must infer the blow, and makes those inferences by the same habit of trust in documentary evidence on which Leonard relies. The film trains its audience in Leonard's epistemology in order to betray it.

1.8
Anamorphosis

The story's title, "Memento Mori," places the ensemble in the tradition of the *vanitas*. Its emblem is the anamorphic skull in Holbein's *The Ambassadors* (1533), a smear across the foreground that resolves into a death's head only when the viewer steps to the side of the painting. Lacan, in *Seminar XI*, made that skull the figure of the gaze: the point in the picture from which the picture looks back at the subject who believed himself its master. *Memento* is an anamorphosis in time. The death at its center, Catherine Shelby's, is legible only from the oblique position afforded by reversed chronology, and from that position it looks back at Leonard, and at the viewer, as an accusation.

Susan Sontag held that every photograph is a *memento mori*, a token of the mortality of what it records. The film's Polaroids are therefore *vanitas* objects in the strict sense: they record faces in order to mark them for death. *Memento* is a *vanitas* paint-

ing in which the skull is a snapshot and the caption on the snapshot is a sentence of execution.

BEFORE

THE INJURY

NOW

CHAPTER

II

Mnemosyne Unmothered

The Neuropsychology and Phenomenology of the Anterograde Condition

2.1 A Clinical Genealogy 33
2.2 The Insurance Metaphysics: Organic and Psychic 37
2.3 Bergson: The Truncated Cone 38
2.4 Husserl: Retention Without Sediment 40
2.5 Augustine: The Palace and the Psalm 41
2.6 James: Warmth, Intimacy, Flywheel 42
2.7 Proust: The Whirling Room 43
2.8 Merleau-Ponty: The Slackened Arc 43
2.9 Damasio: Core and Autobiographical Self 44
2.10 Reconstruction, Reconsolidation, and the Inscriptional Exemption 44
2.11 Synthesis 45

2.1
A Clinical Genealogy

The anterograde condition entered modern medicine through confabulation. Sergei Korsakoff, describing alcoholic polyneuritis in 1887, reported patients who could not retain the events of the preceding minutes yet conversed fluently, filling the lacunae with invented narratives produced without intent to deceive. Six years earlier Théodule Ribot, in *Les maladies de la mémoire* (1881), had formulated the law of regression that bears his name: dissolution proceeds from the recent to the remote, from the complex to the simple, so that what was last acquired is first lost and what is oldest proves most stable. Leonard's intact premorbid past is Ribot's law in its purest clinical form. The old persists; the new cannot form; and the self is organized around a boundary that can be crossed in only one direction.

In 1911 Édouard Claparède published "Recognition et moïité." A Korsakoff patient failed to recognize him from one day to the next. He concealed a pin in his hand and pricked her as they shook hands. The next day she refused his hand without being able to say why, and when pressed offered the general observation that people sometimes hide pins in their hands. Something had been learned, and nothing had been remembered. Korsakoff had already observed that his patients, though they retained little conscious recollection of recent events, could still be conditioned; and Claparède's patient forgot him so quickly that he had to introduce himself again after a quarter of an hour. What the patient lacked, Claparède argued, was not the trace but the *moïité*, the "me-ness" by which a memory is felt as one's own. The film's backstory is a Claparède experiment conducted by an insurance company. Leonard tested Sammy Jankis with electrified objects. On the logic of the claim, a genuinely amnesic patient should learn by conditioning, as Claparède's patient did; Sammy's failure to learn was therefore read as evidence that his condition was psychological, and the claim was denied. The plot of *Memento* turns on a twentieth-century bureaucracy applying the logic of a 1911 pinprick.

The modern taxonomy descends from the case of Henry Molaison, known for half a century as H.M., whose bilateral medial temporal resection for intractable epilepsy, performed by William Scoville on 1 September 1953, when Molaison was twenty-seven, left him profoundly amnesic. Scoville and Brenda Milner's report of 1957 established the hippocampal basis of declarative memory, and Milner's mirror-tracing studies demonstrated that H.M. improved at a motor task across days while denying that he had ever performed it. His intellect was otherwise spared, so that his amnesia was, as later reviews put it, pure, uncontaminated by other cognitive deficits; the case's methodological value lay in that purity, as it would for Boswell below, and as it does for Leonard. Suzanne Corkin, who studied him from 1962 until his death in 2008, titled her account of his life Permanent Present Tense (2013). Larry Squire later systematized the dissociation as a division between declarative memory (episodic and semantic) and nondeclarative memory (procedural skill, priming, classical conditioning). Leonard's repeated appeals to habit, routine, and conditioning are appeals to the nondeclarative system; his deficit lies wholly in the declarative.

Endel Tulving distinguished episodic from semantic memory in 1972 and in 1985 named the consciousness proper to episodic memory *autonoetic*: the capacity to re-experience oneself in the past and to project oneself into the future, a mental time travel in both directions. His patient K.C., who lost episodic memory after a motorcycle accident while retaining much semantic knowledge, described his own future,

when asked about it, as a blankness. Demis Hassabis and colleagues (2007) showed that hippocampal amnesics cannot construct coherent imagined experiences, and Daniel Schacter and Donna Rose Addis (2007) proposed that episodic memory exists chiefly to recombine past experience into simulations of the future. The consequence for Leonard is rarely remarked. He cannot pre-experience what he plans. His planning must therefore be externalized entirely, and his notes supply not only retention but protention. They do not merely record what happened; they prescribe what is to be done. Leonard's writing is anticipatory rather than archival. A note in his hand is less a memory than a prophecy addressed to the one who will fulfill it.

The nearest documentary counterpart to Leonard's system is the diary of the musician Clive Wearing, left amnesic by herpes simplex encephalitis in March 1985, with a span of retention measured in seconds and, unlike Leonard, a retrograde amnesia that erased most of his past. Page after page records, with a time of day, that the writer is now awake for the first time, while each earlier entry of the same kind has been struck through. Each new self repudiates the consciousness of its predecessors. The ethic is the inverse of Leonard's. Wearing's successive selves deny that their predecessors were ever awake; Leonard's successive selves never doubt that their predecessors were right. Wearing's diary is the record of a self that cannot believe it was conscious before; Leonard's notes are the record of a self that cannot believe it was ever mistaken.

Deborah Wearing's memoir, *Forever Today* (2005), adds the decisive counterpoint: her husband greeted her with undiminished joy at every reunion. Affective recognition survived the destruction of episodic memory. Oliver Sacks, who visited the couple twenty years after the illness, recorded two further details that bear on this study. One cannot know one's own amnesia directly, he observed, only infer it, from a faltering conversation, an emptied cup, or entries in one's own handwriting; Clive, instead of inferring, concluded each time that he had just woken from death. Leonard's entire system is that inference, made once and written down so that it never has to be made again. And when asked his full name, Clive once gave it with his wife's name set inside his own, puzzled that his parents had chosen it: the beloved inscribed into the name below the level of memory. Leonard carries his wife on his chest not as a name but as a sentence about her death.

Daniel Tranel and Antonio Damasio (1993) demonstrated the same dissociation experimentally. Their profoundly amnesic patient, Boswell, interacted repeatedly with a kindly "good guy," an unpleasant "bad guy," and a neutral figure; asked later whom he would approach for help, he chose reliably in line with his experiences while

retaining no declarative memory of them. Affective valence was learned covertly. Boswell's amnesia followed herpes simplex encephalitis, and his lesions took in the hippocampus, the amygdala, and the surrounding temporal cortices, so the study showed that this covert learning requires none of them; his span of retention has been reported at about forty-five seconds. The authors added a methodological point that bears directly on this dissertation: the demonstration was possible only in a patient like Boswell, because in anyone whose factual learning survives, fact memory contaminates the result. The film uses Leonard in the same way. Only in a subject who can form no new factual memories can the authority of the written record be observed in isolation, uncontaminated by recollection. Leonard is the film's Boswell, and the film is an experiment in pure inscription. The social world of *Memento* is built on the exploitation of exactly this gap. Natalie provokes Leonard into striking her, leaves, waits, and returns bruised to blame Dodd. She understands that the affective residue of violence will not be indexed to its cause, and that Leonard's inscriptions rather than his feelings will decide whom he blames. Her concealment of every pen in the house is the precise technical gesture of this understanding. She controls the interval between affect and inscription, and whoever controls that interval governs the man.

Sallie Baxendale's survey of amnesia in cinema in the *British Medical Journal* (2004) singled out *Memento* as an exception among films whose amnesiacs bear little relation to clinical reality: Leonard keeps his identity, has little retrograde amnesia, and shows the everyday difficulties of the syndrome, and she read the film's fragmented sequence as an image of the syndrome's perpetual present, suggesting that it drew in part on the case of H.M. The neuroscientist Christof Koch singled it out as the most faithful popular rendering of the brain's distinct memory systems, and Esther Sternberg, reviewing it in Science (2001), praised it as an almost flawless study of the neurobiology of memory. The accuracy matters here not as verisimilitude but as discipline: the film's philosophical claims are constrained by a neurologically coherent premise, and its thought experiments are therefore experiments rather than fantasies. The neuroscientist Larry Squire's warning that no two cases of amnesia are the same, and that amnesia cannot be written about as a single entity, governs the comparisons in this chapter: they are structural, not clinical.

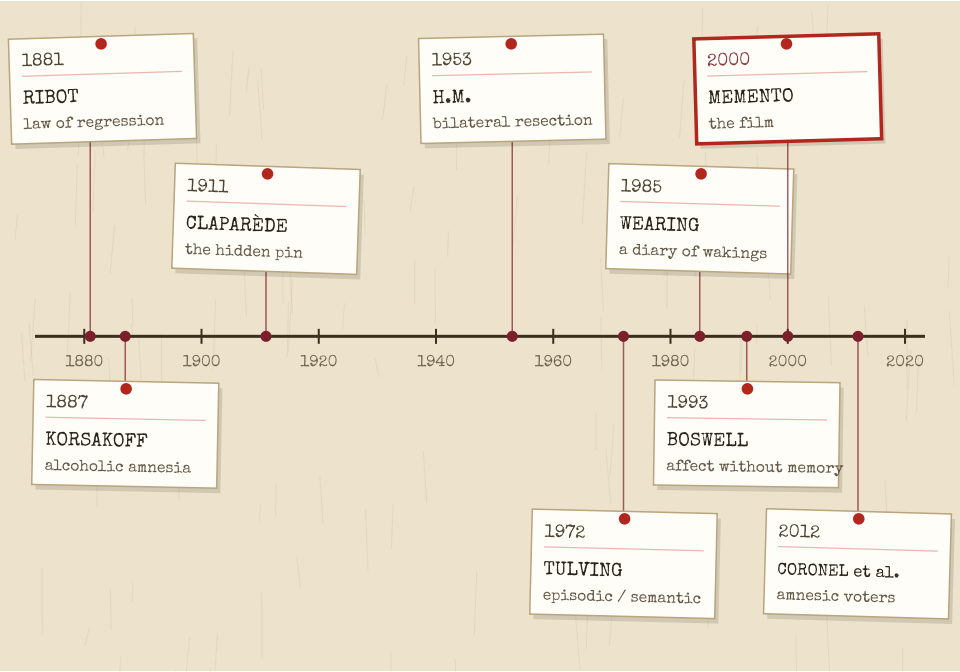


Figure 3. *A clinical genealogy of the anterograde condition, from Ribot's law of regression to the amnesic voters of 2012.*

2.2

The Insurance Metaphysics: Organic and Psychic

The adjudication of Sammy's claim turns on the distinction between a physical and a psychological condition. The film presents this as a technicality of policy wording. It is in fact one of the deepest fault lines in the modern sciences of the mind, and its origin is the insurance claim itself. Trauma, as a medical category, was forged in litigation over railway accidents. John Eric Erichsen's *On Railway and Other Injuries of the Nervous System* (1866) attributed post-accident symptoms to organic concussion of the spine; Herbert Page (1883) countered that many such cases were "nervous shock" without lesion; Charcot's school read such cases as traumatic hysteria; Hermann Oppenheim, who began describing the clinical picture in 1884, codified it as the traumatic neurosis in his monograph of 1889 and rejected the charge that its sufferers were merely compensation neurotics; and the railway companies denied that railway spine existed at all, ascribing claimants' symptoms to litigation.

The German liability law of 1871 had already multiplied claims for railway injuries, and the accident insurance law that took effect in July 1884 turned physicians into assessors (*Gutachter*) charged with deciding whether an accident was an adequate cause of an injury and what it should cost the insurer. A generation of disputes followed over what physicians called pension neurosis, in which the claimant's suffering was suspected of being motivated by the prospect of compensation; François Ewald, Michel Foucault's assistant at the Collège de France, would later show how the problem of industrial accidents moved responsibility from individual fault toward insured risk, and describe the society this produced as an insurantial society, one in which the assessment of fault became a profession. Ian Hacking, in *Rewriting the Soul* (1995), called the resulting complex of sciences *memoro-politics*: the transformation of memory into the field on which the soul is examined, adjudicated, and governed. Leonard, the claims investigator, stands at the genealogical origin of trauma theory, in the position of the insurer who suspects the claimant. His professional ancestor is the assessor created by the law of 1884. The film's backstory is a reenactment of the founding scene of the discipline.

Catherine Malabou, in *Les nouveaux blessés* (2007), argued that cerebral lesion produces a subjectivity that psychoanalysis cannot interpret: a "new wounded" marked by destructive plasticity, coldness, and indifference, whose accident has no meaning because it has no psychic history. Freudian trauma presupposes a continuous psyche that elaborates the wound; the brain-damaged subject, on her account, has been replaced rather than wounded. *Memento* stages the dispute between Malabou and Freud by superimposing organic lesion and psychic defense in a single subject so that neither can be isolated. The organic accident supplies the psychic defense with its instrument. Under H_1, Leonard is Sammy: his neurological condition is real, and his narrative use of it is a defense against guilt. Under H_2, the distinction holds as Leonard drew it. Under either hypothesis, the line he drew professionally is the line that now divides him, and no adjudicator remains who could rule on which side of it he stands.

2.3
Bergson: The Truncated Cone

In *Matter and Memory* (1896) Bergson distinguished two forms in which the past survives. Habit-memory consists of motor mechanisms, exemplified by a lesson learned by heart, which is acted rather than represented. Pure memory, or image-

memory, retains each reading of the lesson as a singular, dated, unrepeatable event. Bergson's diagram of the inverted cone places the totality of the past at its base and the present action at its apex, where the cone touches the plane of the actual. The life of the mind is a continual movement between base and apex, contraction toward action and dilation toward dream.

Leonard's cone is truncated. Its base is sealed at the injury. Its apex is sharpened to pure present action supported by habit. No new strata can be deposited between them, so that every movement of the mind toward its past passes directly from the present to the scene of the attack. After the injury, the past survives in Leonard only in the first of Bergson's two forms. He has become, in the precise sense, a creature of motor mechanisms with a frozen archive of images.

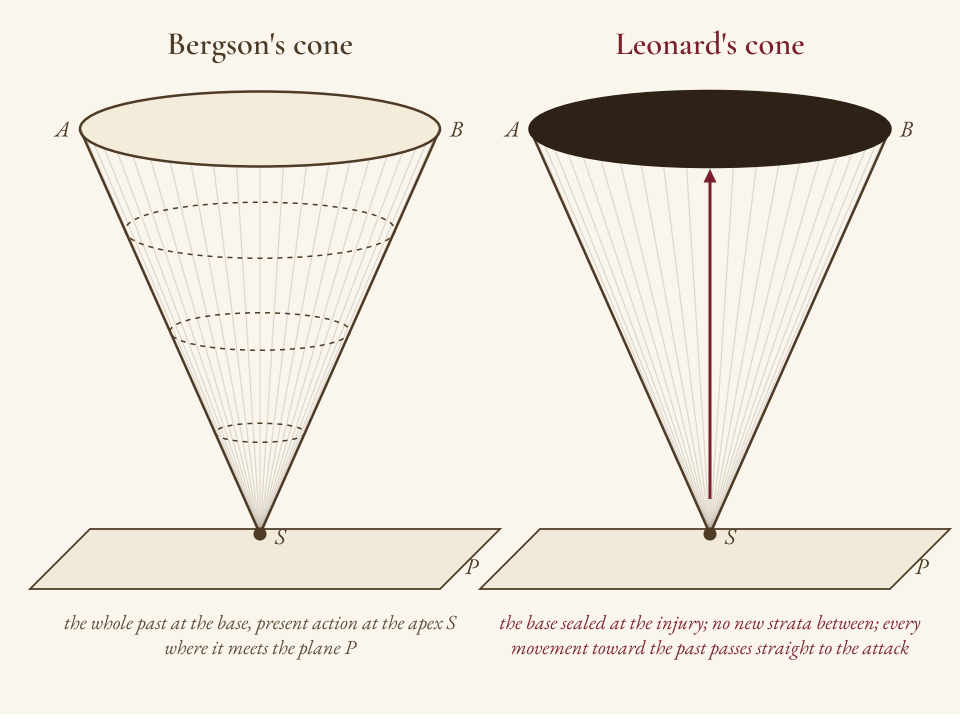


Figure 4. *Bergson's inverted cone of memory, and Leonard's: the base sealed at the injury, the apex sharpened to habit and present action, nothing deposited between.*

Creative Evolution (1907) adds a second diagnosis. The intellect, Bergson argued, takes snapshots of passing reality and strings them along an abstract becoming, as a cinematograph does; he called this the cinematographical mechanism of thought and held it responsible for our blindness to duration. After his injury Leonard's mind

becomes this mechanism literally. Polaroids are snapshots; the narrative written beneath them is the abstract becoming on which they are strung. He possesses instants without duration. Here the film turns Bergson against himself, as Deleuze would. Deleuze argued that cinema does not compose movement from immobile sections but gives the movement-image directly, and that modern cinema gives a direct image of time. *Memento* uses cinema to restore to the spectator the duration that its protagonist has lost, so that the cinematograph, which Bergson took as the emblem of the intellect's falsification of time, becomes the instrument of its recovery.

Bergson's emblem of this falsification was Zeno's arrow, which at every instant occupies a place equal to itself and is therefore at rest, so that its flight dissolves into a series of immobilities. The paradox arises, he argued, from mistaking the indivisible act of motion for the divisible line it traverses. Leonard's life is Zeno's arrow lived. In each interval he is at rest, without the momentum of memory, and yet he is carried to his target along a line his notes have already drawn. When Borges's detective, about to die, asks for a labyrinth consisting of a single straight line (8.1), he is asking for Zeno's labyrinth, which is also Leonard's.

Deleuze's *Difference and Repetition* (1968) supplies the most exact formula for Leonard's temporality. The first synthesis of time is habit, the contraction of instants into a living present. The second is memory, the pure past that Deleuze names Mnemosyne. The third is the empty form of time, which he figures with Hamlet's line that the time is out of joint: a caesura divides life into a before and an after, and the self is fractured by an act too large for it. Leonard retains the first synthesis intact. The second is sealed at the injury. He has been thrown wholly into the third, where the attack is the caesura, the vengeance is the act too large for the self, and the self that performs it is dissolved in the performing. He is Mnemosyne's son without her inheritance: hence the title of this chapter.

2.4
Husserl: Retention Without Sediment

Husserl's lectures on the phenomenology of internal time-consciousness (delivered from 1905, published in 1928 under Heidegger's editorship) analyze the living present into primal impression, retention, and protention, and distinguish all three from secondary memory, or recollection, which re-presents a past that has left the living present. Retention is the comet's tail of the just-elapsed, by virtue of which a melody is heard as a melody rather than as a sequence of isolated tones. Leonard's living

present is intact. He follows a sentence, a melody, a chase. What fails is the passage from retention into recollection: the retained sinks without residue once it leaves the specious interval.

Husserl's later genetic phenomenology explains why this matters for selfhood. In the *Cartesian Meditations* (§32) the ego is described as the substrate of habitualities: when I decide something, the decision remains mine afterward as an abiding conviction, and I am in part the sum of such sedimented positions. Leonard can acquire no new habituality of conviction except by inscription, so that every conviction he has formed since the attack must be read again before it can be held. In *The Origin of Geometry* (written 1936, published 1939), Husserl argued that writing allows ideal objects to persist beyond the lives of those who first grasped them, but that sedimented meaning can be received passively, without the reactivation of the originary evidence that once gave it sense. He warned against the seduction of language: the empty understanding of propositions whose grounds one cannot reconstitute. Leonard's notes are sedimented sense that cannot be reactivated. The evidence that produced the inscription on Teddy's photograph is irrecoverable to every reader of it. Leonard is the crisis of the European sciences compressed into one man: a technique severed from its originary evidence, which continues to produce results.

The chapter's first coinage follows. Husserl's *epochē* suspends the posits of the natural attitude so that the constitution of sense becomes visible. Leonard's injury performs an involuntary suspension of all sense sedimented after the attack, so that each scene is given as if for the first time, which is the ideal of phenomenological description. Call this the **traumatic epochē**. It yields no insight into constitution, only exposure to whoever controls the inscriptions that refill the bracketed world. The reduction suffered rather than performed is not philosophy but vulnerability. Eugen Fink's *Sixth Cartesian Meditation* (1932) named the subject of genuine phenomenological insight the "phenomenologizing onlooker," *der phänomenologisierende Zuschauer*. The word is exact. In *Memento* the transcendental onlooker who sees the constitution of Leonard's world is not Leonard but the *Zuschauer* in the theater.

2.5
Augustine: The Palace and the Psalm

The tenth book of the *Confessions* describes the fields and spacious palaces of memory (*campos et lata praetoria memoriae*, X.8.12) and then offers a stranger image: memory is, as it were, the stomach of the mind (*memoria quasi venter est animi*, X.14.21), and

joy and sadness are like sweet and bitter food, which, once passed into memory, can be stored but no longer tasted. Leonard is a man without a stomach of the mind. Experience is tasted and cannot be stored. The image anticipates Nietzsche's account of forgetting as psychic digestion, to which Chapter V returns.

Augustine then confronts the paradox of remembering forgetfulness (X.16.24–25). When I remember forgetfulness, both memory and forgetfulness are present: memory by which I remember, forgetfulness which I remember. But forgetfulness is the privation of memory; how can it be present to be remembered when its presence is precisely what makes me forget? Leonard's condition puts this paradox to work. He must know, at the outset of every interval, that he forgets; and he knows it by habit, by the tattoo on his hand, by the conditioned reflex of reading himself. The knowledge of one's own forgetting is the one item of post-injury knowledge his system cannot do without, and it is therefore the knowledge on which every manipulation of him depends.

In Book XI, Augustine locates time in the distension of the mind (*distentio animi*) across a threefold present: the present of past things, which is memory; the present of present things, which is attention; and the present of future things, which is expectation. Reciting a psalm, the mind's expectation passes through attention into memory until the whole has been transferred (XI.28.38). Leonard's soul cannot distend. It is contracted to attention, with memory of the recent abolished and expectation delegated to paper. The only psalm he can recite whole is the story of Sammy Jankis, told and retold to strangers, polished to the fluency of liturgy. Chapter VI argues that this is no accident: the one narrative Leonard can perform perfectly is the one that performs his innocence.

2.6

James: Warmth, Intimacy, Flywheel

William James, in *The Principles of Psychology* (1890), held that the present self appropriates past selves by the warmth and intimacy with which their thoughts are felt as one's own, and that the experienced present is no knife-edge but a saddle-back of some breadth. He also called habit the enormous fly-wheel of society, its most precious conservative agent. Leonard's notes are cold. They carry no warmth and no intimacy, and his doctrine of trusting facts rather than memories is a decision to prefer cold appropriation to warm. That is why he can adopt the instruction to kill as his own resolution without feeling it as his. Habit, meanwhile, is the flywheel that car-

ries him across the gaps between intervals: the momentum of routine, pockets checked, skin read, notes consulted. It is a flywheel spinning without an engine, and whoever sets it spinning determines where it will carry him. Clive Wearing found a different momentum. Deborah described music carrying him forward bar by bar, its structure holding him like rails that allowed only one direction, and Sacks concluded that Clive's continuity came not from recollection but from performance, holding only as long as the performance lasted. Leonard's rails are his notes, and his performance is a hunt.

2.7
Proust: The Whirling Room

The overture of *Swann's Way* (1913) describes a sleeper waking in darkness who cannot at first tell where, or even who, he is; rooms from different periods of his life whirl about him until the memory lodged in his body, in his sides, knees, and shoulders, reconstructs the walls from the posture of its fatigue. In C. K. Scott Moncrieff's translation, memory finally comes to the sleeper "like a rope let down from heaven," drawing him out of an abyss of not-being from which he could never have escaped alone. Deborah Wearing quoted the passage in Jonathan Miller's documentary about her husband, Prisoner of Consciousness (1986), and Sacks remarked that no such rope would ever come down to Clive. None comes down to Leonard either. He braids his own out of paper, and it is fastened to nothing above him. Leonard's motel awakenings repeat this overture without its consolation. Proust's narrator emerges from the whirl into the solid room of his past because involuntary memory eventually restores lost time, from the madeleine to the uneven paving stones of *Le Temps retrouvé*. Involuntary memory requires a stored episodic trace for the sensory cue to unlock, and Leonard has none for anything after the attack. Every madeleine he tastes opens onto the time before. For him involuntary memory is therefore an instrument not of recovery but of fixation: every sensory cue returns him to Catherine.

2.8
Merleau-Ponty: The Slackened Arc

The *Phenomenology of Perception* (1945) describes habit as knowledge in the hands and the blind man's cane as an instrument incorporated into the body schema, so that it ceases to be an object and becomes an extension of perception. Merleau-

Ponty's central case, Gelb and Goldstein's patient Schneider, wounded in the occipital region by shell fragments, could perform concrete movements, swatting a mosquito or grasping his nose, but not abstract ones, such as pointing to his nose on command. Merleau-Ponty's diagnosis is that the life of consciousness is subtended by an "intentional arc" that projects around us our past, our future, and our human setting, and that in illness this arc goes slack.

Leonard is Schneider in a noir. His concrete capacities are intact: he fights, drives, runs, and shoots with competence. What has gone slack is the arc that would situate those capacities within a world of reasons. Schneider compensated by explicit deliberation, reaching his nose by first locating his whole body; Leonard compensates by explicit reading, reaching his reasons by first consulting his skin. His notes have become his cane. Like the blind man's stick, they have ceased to be objects and become organs, extensions not of perception but of belief.

2.9

Damasio: Core and Autobiographical Self

Antonio Damasio's *The Feeling of What Happens* (1999) distinguishes a core self, transient and renewed from moment to moment, which survives even profound amnesia, from an autobiographical self, built on the reactivation of personal memory, which does not. Leonard's core self is intact; his autobiographical self is frozen at the injury and patched with text. The recurrent voice-over in which he orients himself to an unfamiliar room is the core self narrating its situation in the absence of the autobiographical self that would ordinarily supply it. It is, in a precise sense, a self reading itself aloud.

2.10

Reconstruction, Reconsolidation, and the Inscriptional Exemption

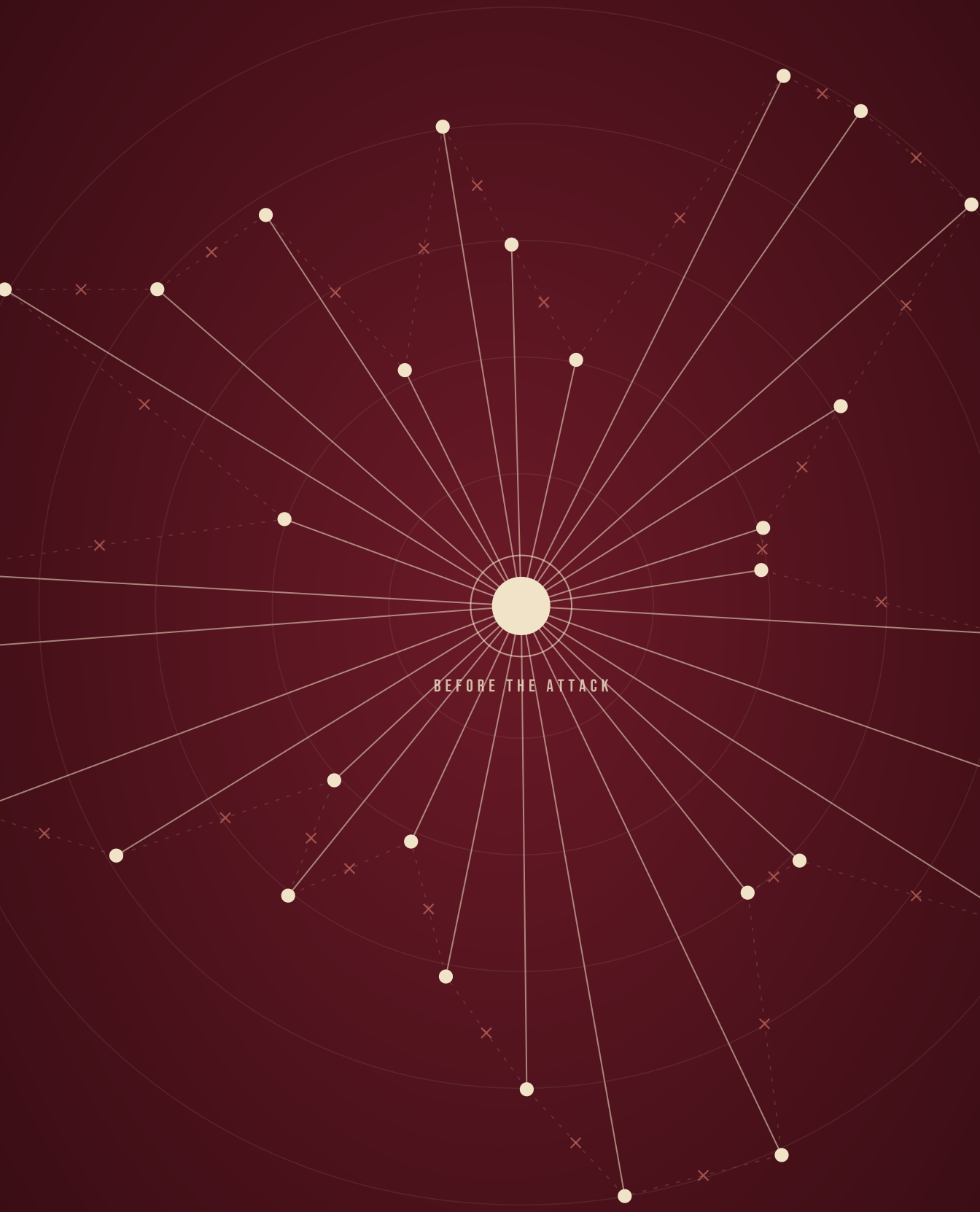
Frederic Bartlett's *Remembering* (1932) established that recall is reconstructive, an effort after meaning governed by schemata. Elizabeth Loftus demonstrated that post-event information alters memory and that entire false episodes can be implanted. Nader, Schafe, and LeDoux (2000) showed that retrieval returns consolidated memories to a labile state from which they must be reconsolidated. Leonard articulates, in one of the film's most frequently cited exchanges, a thoroughly Bartlettian

doctrine: memory can change the shape of a room or the color of a car; it is an interpretation rather than a record; and where one has facts, it is irrelevant.

As psychology this is sound. As epistemology it contains a fatal exemption. Leonard applies the reconstructive critique to memory and exempts writing from it. Yet a note is a memory externalized at a moment of interpretation. It inherits every bias of the instant of its writing and adds a further defect: it cannot be reconsolidated by later evidence, because its author cannot revisit it with new knowledge. Call this the **inscriptional exemption**: the belief that an inscription escapes the interpretive conditions of its production. Sacks drew the underlying contrast exactly: episodic memories are revised or recategorized each time they are recalled, whereas procedural memory must be literal, exact, and reproducible. Leonard's notes are an attempt to give facts the literalness of procedure, to make a proposition behave like a habit. The film refutes it visually. It shows memory reconsolidating before our eyes, in the flashes in which Leonard's playful pinch of Catherine's thigh becomes the press of an insulin needle, while the notes remain immobile. Reconsolidation is the mechanism by which living memory updates itself to new evidence. The fixity of the notes is therefore not reliability but obsolescence, and the inscriptional exemption is the founding error of hypomnesic sovereignty: the belief that the sovereign's written will is less interpretive than the subject's lived memory.

2.11
Synthesis

Leonard's condition is a system of dissociations: retention from sedimentation, habit from recollection, core self from autobiographical self, affect from its index, imagination from planning. Each dissociation opens a gap; each gap is filled by inscription; each inscription is a site at which power can be exercised, by Leonard over his successors or by others over all of them. The neuropsychology of the anterograde condition is therefore already a political anatomy, and the rest of this dissertation is an attempt to read it as one.


BEFORE THE ATTACK

CHAPTER

III

The Forensic Orphan

Personal Identity from Locke to Parfit and Beyond

3.1 Locke: Consciousness Extended Backwards 47
3.2 Butler's Circle and Leibniz's Testimony 49
3.3 Hume: The Labyrinth and the Commonwealth 50
3.4 Quasi-Memory and the Right Kind of Cause 51
3.5 Williams: The Self and the Future 52
3.6 Nozick: The Closest Continuer and the Experience Machine 52
3.7 Narrative Identity: Schechtman, Strawson, MacIntyre, Ricoeur 53
3.8 The Leonardine Circle 54
3.9 Spinoza's Spanish Poet 55
3.10 Anattā, the Lamp, and the Storehouse 57
3.11 Dennett: The Center of Narrative Gravity 57
3.12 Synthesis 58

3.1

Locke: Consciousness Extended Backwards

The chapter on identity that Locke added to the second edition of the *Essay* (1694) locates personal identity in consciousness: "as far as this consciousness can be extended backwards to any past action or thought, so far reaches the identity of that person" (II.xxvii.9). Its purpose is juridical. "Person," Locke writes, "is a forensic term, appropriating actions and their merit; and so belongs only to intelligent agents, capable of a law, and happiness and misery" (II.xxvii.26). To punish someone for an act of which he can never be made conscious would be, on Locke's account, all one as to make him miserable in his first being, without any demerit at all. Identity matters because responsibility requires an owner.

Locke tests the criterion against cases that *Memento* reassembles. He imagines "two distinct incommunicable consciousnesses acting the same body, the one con-

stantly by day, the other by night," and asks "whether the day- and the night-man would not be two as distinct persons as Socrates and Plato" (II.xxvii.23). Of waking and sleeping Socrates he says that to punish the one for what the other did would be no more right than to punish one twin for what his brother twin did, whereof he knew nothing, because their outsides were so alike that they could not be distinguished (II.xxvii.19). Leonard's successive selves are twins with a single outside. He then confronts the drunkard who is punished for what he did while drunk, though never afterwards conscious of it. Human laws, Locke answers, "punish both, with a justice suitable to their way of knowledge; because, in these cases, they cannot distinguish certainly what is real, what counterfeit." At the Great Day, however, "wherein the secrets of all hearts shall be laid open," no one shall be made to answer for what he knows nothing of (II.xxvii.22).

Apply the criterion to Leonard and a structure appears that the literature has not described. Each post-injury interval possesses consciousness that extends backwards to the premorbid past and to nothing in between. The topology of his identity is a star: a hub, Leonard before the attack, with spokes radiating to each interval, and no edges between the spokes. By Locke's criterion each interval is the same person as the hub. By the transitivity of identity, every interval is therefore the same person as every other. By Locke's criterion applied directly, no interval is the same person as any other, since none can extend its consciousness to its siblings. Thomas Reid's objection of the brave officer (1785) exposed the intransitivity of the memory criterion along a chain: the general remembers the officer, the officer the flogged boy, the general not the boy. Leonard's star exposes the same incoherence along a different graph. Reid's case is a chain that breaks at its ends; Leonard's is a wheel without a rim.

The forensic consequence is decisive. When the interval in which Jimmy Grantz is killed closes, no subsequent interval can extend its consciousness to the killing, and the hub cannot, since the hub precedes it. By the Lockean criterion, no existing person is then the same person as the killer. The act persists in the world, in a corpse, a stolen car, a borrowed suit; but it has no owner. Call such an act a **forensic orphan**: a deed that, under the memory criterion, belongs to no extant person once the interval of its performance has closed. Locke's solution to the drunkard (human courts punish because they cannot detect counterfeits) presupposes that the plea of ignorance might be feigned. Leonard's condition is not feigned. Locke states the premise outright in the same section: human courts justly punish the drunkard "because the fact is proved against him, but want of consciousness cannot be proved for him." In Leonard's case the want of consciousness can be proved; it is the one fact about him

that neurology certifies. The pragmatic justification for punishing him therefore collapses into the theological one: only on the Great Day, when consciousness is restored to all, could his acts be appropriated. The film supplies a substitute Great Day. Its reversed form endows the spectator with a consciousness that extends over every interval, and so constitutes, outside the diegesis, the only person to whom Leonard's acts can belong. Chapter IX names this **spectatorial personhood**.

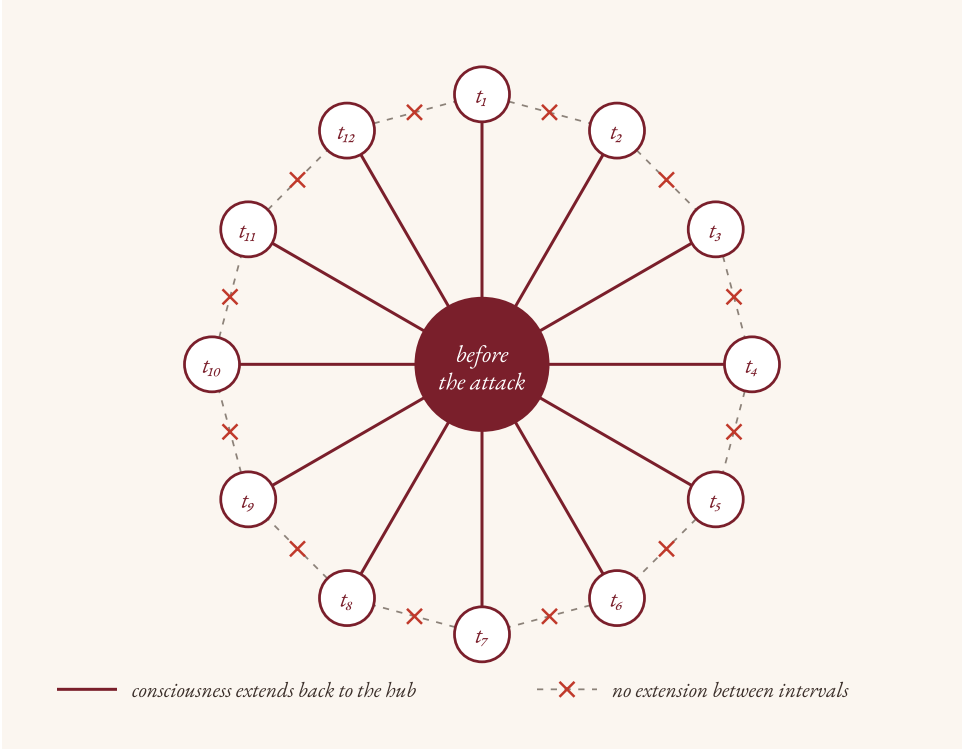


Figure 5. *The star topology of Leonard's Lockean identity. Each interval extends its consciousness back to the self before the attack; none extends to its siblings.*

3.2
Butler's Circle and Leibniz's Testimony

Joseph Butler, in the dissertation "Of Personal Identity" appended to *The Analogy of Religion* (1736), objected that "consciousness of personal identity presupposes, and therefore cannot constitute, personal identity, any more than knowledge, in any other case, can constitute truth, which it presupposes." The objection had first been raised by John Sergeant in 1697, three years after Locke's chapter appeared; Butler gave it its

classic form. Leonard's dependence on his notes enacts Butler's circularity as a practical predicament. He trusts a note because it is his; he knows it is his because its handwriting is his and because his system tells him to trust his handwriting. The circle that Butler found in a definition Leonard inhabits as a way of life (3.8).

Leibniz, answering Locke in the *New Essays* (written 1704, published 1765), held that real identity persists through total amnesia and that, for moral identity, the testimony of others can supply what memory lacks: a man who had forgotten his entire past could learn it from those around him and so recover his standing as the same moral person. *Memento* converts Leibniz's remedy into a hazard. Testimony repairs identity only if those who testify are benevolent. Teddy and Natalie are Leibnizian testifiers with motives of their own. The social repair of memory is also its social capture, and a self restored by others is a self owned in part by them.

3.3
Hume: The Labyrinth and the Commonwealth

Hume's *Treatise* (1739) begins its inquiry into personal identity with an act of introspection that fails: "when I enter most intimately into what I call myself, I always stumble on some particular perception or other ... I never can catch myself at any time without a perception, and never can observe any thing but the perception" (I.iv.6). When his perceptions are removed for any time, as by sound sleep, so long, he adds, is he insensible of himself, and "may truly be said not to exist." Each of Leonard's intervals ends in a nonexistence of exactly this kind. The self is a bundle of perceptions in perpetual flux; memory "does not so much produce as discover personal identity, by shewing us the relation of cause and effect among our different perceptions." Then comes the sentence on which this dissertation pivots. "I cannot compare the soul more properly to any thing than to a republic or commonwealth, in which the several members are united by the reciprocal ties of government and subordination, and give rise to other persons, who propagate the same republic in the incessant changes of its parts."

Hume already conceives identity as a polity sustained by government across the succession of its members. Leonard literalizes the analogy. His intervals are the members of the commonwealth; his notes and tattoos are the reciprocal ties of government and subordination; and the republic is propagated through the incessant change of its parts by a written constitution that no member remembers ratifying. In the Appendix of 1740 Hume confessed that he found himself "involv'd in such a

labyrinth" that he could neither correct his former opinions nor render them consistent, because he could discover no principle uniting the perceptions he had dissolved the self into. The two principles he could neither reconcile nor renounce were "that all our distinct perceptions are distinct existences, and that the mind never perceives any real connexion among distinct existences." Leonard's intervals are distinct existences in exactly this sense, and the only connexion among them is one he has written. His labyrinth has a principle of union, and it is his own handwriting.

Hume's theory of belief adds a further contrast. For Hume, what distinguishes memory from imagination, and belief from mere conception, is force and vivacity. Leonard's notes possess no vivacity whatsoever; they are faint marks on cheap paper. Yet they command more belief than his vivid memories, which he dismisses as interpretations. Leonard believes on authority rather than vivacity. Hume's psychology of belief is replaced by a jurisprudence of belief, in which assent is owed to a text because of who signed it.

3.4
Quasi-Memory and the Right Kind of Cause

Sydney Shoemaker's notion of quasi-memory (1970), a state like memory except that it does not presuppose that the rememberer is the person who had the remembered experience, was designed to escape Butler's circle. Derek Parfit's *Reasons and Persons* (1984) built on it a reductionist account in which what matters is Relation R: psychological connectedness, constituted by direct links such as memories, persisting beliefs and desires, and the link that holds when an intention is later carried out; and psychological continuity, the holding of overlapping chains of strong connectedness. Parfit distinguished three versions according to the causes permitted: the narrow version requires the normal cause; the wide version admits any reliable cause; the widest version admits any cause at all.

Leonard discriminates among these versions with the precision of a crucial experiment. Direct connectedness between his post-injury intervals is nearly nil, with one exception: an intention formed in one interval, written down, and carried out in another. This is a Parfitian connection mediated by paper. On the narrow version it does not count, since its cause is abnormal. On the wide version it counts only if the paper is reliable, and it is not, since the notes can be falsified by others and by Leonard himself. Only on the widest version, which admits any cause, does Leonard remain psychologically continuous; and the widest version would count a forged note as

identity-preserving. *Memento* is thus a reductio of the widest view: on it, Teddy could make himself a co-author of Leonard's identity by writing a sentence on the back of a photograph.

Parfit concluded that identity is not what matters. Leonard suggests that neither is R. What holds his intervals together is not memory, nor connectedness, nor narrative, but the persistence of an end. Call this **teleological continuity**: a self held together by a final cause, in Aristotle's sense, rather than by any efficient chain of psychological states. The self becomes a vector rather than a substance or a story. Parfit reported that, once he became a reductionist, the walls of the glass tunnel in which he had seemed to live disappeared and he lived in the open air. Leonard lives in the open air of disconnection and builds himself a tunnel out of ink.

3.5
Williams: The Self and the Future

Bernard Williams's "The Self and the Future" (1970) asks the reader to imagine being told that tomorrow she will be tortured, but that before the torture her memories will be erased and replaced. Williams observes that she will still fear, and concludes that memory is not what makes the future sufferer *her*. Leonard reverses the roles of the experiment. His present self cares about his future self, writes for him, arms him, protects him; but at the decisive moment he also prepares a fate for him, erasing the knowledge that would alter it and supplying a script in its place. Leonard is not the subject of Williams's experiment but its experimenter, and his successor is the subject. Self-paternalism has become self-despotism. Butler had drawn the consequence long before: if the self of today and that of tomorrow are "not the same, but only like persons, the Person of to Day is really no more interested in what will befall the Person of to morrow, than in what will befall any other person." Butler offered this as a reductio of Locke. Leonard lives it, treating his successor at the junction with a stranger's indifference and a sovereign's authority.

3.6
Nozick: The Closest Continuer and the Experience Machine

Robert Nozick's closest-continuer theory (*Philosophical Explanations*, 1981) holds that a later being is the same as an earlier one if it is, among sufficiently close candid-

ates, the closest continuer, with no tie. For Leonard, the closest continuer of each interval is the next interval that reads its notes. But at the junction of the film, Leonard determines what that continuer will read. His successor is designed by his predecessor. Identity becomes succession planning, and the closest continuer is a successor appointed by the incumbent.

Nozick's experience machine (*Anarchy, State, and Utopia*, 1974) argued that we would not plug ourselves into a device supplying any desired experience, because we want to do things and to be certain persons, not merely to have the experience of doing and being. Leonard articulates this anti-hedonist position with unusual force. Told that he will never know whether he has succeeded, he answers, in substance, that his wife deserves vengeance whether or not he knows of it, and that the world does not vanish when his eyes are closed. Yet his life is an experience machine of his own design. By controlling the inscriptions that become his inputs, he curates for his successors the experience of pursuit. Leonard is at once the experience machine's most eloquent critic and its most ingenious engineer. Chapter VI argues that this is the definitive form of his bad faith.

3.7

Narrative Identity: Schechtman, Strawson, MacIntyre, Ricoeur

Marya Schechtman's narrative self-constitution view (*The Constitution of Selves*, 1996) holds that a person constitutes herself through a self-narrative subject to two constraints: an articulation constraint, requiring that she be able to articulate her narrative locally when called upon, and a reality constraint, requiring that it cohere with the basic facts as others would recognize them. Leonard satisfies the articulation constraint hyperbolically. He narrates himself compulsively, to clerks, bartenders, and strangers on the telephone. He violates the reality constraint systematically, and at the junction of the film he does so by policy. He thereby demonstrates that the two constraints are independent: maximal articulation is compatible with minimal reality. He demonstrates something further. The view presupposes good faith in the narrator. Leonard shows that narrative self-constitution can be a fraud perpetrated by the narrator on himself, and that its articulateness can be the very instrument of the fraud.

Galen Strawson's "Against Narrativity" (2004) distinguishes Episodic from Diachronic self-experience and rejects both the descriptive thesis that human beings experience their lives as narratives and the normative thesis that they should. Leonard

is Episodic by injury and Diachronic by ideology. He cannot experience himself as extending across intervals, yet his whole existence is organized by a diachronic project. He refutes Strawson's opponents, since his life is not experienced as a narrative, and he troubles Strawson, since he shows that a forcibly Episodic subject can sustain a Diachronic project by externalizing narrative into a medium. That medium is precisely what makes him governable.

Alasdair MacIntyre's *After Virtue* (1981) conceives the unity of a human life as the unity of a narrative quest, whose telos is partly discovered in the questing, and holds that I can answer the question of what I am to do only if I can answer the prior question of which stories I am part of. Leonard's life is a MacIntyrean quest deformed. Its telos is fixed rather than discovered, and when attained it is erased, so that the quest must be reinstituted. It is a quest that cannot end because it cannot know that it has ended.

Paul Ricoeur, in *Oneself as Another* (1990), distinguished *idem*-identity, sameness of character and continuity across time, from *ipse*-identity, selfhood as self-constancy, whose paradigm is keeping one's word: whatever changes in my desires or opinions, I will hold firm. Narrative identity, on his account, mediates between the two. Leonard has lost narrative mediation and the *idem* continuity of memory, yet exhibits *ipse* in its purest form: constancy to a vow. The tattoo is a promise that keeps itself, a promise without a promiser, because the one who promised is gone and the promise survives him, written into his body. Hannah Arendt (*The Human Condition*, 1958) assigned to promising the remedy for the unpredictability of action and to forgiving the remedy for its irreversibility. Leonard can still promise, by tattoo. Chapter V shows that he can no longer forgive.

3.8
The Leonardine Circle

In the Second Meditation, Descartes secures the existence of the thinking self and immediately limits it: I am, I exist; but for how long? For as long as I am thinking, since if I ceased entirely to think, I might at once cease entirely to be. The Cartesian ego is an ego of the instant. The Third Meditation adds that the parts of time are mutually independent, so that from my having existed a moment ago it does not follow that I exist now unless some cause recreates me; conservation is continuous creation. The Fifth Meditation concedes that, without knowledge of God, I might doubt a conclusion I remember having demonstrated once I no longer attend to the

demonstration; God guarantees the reliability of remembered proof. Antoine Arnauld's objection is famous: we are certain of God's existence only because we clearly and distinctly perceive it, and certain of what we clearly and distinctly perceive only because God exists.

Leonard's notes perform the two Cartesian functions of God. They recreate him at the start of every interval, and they guarantee the conclusions of demonstrations he can no longer remember performing. But the guarantor is the guaranteed. He trusts the note because it is written in his hand and according to his system; he trusts his hand and his system because the notes and the tattoos tell him what his system is and that it may be trusted. Call this the **Leonardine Circle**: a closed epistemic loop in which inscription certifies author and author certifies inscription, with no point of verification outside the loop. It is Arnauld's circle secularized, and its consequence is the same: whoever can write in Leonard's hand, or persuade Leonard to write, occupies the place of God.

Bertrand Russell, in *The Analysis of Mind* (1921), observed that "there is no logical impossibility in the hypothesis that the world sprang into being five minutes ago, exactly as it then was, with a population that 'remembered' a wholly unreal past." Russell's point was that memory-beliefs are logically independent of the past they concern. Leonard lives inside Russell's hypothesis as a practical condition. At the opening of each interval his world springs into being furnished with documents that remember a past he must take on trust. What for Russell was a skeptical possibility is for Leonard a daily administrative fact.

3.9

Spinoza's Spanish Poet

In the scholium to Proposition 39 of Part IV of the *Ethics* (1677), Spinoza argues that nothing compels us to hold that a body dies only when it is changed into a corpse, since experience seems to show the contrary. A man can undergo such changes that he can hardly be called the same. Spinoza has heard of a Spanish poet who fell ill and, though he recovered, remained so oblivious of his past life that he did not believe the tales and tragedies he had written were his own; he might have been taken for a grown infant had he forgotten his native tongue as well. For Spinoza, then, death need not wait for a corpse. Each closing interval in Leonard's life is a Spinozist death without a corpse.



Figure 6. *The Leonardine Circle: inscription certifies author and author certifies inscription, with no point of verification outside the loop.*

The poet is also Leonard's inverse. Spinoza's amnesiac disowns his own writings. Leonard, equally unable to remember writing, owns his absolutely. The poet shows that the natural response of an amnesiac to his own texts is estrangement. Leonard's system is a technique for suppressing that estrangement: the trained habit of trusting his handwriting is an artificial *moïité*, Claparède's lost sense of ownership grafted onto paper.

Spinoza also supplies the counter-motto to the story's title. A free man, he writes, thinks of nothing less than of death, and his wisdom is a meditation not on death but on life (IV P67). In the preceding scholium he calls the man led only by affect and opinion a slave, and the man led by reason free. *Memento mori* is, in Spinoza's terms, the motto of servitude, and Leonard, whose whole life is organized around the remembrance of a death, is its realization: a man governed by an affect whose cause he cannot know (5.8).

3.10

Anattā, the Lamp, and the Storehouse

Buddhist philosophy approaches Leonard's case from the side of the doctrine of no-self (*anattā*). In the *Milindapañha*, the monk Nāgasena tells King Milinda that "Nāgasena" is a designation for a collection of parts, as "chariot" designates axle, wheels, and pole, with no chariot over and above them. Asked whether the one reborn is the same as the one who died, he answers with the image of a lamp burning through the night: the flame of the last watch is neither the same as the flame of the first nor another (*na ca so na ca añño*). Leonard's intervals are neither the same nor another. They are a living demonstration of Nāgasena's formula.

The doctrine of karma without a transmigrating self finds in Leonard a precise analogue. Actions bear fruit for successors who do not remember performing them: a corpse in a building, blood on a shirt, a stranger's car. The Yogācāra masters Asaṅga and Vasubandhu posited a storehouse consciousness (*ālaya-vijñāna*) in which the seeds (*bīja*) of karmic impressions (*vāsanā*) are deposited to ripen later. Leonard's skin and paper constitute an externalized storehouse: seeds planted in one interval ripen as acts in another.

One further point corrects a modern misreading. The Pali *sati*, conventionally rendered "mindfulness," derives from the root *smṛ*, "to remember"; in early usage it denotes keeping in mind, the retention of an object and of the teaching. Contemporary ideologies of the present moment sometimes treat mindfulness as attention without memory. Leonard is the reductio of that error. He is pure present attention without *smṛti*, and he is not liberated but enslaved. The canonical account of the Buddha's awakening begins, in the first watch of the night, with the recollection of former lives. In the Buddhist narrative, awakening begins in total memory. In Leonard's, every awakening begins in total amnesia.

3.11

Dennett: The Center of Narrative Gravity

Daniel Dennett (1992) proposed that the self is a center of narrative gravity: an abstraction, like a physical center of gravity, posited to organize a body's narrative productions, which human beings spin as spiders spin webs, without conscious design. Leonard's center of narrative gravity lies outside his body, in the notes and the

skin, as the center of gravity of a ring lies in empty space. Dennett's earlier thought experiment "Where Am I?" (1978), in which a brain in a Houston vat remotely operates a body in Oklahoma, asks where the self is located. The final words of *Memento*, Leonard's question as he resumes his drive, pun on Dennett's question. To ask where one was asks at once after a location and after a place in a text. The Conclusion argues that the self, for Leonard, is located exactly where reading resumes.

3.12
Synthesis

Leonard falsifies every memory-based criterion of personal identity while satisfying a teleological one. In doing so he converts the problem of personal identity from a metaphysical question into a juridical and political one. The tradition from Locke to Parfit asks what relation makes a later self the same as an earlier. *Memento* asks who governs the succession of selves, by what instrument, and with what title. The forensic person has become a constitutional question, and the next chapter examines the instruments of its constitution.



OBEY WHAT YOU CANNOT REMEMBER WRITING

CHAPTER

IV

Pharmakon, Hypomnema, Prosthesis

The Technics and Semiotics of the Inscribed Self

4.1 Theuth and Thamus 61
4.2 Hypomnemata and the Technologies of the Self 63
4.3 The Mystic Writing-Pad 64
4.4 Testament, Tertiary Retention, Proletarianization 64
4.5 The Extended Mind and the Invaded Mind 65
4.6 The Photograph and the Caption 67
4.7 The Semantics of "John G." 69
4.8 The Tattooed Body 70
4.9 The Lethean Constitution 73

4.1 Theuth and Thamus

In the myth Socrates recounts near the close of the *Phaedrus* (274c–277a), the Egyptian god Theuth presents his inventions to King Thamus and commends letters above all as a drug (*pharmakon*) for memory and wisdom. Thamus refuses the gift. Writing, he predicts, will implant forgetfulness in the souls of those who learn it, through neglect of memory; trusting to writing, they will be reminded from outside, by alien marks, and not from within, by themselves. Theuth has found a drug not of memory (*mnēmē*) but of reminding (*hypomnēsis*), and he offers his pupils the semblance of wisdom rather than its truth (275a–b). Socrates adds two complaints. Written words resemble painted figures: they seem alive, but if questioned they keep a solemn silence, and they always signify one and the same thing. And once written, a discourse drifts everywhere, among those who understand it and those who have no business with it; it does not know to whom it should speak; and

when it is ill-treated it always needs its father to help it, being unable to defend itself (275d–e).

Leonard's condition fulfills Thamus's prophecy to the letter. He is reminded entirely from outside, by marks that have become alien because he cannot remember making them. His notes are orphans in Socrates' precise sense. Questioned, they repeat what they were written to say; and their father cannot come to their aid, because their father does not remember fathering them. The Polaroid of Teddy, interrogated by whichever interval holds it (who is this man, and why must he die?), keeps a solemn silence and returns the same answer at every reading. The Platonic critique of writing, usually treated as a venerable archaism, is in *Memento* a clinical description.

Derrida's "La pharmacie de Platon" (1968) showed that *pharmakon* in Plato's text is undecidable between remedy and poison, and that the chain of signification in which it is embedded binds it to *pharmakos*, the scapegoat expelled from Athens during the Thargelia to purify the city, although Plato never writes that word. The *Memento* ensemble reconstitutes the entire chain. Leonard's notes are *pharmaka*: remedy against amnesia and poison of manipulation on a single sheet. His John Gs are *pharmakoi*: surrogate victims expelled from his world to purify it of a guilt it cannot name. Pharmacy and sacrifice are one operation, which Chapter V analyzes under Girard's name.

Greek tradition did not speak with one voice. In *Prometheus Bound*, the Titan lists among his gifts to mortals the combining of letters, "memory of all things, the Muses' mother, maker of crafts" (460–461). Where Thamus calls writing the ruin of memory, Prometheus calls it memory itself. Liddell, Scott and Jones gloss his compound μουσομήτωρ, "mother of Muses and all arts," as an epithet of Memory: Aeschylus gives the alphabet the title of Mnemosyne. Later, about to map Io's future wanderings, Prometheus bids her inscribe them on the remembering tablets of her mind (ἐγγράφου σὺ μνήμοσιν δέλτοις φρενῶν, 789), an image Hamlet's table of memory will echo; and when the Chorus asks who steers Necessity, he answers: the three-shaped Fates and the mindful Furies (516). In the Erinyes, memory is the helmsman of fate, and the wanderer receives her route as an inscription, as Leonard does. Leonard lives the contradiction: his letters are at once the memory of all things and the instrument of forgetting. The Promethean myth contributes a second figure. For his gifts, the Titan is chained to a rock where an eagle devours his liver by day and it regrows by night, so that the wound is new every morning. Leonard's grief is Promethean in exactly this sense. His lament that he cannot heal because he cannot feel

time pass describes a wound renewed at every interval. In the myth the giver of letters and the bearer of the perpetually fresh wound are the same figure. So they are in the film.

4.2
Hypomnemata and the Technologies of the Self

In "L'écriture de soi" (1983), Michel Foucault reconstructed the Greco-Roman practice of *hypomnemata*: notebooks in which one recorded quotations, examples, maxims, and reflections, to be reread and meditated upon so that they might become a material memory of things read, heard, or thought, an equipment (*paraskeuē*) ready to hand when needed. Their purpose, Foucault insisted, was not to reveal a hidden interiority, as Christian confession would later demand, but to capture the already-said and make it constitutive of the self. One became what one chose to collect and reread.

Leonard's notes are *hypomnemata* inverted. They do not collect the wisdom of others; they record the decisions of a self he cannot remember being. They are reread not to form a character capable of freedom but to supply an executive capable of a single task. Foucault stressed that the unity of the *hypomnemata* lay in the writer's selection rather than in narrative continuity, and Leonard's notes are likewise disparate, unified only by the purpose of the hunt. They are a technology of the self that produces not a self but an instrument.

Marcus Aurelius's notebook, transmitted under the title *Ta eis heauton*, "To Himself," is the canonical hypomnema: reminders addressed by a man to himself, often in the second person and in the imperative, for use in moments of weakness. Among them: soon you will have forgotten all things, and soon all things will have forgotten you (VII.21). The Stoic consolation is Leonard's clinical condition. What the emperor wrote to prepare himself for death, Leonard undergoes every few minutes; what was for Marcus a meditation is for Leonard a diagnosis.

Epictetus's teachings were compiled by Arrian as the *Enchiridion*, a word naming what is held in the hand: a handbook, and also a hand-knife or dagger. The inscription on the back of Leonard's hand is an enchiridion in both senses. It is a handbook, an injunction to remember Sammy Jankis, the case that explains his condition and, under H_1, the screen that conceals his guilt (6.4); and it is a weapon, borne on the hand that strangles Jimmy, holds the gun that kills Teddy, and, under hypothesis H_1, held the syringe. Leonard's memory is literally in his hand, and it is a blade.

4.3
The Mystic Writing-Pad

Freud's "Notiz über den 'Wunderblock'" (1925) begins from the problem of memory aids. A sheet of paper retains its marks permanently but is soon filled; a slate can be wiped and reused indefinitely but retains nothing. The psychic apparatus combines unlimited receptivity with permanent traces, and Freud explains the combination by dividing the labor between two systems: perception-consciousness, which receives stimuli but retains no trace of them, and the mnemic systems behind it, in which lasting traces are laid down. The children's toy called the Mystic Writing-Pad models the arrangement. A slab of dark wax is covered by a sheet of waxed paper and a protective sheet of celluloid. A stylus pressed on the celluloid brings the paper into contact with the wax and the writing appears; lifting the covering sheets erases it, but the trace persists in the wax, legible in suitable light. The intermittent appearance and disappearance of the writing figures, for Freud, the periodic flickering of consciousness.

Leonard's apparatus is a Mystic Writing-Pad whose wax has ceased to take impressions. Celluloid and paper function; marks appear and vanish; but every lifting of the sheet, at the close of each interval, erases without residue. His notes are a substitute slab of wax, placed outside him, legible in any light, and legible to anyone. Freud ends by imagining one hand writing on the surface while another periodically raises the covering sheet from the wax, and proposes this as a picture of the mind. In *Memento*, at the decisive moment, the second hand belongs to someone else. Derrida's "Freud et la scène de l'écriture" (1966) argued that Freud's metaphors of writing are not metaphors: the psyche is already a writing machine, and memory is already inscription. Leonard is that thesis externalized, a psyche whose writing has been moved from the skull onto the skin and thereby exposed to every reader.

4.4
Testament, Tertiary Retention, Proletarianization

In his introduction to Husserl's *Origin of Geometry* (1962), Derrida drew a consequence that Husserl had not. If writing is what allows meaning to persist beyond its living producers, then the capacity to function in the absence of the author, including after the author's death, belongs to the essence of the written sign. Every inscription is structurally testamentary. Leonard's notes realize this structure with unusual

purity, since they function only after their author has, in Spinoza's sense (3.9), died. Each note is a will, executed by an heir who does not remember the testator and cannot contest the bequest. The successor inherits not property but obligation, and the estate is a hunt.

Bernard Stiegler extended Husserl's analysis of retention. Primary retention holds the just-past in the living present; secondary retention is recollection; tertiary retention is memory externalized into technical objects, from tools and writing to the phonograph and film. Human beings, on his account, are *epiphylogenetic*: their memory accumulates in technics beyond the individual organism and beyond the genome. Stiegler adopted Derrida's term to speak of a *pharmacology* of technics, every technical support of memory being both remedy and poison. His concept of *proletarianization* names what happens when knowledge passes from persons into apparatuses, as the artisan's skill passed into the machine-tool and left the worker without know-how. Leonard is a proletarian of memory. His knowledge of how to live has passed into his notes; he no longer knows how to live, only how to read his instructions; and, like the proletarian, he does not own the means of his own reproduction, which others can seize.

4.5
The Extended Mind and the Invaded Mind

Andy Clark and David Chalmers's "The Extended Mind" (1998) contrasts Inga, who recalls a museum's address from biological memory, with Otto, who has Alzheimer's disease and consults the address he wrote in a notebook. Their parity principle holds that if a part of the world functions as a process which, were it performed in the head, we would without hesitation recognize as cognitive, then that part of the world belongs to the cognitive process. They proposed conditions for such extension: the resource must be reliably available and typically invoked; information retrieved from it must be more or less automatically endorsed; it must be easily accessible; and, more tentatively, it should have been consciously endorsed at some point in the past. Leonard's system satisfies all four, the last only formally, since the past endorsement was made by a self he cannot recall.

Memento discloses a condition that Clark and Chalmers did not list, and its absence is fatal. Otto's notebook is safe because no one writes in it but Otto. Leonard's world is crowded with writers. The parity principle cuts both ways: if the notebook is part of the mind, then whoever writes in the notebook writes in the

mind. The trust condition that licenses the extension, automatic endorsement, is precisely what makes the extension exploitable. Natalie's removal of every pen is the excision of a cognitive organ. Teddy's warnings about Natalie, the clerk's sale of a second room to a guest who will not remember the first, and Natalie's lookup of a license plate are all interventions in the external portion of Leonard's mind. Call the resulting structure the **invaded mind**: an extended mind whose external components are writable by others. The case establishes that cognitive extension presupposes a further condition, which may be called **authorial closure**: the agent's exclusive power to write to the extended resource. Without it, extension is invasion. Chapter IX argues that the missing condition defines the predicament of the networked subject.

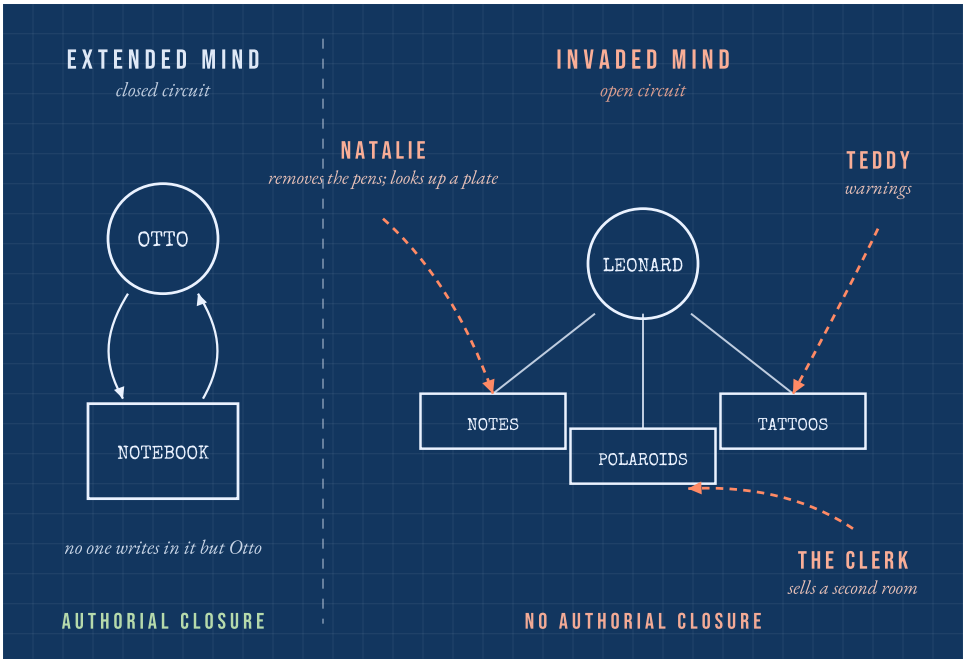


Figure 7. *The extended mind and the invaded mind. Otto's notebook is safe because no one writes in it but Otto; Leonard's world is crowded with writers.*

Daniel Wegner's theory of transactive memory (1987) observed that couples distribute remembering between them, each partner knowing what the other knows and where to find it, so that the death of a spouse destroys half of the survivor's memory system. Leonard has lost not only his wife but the partner of his transactive memory. His new partners, Teddy, Natalie, the clerk, know what he cannot and exploit the asymmetry. At the level of cognitive architecture, the tragedy of *Memento* is the replacement of a conjugal transactive memory by a predatory one.

4.6
The Photograph and the Caption

Charles Sanders Peirce classified signs by their relation to their objects: icons signify by resemblance, indices by physical connection, symbols by convention. A photograph is index and icon at once, caused by the light its object reflected and resembling what it records. Leonard's Polaroids belong to a technology whose temporal property is decisive. Edwin Land's instant process, demonstrated in 1947 and marketed the following year, delivers a print within minutes, that is, within the span of Leonard's retention. He can annotate an image while he still knows what it shows. A conventional photograph, developed days later, would return to him as the face of a stranger. The instant camera is the technology of the anterograde: it brings the production of evidence inside the window in which evidence can still be labeled.

Roland Barthes, in *La Chambre claire* (1980), named the *noeme* of photography: that-has-been. The photograph certifies that its referent stood before the lens; it certifies nothing about who the referent is or what he did. Barthes wrote the book in mourning for his mother, around a photograph of her as a child that he declined to reproduce. Leonard too mourns through photographs, but his are of the living, taken to mark them for death. Susan Sontag's observation that photographs are *memento mori* here becomes operational.

Wittgenstein's *Tractatus* (1921) supplies the logic of Leonard's system and its defect. A picture is a model of reality that agrees or fails to agree with it, and "in order to discover whether the picture is true or false we must compare it with reality" (2.223). "It cannot be discovered from the picture alone whether it is true or false" (2.224), and "there is no picture which is a priori true" (2.225). The Polaroid is a picture in this sense: this man stood here. It can be compared with reality, and Leonard compares it constantly, matching faces to faces. The caption beneath it is a different kind of sign. "Don't believe his lies," "he is the one," "kill him": these are not pictures but imperatives and moral predicates, which no comparison with reality can verify. Leonard's system uses the verifiable picture as the vehicle of the unverifiable proposition; the face authenticates the sentence attached to it. Call this **indexical laundering**: the transfer of an index's credibility to a proposition physically attached to it. Nolan reported its effect on audiences, who went on trusting the captioned image over Teddy's testimony even after the film had discredited Leonard's records (0.4). The laundering works on the spectator as it works on Leonard.

Two neighboring propositions sharpen the point. In Ogden's rendering, the picture represents its object from without, its standpoint being its form of representation, and "the picture cannot place itself outside of its form of representation" (2.173–2.174). A Polaroid's standpoint, who took it, when, and to what end, is exactly what Leonard's amnesia removes. He holds pictures whose standpoint he once occupied and can no longer reconstruct, so the caption must stand in for the standpoint, and the caption was written by a self he cannot question.

Emmanuel Levinas, in *Totalité et infini* (1961), located the origin of ethics in the face of the other, whose exposure and vulnerability signify, before any word is spoken, the prohibition of murder, and he distinguished the face from the plastic image to which representation reduces it. Leonard's system is a machine for converting faces into images. The Polaroid preserves the likeness as a plastic form, identifiable and comparable; the caption replaces the face's own address, the prohibition of killing, with a command to kill. Each photograph is a defacement in the strict sense: it removes the face while preserving the features, so that Leonard can recognize a man without being addressed by him. Before he kills Teddy, Leonard consults the photograph and its caption rather than the man in front of him.

The later Wittgenstein completes the diagnosis. In the *Philosophical Investigations* (§258), a diarist who records a private sensation under the sign "S" has no criterion of correctness, since whatever will seem right to him is right, which means that here one cannot speak of right at all. In §265, checking a remembered timetable against an imagined one is likened to buying several copies of the same morning paper to assure oneself that what it says is true. Leonard's verification procedure is the purchase of further copies of the same paper. Note is checked against note, and fact against a tattoo written on the authority of that same fact. When an external check is finally supplied, as when Natalie runs the license plate, it is supplied by an interested party. Every external check in *Memento* is someone else's copy of the paper.

Wittgenstein's last notes, published as *Über Gewißheit* (1969), add that doubt itself presupposes propositions that stand fast: hinges on which our questions turn and which are not themselves put to the test. Leonard's hinges are his name, his wife, and his injury. Everything after the injury must turn on them, and a sentence attached to them, as the license plate is attached to the facts on his thigh, stands fast with them.

4.7
The Semantics of "John G."

The list of facts on Leonard's thigh is a definite description in Russell's sense: male, white, first name John or James, surname beginning with G, a drug dealer, and eventually a license plate. On the theory of descriptions (1905), a sentence of the form "the F is G" is true only if exactly one thing is F. Leonard's description fails the uniqueness condition by construction. Its first name is a disjunction and its surname an initial, and it is satisfied by Jimmy Grantz, by John Edward Gammell, and, as the junction scene makes explicit, by a great many others. Every sentence containing "John G." on which Leonard acts is, by Russell's analysis, false for want of a unique satisfier.

The chest inscription supplies the description's predicate, and under H_1 it fails more radically still. "The man who raped and murdered my wife" is a conjunctive description: the *x* such that *x* raped her and *x* killed her. Under H_1 nothing satisfies both conjuncts. The rape, which Teddy does not dispute, was the intruders' act; the killing, by insulin, was Leonard's. The description is improper not by an excess of satisfiers but by their absence, and of its two conjuncts one describes the assailant and the other describes Leonard. The inscription is the grammatical site of the projection analyzed in 6.4: it welds an act Leonard suffered to an act he committed, so that the true conjunct lends its credibility to the false one. Call this **conjunctive laundering**, the propositional twin of the indexical laundering of 4.6. Under H_2 the description fails differently but no less. By Leonard's own account the man he shot on the night was the one who raped and strangled Catherine, yet the inscription charges both acts to the man who escaped; unless both men did both things, which the film never shows, it accuses John G. of acts its own author attributes to someone else. The inscription is unsatisfied under either hypothesis: under H_1 because no one did both things, under H_2 because the man who did them died on the night of the attack.

Saul Kripke's lectures of 1970, published as *Naming and Necessity* (1980), held that proper names are rigid designators whose reference is fixed by an initial baptism and transmitted along a causal chain of communication, so that a name may refer to its bearer even if every description associated with it is false of him. Leonard's "John G." has lost its baptism. The chain that would link the name to its bearer, the second intruder, who struck Leonard and escaped, has been severed by amnesia and, under H_1, by that man's death more than a year before. The name has collapsed into an improper description. At the junction, Leonard performs a new baptism. By record-

ing Teddy's license plate as the sixth fact, he fixes the reference of "John G." by stipulation and transmits it to his successors along a causal chain of tattoo ink. The final scene of *Memento* is a Kripkean naming ceremony.

Outside the fiction, the name has exactly the baptism Kripke describes. "John G." was reportedly an homage to Jonathan Nolan's screenwriting professor at Georgetown, John Glavin, so that its causal chain runs, from its first use, to a real man who never enters the diegesis. Inside the fiction no chain survives, and the name must be re-baptized by stipulation; outside it, the chain is intact and ends at someone who has done nothing. The two situations bracket the semantics of the case: a name with a bearer and no crime, and a crime with a name and no bearer.

Gareth Evans, in "The Causal Theory of Names" (1973), answered the pure causal theory with the case of Madagascar: a name once used for part of the African mainland was transferred, through Marco Polo's misunderstanding, to the island, and now refers to the island because the dominant source of information associated with the name has changed. "John G." is a Madagascar-name. Its reference shifts from the assailant to Jimmy and then to Teddy because the dominant source of information associated with it, the notes, has shifted.

The oldest narrative treatment of this semantic trap is found in the Droṇa Parvan of the *Mahābhārata*. Droṇa, commander of the Kaurava host, cannot be defeated while he bears arms. Bhīma kills an elephant named Aśvatthāman, which is also the name of Droṇa's son. Yudhiṣṭhira, renowned never to have lied, tells Droṇa that Aśvatthāman is dead, adding indistinctly that it was the elephant. Droṇa hears only the first clause, lays down his weapons, and is killed; and Yudhiṣṭhira's chariot, which had always ridden above the earth, sinks to the ground. A true sentence about another bearer of the same name destroys its hearer. The deception practiced on Leonard has this form: "John G. is the one" is true of someone. Chapter V follows the son, Aśvatthāman, into his vengeance.

4.8
The Tattooed Body

In Kafka's "In der Strafkolonie" (1919), an apparatus inscribes with needles upon the condemned man's body, over twelve hours, the commandment he has violated. The condemned does not know his sentence; he learns it on his body. Around the sixth hour, the officer explains, enlightenment comes even to the dullest: he begins to decipher the script with his wounds. When the visiting explorer withholds his

approval, the officer frees the prisoner, sets the machine to inscribe "Be just!" and lies down beneath it himself. The apparatus malfunctions and stabs him to death without writing, and his face shows no trace of the promised enlightenment. Leonard's tattoos constitute a penal colony administered by the condemned. He knows his sentence, but he must read it anew at every interval, so that the enlightenment of the sixth hour is repeated endlessly and never deepens. The offense of Kafka's prisoner is itself a lapse in a recurring duty: he was to rise every hour and salute his captain's door, and he fell asleep. The colony punishes a failure of hourly vigilance; Leonard's system is hourly vigilance made law. And the Harrow's script is so ornamented that the visiting explorer cannot read it; only the condemned, through his wounds, deciphers it, as only Leonard, in a mirror, reads the sentence on his chest. His final inscription is the officer's: a law he writes for himself, which will produce killing without understanding.

Nietzsche asked, in the second essay of the *Genealogy* (1887), how one makes a memory for the human animal, and answered with what he called the oldest psychology on earth: something is burned in so that it stays in the memory; only what never ceases to hurt remains (II.3). Punishment, sacrifice, mutilation, and the cruelties of cult are mnemotechnics, and the worse humanity's memory, the more fearful its customs. The purpose of this long torment was to breed an animal entitled to make promises, possessed of a memory of the will set against its native forgetfulness; its ripest fruit, Nietzsche writes, is the sovereign individual (*das souveraine Individuum*), autonomous and entitled to promise (II.1–2). Leonard's tattoos are Nietzschean mnemotechnics literalized: the memory of the will needled into a being whose forgetfulness is no longer active but organic. Hypomnesic sovereignty is the parody of Nietzsche's sovereign individual, the right to promise restored by needle to a man who cannot remember promising. Deleuze and Guattari, in the third chapter of *Anti-Œdipe* (1972), built on the same essay a theory of the primitive territorial machine as a system of cruelty that marks bodies to create a memory of debt. Leonard's body is a socius of one, and its debt is blood.

Melville anticipated Leonard's practice with uncanny exactness. In chapter 102 of *Moby-Dick* (1851), Ishmael reports that the dimensions of the whale's skeleton he is about to give are copied from his right arm, where he had them tattooed, because in his wanderings "there was no other secure way of preserving such valuable statistics"; crowded for space, he wished the rest of his body to remain "a blank page for a poem I was then composing." Leonard's chest keeps a space for an inscription of completion that appears only in a fantasy image near the film's end. In chapter 110, Queequeg's

tattoos are described as the work of a departed prophet who wrote on his body a complete theory of the heavens and the earth, so that Queequeg was a riddle to unfold, a wondrous work in one volume, "but whose mysteries not even himself could read, though his own live heart beat against them." Leonard's live heart beats against a text he misreads. Melville's two tattooed men divide what Leonard combines. Ishmael's skin is a legible parchment of statistics; Queequeg's is a theology its bearer cannot read. Leonard carries both, legible facts on his thigh and, over his heart, a sentence he misreads. Queequeg, near death, copies parts of his tattooing onto the lid of the coffin that becomes, in the novel's last pages, the buoy on which Ishmael alone survives. The unreadable text outlives its bearer and carries the witness who tells the story. In Memento, too, the one carried to safety by the inscriptions is not their bearer but the spectator.

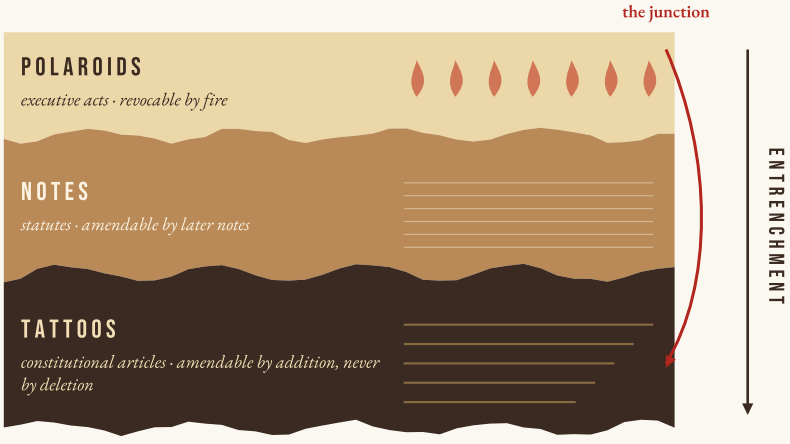
The inscription across Leonard's chest, which states that John G. raped and murdered his wife, is reversed, so that it reads correctly in a mirror. Leonardo da Vinci kept his notebooks in mirror script; the onomastic echo is an emblem rather than a source. Lacan's mirror stage (1949) describes the infant's jubilant assumption of its specular image as the matrix of the "I," a misrecognition (*méconnaissance*) of fragmented motor experience as a unified form. Leonard's mirror stage has a caption. He assumes his identity as the reader of a text inscribed on his reflection, so that the ideal-I is not an image but a sentence.

Deuteronomy commands that the words of the law be upon the heart: "thou shalt bind them for a sign upon thine hand, and they shall be as frontlets between thine eyes. And thou shalt write them upon the posts of thy house, and on thy gates" (6:8–9). Leonard's system is a Deuteronomy for one: words upon his hand, an inscription over his heart, signs before his eyes in the mirror, papers pinned to the walls of a rented room. Jan Assmann, in *Das kulturelle Gedächtnis* (1992), read Deuteronomy as the paradigm of cultural mnemotechnics, a catalogue of procedures for keeping alive a memory that would no longer be carried by living witnesses once the people entered the land: marking the body, teaching the young, inscribing boundaries, publishing the written law, instituting festivals, canonizing a text. The urgency of Deuteronomy derives from the death of the witnesses. In Leonard's life every interval is a generation, and the end of every interval is the death of the witnesses.

Hölderlin's "Mnemosyne" supplies the epitaph of this body: a sign are we, without interpretation. In Peircean terms, Leonard's skin bears signs whose interpretant has been lost, so that each reader supplies it anew, and the sign means whatever the reader who wakes inside it needs it to mean.

4.9
The Lethean Constitution

Leonard's three media form a legal order with tiers of entrenchment. Polaroids are executive acts: identifications of persons for action, revocable by fire. Notes are statutes: ordinary legislation, amendable by later notes. Tattoos are constitutional articles: entrenched, amendable by addition and never by deletion. The entrenched governs the revocable; the tattoos determine which notes may be written and which photographs taken. Call the whole the **Lethean constitution**. H. L. A. Hart's *The Concept of Law* (1961) argued that a legal system requires a secondary rule of recognition by which valid primary rules are identified. Leonard's rule of recognition is the injunction on his hand together with the doctrine it encodes: trust the handwriting, trust the facts, distrust memory. Behind it stands what Hans Kelsen called the basic norm, presupposed rather than posited: the past self is to be obeyed. It cannot be written down, because writing it would presuppose it.



Rule of recognition: the injunction on his hand, with its doctrine: trust the handwriting, trust the facts, distrust memory.

Basic norm, presupposed and unwritable: the past self is to be obeyed.

Figure 8. *The Lethean constitution: three media as tiers of entrenchment, governed by a rule of recognition and resting on an unwritable basic norm.*

The junction of the film is a constitutional amendment. A provisional identification, Teddy's license plate, is elevated into the entrenched register of facts, and the amendment is ratified by a needle in the scene that follows it chronologically, which the film screened near its opening. A sovereign who has just learned that his constitution rests on a lie amends it to preserve the lie. Chapter IX treats this as the paradigmatic constitutional moment of hypomnesic sovereignty. First, however, the passion the constitution serves must be examined.




ORESTES · HAMLET · AHAB · VICTOR FRANKENSTEIN · ASVATTHAMAN · SAUL · LEONARD ·
JOHN G · JOHN G · JOHN G ·

CHAPTER

V

The Erinyes Without Athens

Vengeance, Sacrifice, and the Theology of Remembrance

5.1 The Oresteia: Orestes Who Never Reaches Athens 77

5.2 Hamlet's Tables 78

5.3 Ahab: Agent or Principal 80

5.4 Frankenstein: The Pursued Who Writes 81

5.5 Mark, Refuge, and Amalek 82

5.6 Girard: The Sacrificial Machine and Its Refused Apocalypse 84

5.7 Nietzsche: Ressentiment Without Digestion 85

5.8 Spinoza, Arendt, Hegel: The Impossibility of Forgiveness 86

5.9 The Mahābhārata: The Avenger's Unhealing Wound 87

5.10 The Economy of Vengeance 88

5.1
The Oresteia: Orestes Who Never Reaches Athens

Aeschylus's trilogy (458 BCE) is the founding Western narrative of the transformation of vengeance into justice. Clytemnestra kills Agamemnon; Orestes, at Apollo's command, kills Clytemnestra; and the Erinyes, daughters of Night, pursue the matricide. In the *Eumenides* they describe themselves as mindful of evils (κακῶν μνήμονες), and around their quarry they dance a binding song (ὕμνος δέσμιος, 306), sung without the lyre, which fetters the mind and withers mortals. Christopher Faraone has argued that the song echoes the Athenian judicial curse tablets, inscriptions on lead with which litigants sought to bind their opponents' tongues and fix the outcome of a trial. The Furies' hymn is already a written curse. At Athens, Athena convenes a court on the Areopagus. The votes are equal; her casting vote acquits Orestes; and the Furies, persuaded rather than defeated, accept a cult beneath the Acropolis as the Eumenides, the Kindly Ones. The cycle of

blood ends when a third party, the court, is interposed between avenger and offender, and when the powers of remembrance are given a home within the city.

Leonard is at once Orestes and his own Erinys. He is the avenger driven by a duty of blood, and he is the remembering power that pursues. The paradox is exact: the Furies are memory personified, and Leonard's fury persists without memory. It is sustained instead by a binding song written on his body. The tattoos are the Erinyes' hymn transcribed, a song without lyre that binds the wits of whoever reads it. More exactly, they are curse tablets: inscriptions made to decide in advance the outcome of a trial that will never be held. And Leonard never reaches Athens. There is no Areopagus, no Athena, no interposed third, no vote. Teddy, who presents himself as an officer of the law, is the Areopagus parodied: the agent of the court who, far from ending the cycle, harvests it. In the *Eumenides*, the ghost of Clytemnestra rouses the sleeping Furies and upbraids them for sleeping. In *Memento*, the image of Catherine, flashing at the opening of an interval, wakes the hunt again. The dead woman sounds the alarm, and the avengers rise without knowing what they avenge.

5.2
Hamlet's Tables

The Ghost of Hamlet's father departs with a command: "Adieu, adieu, adieu! remember me." Hamlet's answer is a program of mnemonic purification: "Remember thee! / Ay, thou poor ghost, whiles memory holds a seat / In this distracted globe. Remember thee! / Yea, from the table of my memory / I'll wipe away all trivial fond records, / All saws of books, all forms, all pressures past, / That youth and observation copied there; / And thy commandment all alone shall live / Within the book and volume of my brain, / Unmix'd with baser matter" (1.5). Then, without transition, he reaches for his tables, the erasable notebook of the Elizabethan student: "My tables, meet it is I set it down, / That one may smile, and smile, and be a villain." Then he writes down his "word" as well: "Adieu, adieu, remember me." The command to remember is itself set down in the tables, because the one who has sworn to remember cannot trust himself to. Leonard's hand carries an entry of the same kind. The Ghost had already named the alternative: Hamlet would be duller than "the fat weed / That roots itself in ease on Lethe wharf" if he did not stir. Leonard is the case the Ghost could not imagine, a weed on Lethe wharf that stirs.

The scene is the archetype of both Leonard's condition and his system. The table of memory is wiped clean of everything but a single commandment; the command-

ment is transferred to an external tablet; and the first entry is a warning about the smiling villain. Leonard's injury has wiped his table; only the commandment survives; and he writes in his tables that a smiling man is not to be believed. When Hamlet laments that "the time is out of joint" and that he was born to set it right, he names the condition Deleuze would make the formula of the third synthesis of time (2.3).

Hamlet is also Leonard's inverse. Hamlet delays because thought accumulates: "the native hue of resolution / Is sicklied o'er with the pale cast of thought" (3.1). Leonard cannot delay, because no thought persists long enough to sicken resolution. He is resolution without the pale cast of thought, a revenger who cannot hesitate because he cannot remember having doubted.

Yet both write tables, and both have reason to suspect their ghost. "The spirit that I have seen / May be the devil," Hamlet reasons (2.2; so the Folio, where the Second Quarto reads "a deale," a devil), and he stages the Mousetrap to test the Ghost's testimony by catching the conscience of the king. His reason for doubt is his own condition: the devil, "very potent with such spirits," may work "out of my weakness and my melancholy" to abuse him to his damnation, and it was a commonplace of the period's ghost-lore, as the New Cambridge editors note after Eleanor Prosser, that melancholics were peculiarly open to demonic visitation. The grieving man is the one most easily used: Natalie and Teddy find Leonard as the devil finds Hamlet, through his grief.

Hamlet's test is itself a staged repetition of the crime before its suspect, so that his reaction will show what his words conceal. The insulin test in the story of Sammy is a Mousetrap of the same design, staged by a wife upon her husband, and, unlike Hamlet's, it kills the one who stages it. Leonard's notes are ghosts of his former self, demanding remembrance, whose testimony cannot be tested. When a Mousetrap is staged for him, in the form of Teddy's revelation, a performance designed to catch his conscience, Leonard does not rise from his seat as Claudius did. He rewrites the play.

Stephen Greenblatt's *Hamlet in Purgatory* (2001) located the Ghost's demand in the Reformation's abolition of Purgatory and of the institutions, chantries, masses, and prayers for the dead, through which the living had discharged their obligations to the departed. The Ghost returns from a Purgatory that English doctrine no longer acknowledges, demanding a remembrance no institution can now supply, and vengeance substitutes for suffrage. Leonard is a post-Purgatorial mourner. No church and no court mediates his obligation to Catherine, so he invents a private liturgy in which the hunt is a requiem performed in blood. In Kyd's *The Spanish Tragedy* (c. 1587), Hieronimo enters with a book and reads "Vindicta mihi," Paul's citation of the

divine claim to vengeance, and then reasons his way through Seneca to taking vengeance himself. The avenger with a book in his hand, reading the text that forbids him and resolving to act anyway, is the precise image of Leonard reading his own notes.

5.3
Ahab: Agent or Principal

Melville's Ahab gives vengeance its metaphysics. "All visible objects, man, are but as pasteboard masks," he tells Starbuck; behind them some unknown but still reasoning thing puts forth the mouldings of its features; "If man will strike, strike through the mask!" The whale is the mask of an inscrutable malice, and Ahab does not care which it is: "be the white whale agent, or be the white whale principal, I will wreak that hate upon him" (ch. 36). "John G." is a pasteboard mask. Whatever stands behind it, agent or principal, assailant or substitute, receives the hatred meant for the inscrutable thing that destroyed Leonard's life. Ahab asks how the prisoner can reach outside except by thrusting through the wall, and calls the whale that wall, shoved near to him; Leonard, prisoner of the present, finds his wall in whoever bears the name. Ishmael adds that Ahab piled upon the whale's white hump the sum of all the general rage and hate felt by his whole race from Adam down. The whale is a scapegoat in Girard's exact sense (5.6), and so is each John G.

Melville also supplies, in a single passage of chapter 41, both the grammar of Leonard's self-deception and the formula of his rationality. Ahab, Ishmael says, knew that to mankind he had long dissembled, and in some sort still did, and that his dissembling "was only subject to his perceptibility, not to his will determinate": a deception its author can glimpse but not command. This is the structure of chronopartite self-deception (6.7), in which Leonard's deception is glimpsed in flashes and never willed by the interval that glimpses it. The formula of the rationality comes in the same breath: "all my means are sane, my motive and my object mad." Leonard's system, with its facts, procedures, verifications, and photographs, is impeccably sane; its motive and object are mad. Horkheimer and Adorno would describe instrumental reason as reason reduced to the calculation of means for ends it no longer examines. Leonard is its purest exemplar: a perfect means-machine whose end has become arbitrary.

5.4
Frankenstein: The Pursued Who Writes

At the graves of his family, Victor Frankenstein swears by the shades of the dead "to pursue the daemon who caused this misery, until he or I shall perish in mortal conflict." The pursuit that follows, across Europe and into the Arctic, has a feature that bears directly on *Memento*: the creature sustains his pursuer. He leaves "marks in writing on the barks of the trees, or cut in stone," which guide Victor and inflame his fury; one reads "My reign is not yet over" and bids him follow. He leaves food so that the hunter will not perish before the hunt is done. The pursued writes the inscriptions that keep the pursuer in pursuit. When Victor swears his vow at the graves, the creature answers with a laugh and declares himself satisfied that Victor has determined to live: the vow is a reason to live, as Teddy says Leonard's hunt has been. Victor himself describes the pursuit as "the mechanical impulse of some power of which I was unconscious" rather than the ardent desire of his soul. And dying aboard Robert Walton's ship, he asks Walton to swear that he will seek out and kill the creature if Victor dies: the vow is bequeathed to a successor, as Leonard's are. Walton, the frame narrator who has heard the whole story, does not take up the bequest. The listener who knows everything declines the inheritance, which is the spectator's position in Memento (9.9).

In *Memento*, pursuer and writing pursued are one man. At the junction Leonard writes the inscriptions that will keep his successor hunting, and Teddy, by his own account, has been feeding the hunt for a year, supplying a reason to live as the creature supplied provisions. In one of the film's most comic and most philosophically exact moments, Leonard finds himself running beside another man and must reason out whether he is chasing or being chased, until a gunshot settles the matter. The indistinction of hunter and hunted that *Frankenstein* reaches only at the end of its long chase, *Memento* enacts in a single sprint. The protagonist's surname, which nearly echoes Shelley's, is an emblem rather than a source, like the echo of Leonardo in his first name (4.8).

5.5
Mark, Refuge, and Amalek

The Hebrew Bible legislates the problem of vengeance more extensively than any other ancient corpus, and it does so through the categories of inscription and memory. After Abel's murder, "the LORD set a mark upon Cain, lest any finding him should kill him" (Genesis 4:15). Cain's mark is a sign on the body that suspends vengeance. Leonard's marks compel it. Cain's descendant Lamech then sings: "If Cain shall be avenged sevenfold, truly Lamech seventy and sevenfold" (Genesis 4:24). The Gospel answers with the same number turned against itself, when Peter asks how often he must forgive: "I say not unto thee, Until seven times: but, Until seventy times seven" (Matthew 18:22). Leonard's serial vengeance follows Lamech's curve, and its interminability measures a forgiveness that cannot take place.

The law of the blood-avenger, the *go'el ha-dam*, in Numbers 35, Deuteronomy 19, and Joshua 20, distinguishes the murderer, whom the avenger may kill, from the unintentional manslayer, who may flee to a city of refuge and live there until the death of the high priest. Under hypothesis H_1, Leonard is both figures: the avenger of Catherine's blood and the manslayer whose amnesia made the repeated injections lethal. He is the avenger in pursuit of a manslayer who is himself, and there is no city of refuge from oneself. Or rather, there is exactly one. Amnesia is Leonard's city of refuge. The city of refuge is Lethe.

The most radical text in this tradition concerns Amalek. "Write this for a memorial in a book, and rehearse it in the ears of Joshua: for I will utterly put out the remembrance of Amalek from under heaven" (Exodus 17:14). "Remember what Amalek did unto thee by the way ... thou shalt blot out the remembrance of Amalek from under heaven; thou shalt not forget it" (Deuteronomy 25:17–19). The commandment is a paradox of inscription: write in a book so that remembrance may be erased; remember to blot out remembrance; do not forget to make forgotten. In later tradition Amalek became a floating designation, reassigned to successive enemies from Haman the Agagite onward, because the commandment outlived every historical bearer of the name. "John G." is Leonard's Amalek: a name for the enemy that must be perpetually re-identified, because the commandment to remember outlasts each of its bearers. Leonard's confession that forgetting his wife is something he cannot remember to do inverts the paradox. Here the beloved, not the enemy, is the object of a remembrance that is also an erasure.

The paradox is not only mnemonic; it is lethal. In 1 Samuel 15, Samuel conveys to Saul the command to destroy Amalek entirely: "slay both man and woman, infant and suckling, ox and sheep, camel and ass" (15:3). Saul spares the Amalekite king Agag and the best of the livestock, is rejected as king for his disobedience, and Samuel kills Agag himself at Gilgal (15:33). The name Amalek thus licenses the killing of everyone who bears it, noncombatants included. In the book of Esther, Haman the Agagite, heir to that name, plots the destruction of all the Jews of the Persian empire, so that the designation passes between persecutor and persecuted. Over the following centuries it was reapplied, in polemic and political rhetoric, to successive enemies, and so continued to mark living groups for hostility. Against this, a strong current in rabbinic law neutralized it. The Talmud taught that Sennacherib had mixed the nations so that their descent could no longer be traced (Berakhot 28a), and the Mishnah applied the principle to Ammonites and Moabites (Yadayim 4:4). Maimonides confined the commandment to an Amalek that refuses peace (Laws of Kings 6:4), and Yosef Babad's Minhat Hinukh (1869) concluded that it no longer binds because the nations have been mixed; other authorities dissented and held it in force. Jonathan Sacks drew the line in our own time: the war against Amalek no longer applies, while the duty to remember the evil Amalek embodied remains. The tradition separated remembrance from execution.

This sharpens the identification of John G. with Amalek. "John G." is a name that licenses the killing of whoever is made to bear it, the function Chapter IX calls the ban of the *homo sacer* (9.5). And the rabbinic solution is the exact inverse of Leonard's. Faced with a name whose bearer could no longer be identified, the rabbis declared the commandment unenforceable. Faced with the same predicament, Leonard stipulates a bearer. The rabbis kept the duty to remember and retired the duty to kill; Leonard's system cannot separate them, because for him the only form remembrance can take is the next execution.

The same corpus forbids private vengeance, "Thou shalt not avenge, nor bear any grudge against the children of thy people" (Leviticus 19:18), and reserves it to God: "Vengeance is mine; I will repay, saith the Lord" (Romans 12:19, after Deuteronomy 32:35). The theological rationale is mnemonic. Vengeance belongs to the one who remembers perfectly, before whom "a book of remembrance was written" (Malachi 3:16). Leonard usurps the divine prerogative on the strength of its opposite: he claims the right that belongs to perfect memory on the basis of a perfect deficit. Yosef Hayim Yerushalmi's *Zakhor* (1982) showed how thoroughly the biblical imperative to

remember structured Jewish existence. Leonard's *zakhor* is that imperative emptied of every content but its form.

5.6
Girard: The Sacrificial Machine and Its Refused Apocalypse

René Girard's *La Violence et le sacré* (1972) argued that vengeance is the gravest threat to any community because it is interminable: each act of vengeance calls forth another, in a chain without natural end. Archaic societies contain it by sacrifice, diverting violence onto a surrogate victim whose death restores unanimity; modern societies contain it by a judicial system that reserves the last word for itself. The sacrificial mechanism depends on *méconnaissance*: the participants must not recognize the arbitrariness of the victim, for if they knew he had been chosen rather than found guilty, the mechanism would fail. Mimetic rivalry dissolves differences into doubles, and the crisis resolves when violence converges on one of them.

Leonard reconstitutes the entire sacrificial apparatus inside a single psyche. The crisis is the dissolution of the difference between avenger and offender, which under H_1 is complete. The surrogate victim is a John G. The *méconnaissance* is supplied organically: the sacrificer cannot know the arbitrariness of his victim because he cannot remember having chosen him. Call this **neurological méconnaissance**. The restoration of order is the moment Teddy describes, a year before the events of the film, when Leonard was photographed beaming and pointing at the space on his chest reserved for an inscription of completion. Recurrence follows, because the peace, like every sacrificial peace, depends on forgetting, and Leonard forgets the peace as well. Under H_2 the vengeance came earlier still: by Leonard's own account he shot the man who raped and strangled Catherine on the night itself. Under either hypothesis, then, the vengeance he pursues was accomplished before the film begins, and the hunt is its repetition.

In *Des choses cachées depuis la fondation du monde* (1978) and *Le Bouc émissaire* (1982), Girard argued that the Gospels dismantle the sacrificial mechanism by narrating it from the side of the victim and declaring the victim innocent. Revelation, *apokalypsis*, is an unveiling that renders sacrifice impossible, because the mechanism cannot survive being seen. Teddy's revelation has precisely this function. It unveils the arbitrariness of the John Gs: the victims were chosen, not found. Leonard's response is a **refused apocalypse**. Instead of renouncing the mechanism once he has seen it, he

restarts it knowingly, selects the revealer as its next victim, and arranges to forget that he has seen. This is darker than Girard's archaic misrecognition. It is a second-order *méconnaissance*: misrecognition chosen after recognition, and manufactured by the one who recognized.

The film's social world is a field of mimetic doubles. Teddy is a John G. Natalie, mourning Jimmy, is an avenger who makes Leonard's vengeance the instrument of her own. Leonard and Dodd exchange the roles of hunter and hunted: Dodd shoots at Leonard in the street, and Leonard, primed by Natalie, ambushes Dodd, knocks him unconscious, and binds him in a motel closet. Leonard and Sammy may be one man. Even the motel ledger doubles him, renting two rooms to a single guest. Girard's monstrous double has a room key.

5.7
Nietzsche: Ressentiment Without Digestion

Nietzsche opened the second essay of the *Genealogy* by defending forgetfulness as an active faculty of inhibition, which ensures that what we experience enters consciousness no more than what we eat does in the process of digestion. Active forgetting is a doorkeeper, a preserver of psychic order, rest, and etiquette; without it there could be no happiness, no cheerfulness, no hope, no pride, no present. The man in whom this apparatus is damaged resembles a dyspeptic: he cannot be done with anything (II.1). In the first essay, the noble type is exemplified by Mirabeau, who had no memory for insults and could not forgive simply because he forgot (I.10). The man of *ressentiment*, by contrast, knows how to keep silent, how not to forget, how to wait.

Dostoevsky had already drawn the figure from inside. In *Notes from Underground* (1864), the insulted man is likened to a mouse that retreats into its hole and spends forty years remembering its injury to the smallest and most shameful detail, adding humiliations of its own invention each time. The underground man cannot forget, and therefore cannot act. Leonard cannot remember, and therefore cannot stop acting, except in the one matter of his injury, where he is the underground man's equal.

Leonard is Mirabeau exactly inverted. He forgets everything except the injury, and he cannot forgive because he cannot forget the one thing he retains. Total forgetting of the present combined with total retention of the wound is *ressentiment* in its pure, mechanical form. He cannot be done with anything, not because his digestion is weak but because, in Augustine's image (2.5), he has no stomach of the mind.

Nietzsche's essay on history (1874) describes cattle grazing, happy because they are tethered to the peg of the moment, and the human being who envies them because he cannot learn to forget. It defines the plastic power of a person or a culture: the capacity to grow out of oneself, to transform and incorporate the past, to heal wounds, replace what is lost, and recreate broken forms. Leonard lacks plastic power absolutely; his lament about healing is its clinical definition. He is the animal tethered to the peg of the moment without its happiness, because he has kept one memory, and a being with one memory and an animal's present is the unhappiest of creatures. The later aphorism "Blessed are the forgetful, for they get over even their stupidities" (*Beyond Good and Evil* §217) describes Leonard's blessing exactly, and his curse. He gets over his stupidities, mistaken killings included, and never gets over his wound.

5.8
Spinoza, Arendt, Hegel: The Impossibility of Forgiveness

Spinoza defines vengeance as the desire by which, from reciprocal hatred, we are roused to injure one who, from a like affect, has injured us (*Ethics* III, Definitions of the Affects, 37). His therapy of the affects depends on knowledge: an affect that is a passion ceases to be a passion as soon as we form a clear and distinct idea of it (V P3). Leonard cannot form a clear and distinct idea of the cause of his hatred, because he cannot reliably remember it, and his affect is therefore condemned to remain a passion. The Spinozist cure is neurologically foreclosed.

Hannah Arendt held that forgiveness is the only remedy for the irreversibility of action, and that vengeance, by contrast, is the natural and automatic reaction to transgression, binding doer and sufferer in the relentless automatism of the action process. Forgiveness alone does not merely re-act but acts anew. What is forgiven, she added, is forgiven for the sake of the one who did it. Leonard's vengeance is automatic in Arendt's sense and in the clinical sense. And forgiveness presupposes a persisting "who" on both sides: an offender who endures to be forgiven and a forgiver who endures to forgive. Leonard has neither. The real offender is, under H_1, long dead, and the substitutes are not the offender; the self that might forgive does not persist long enough to do so. Arendt's natality, the human capacity to begin anew, is in Leonard a counterfeit. He begins anew every few minutes and never begins anything.

Hegel closes the section of the *Phenomenology of Spirit* on conscience and the beautiful soul with the dialectic of confession and forgiveness and a sentence of great consolation: the wounds of spirit heal and leave no scars behind (§669). Leonard's

wounds do not heal, and the scars they leave are writing. His tattoos are anti-Hegelian scars, inscriptions that prevent reconciliation by preserving the wound in legible form. Hegelian forgiveness also requires confession, and Leonard's only confession is the story of Sammy, a confession in the third person, which no one can forgive because it is attributed to someone else.

Two further Hegelian figures complete the diagnosis. The *Science of Logic* (1812–16) distinguishes the true infinite, which returns into itself, from the bad infinite (*die schlechte Unendlichkeit*), the endless progression in which each finite term is surpassed by another finite term without the series ever arriving. Leonard's serial vengeance is the bad infinite in its purest form: John G. after John G., each surpassed by the next, none returning the series to itself. And the *Phenomenology* ends with spirit recollecting its past shapes as a gallery of images, a recollection Hegel writes as *Er-innerung*, a going-inward by which what was externalized is made inward again. Leonard's Polaroids are a gallery of images without *Er-innerung*: an externalization never taken back in, a recollection pinned to the walls of a rented room.

In the *Gorgias* (493a–c), Socrates reports an image of the appetitive soul as a jar perforated by its intemperance, which can never be filled, and into which the uninitiated carry water in a sieve. Leonard's vengeance cannot be satisfied because satisfaction cannot be stored; the perforation is in the hippocampus. The inscription of completion, glimpsed only in a fantasy image of his chest, is the emblem of a full jar that cannot exist. Satisfaction requires memory of satisfaction. Girard showed that vengeance is interminable. *Memento* shows that, without memory, it is also unsatisfiable in principle: a Danaid labor whose water drains as fast as it is poured.

5.9
The Mahābhārata: The Avenger's Unhealing Wound

The son whose name destroyed Droṇa (4.7) becomes the epic's great avenger. In the Sauptika Parvan, the Book of the Sleeping Warriors, Aśvatthāman lies sleepless beneath a banyan tree and watches an owl descend at night upon a roost of sleeping crows and kill them one by one. Taking the owl as his teacher, he enters the Pāṇḍava camp in darkness and slaughters Dhṛṣṭadyumna, his father's killer, together with the sleeping sons of the Pāṇḍavas. Pursued, he looses a weapon of annihilation and turns it upon the wombs of the Pāṇḍava women. Krishna revives the unborn child and curses Aśvatthāman to wander the earth for three thousand years, diseased, without a companion, and unable to speak with anyone; the jewel is taken from his forehead;

and in a tradition that has outlived the epic, he wanders still, with a wound where the jewel was that will not heal. The structural homology is striking: an avenger whose catastrophe began with the ambiguity of a name, who strikes by night at those who cannot see him, and who is condemned to wander indefinitely with a head wound that never closes. Kafka's hunter Gracchus, whose death-barque lost its way so that he drifts forever between the living and the dead, is the modern form of this wanderer. The epic's own terms for the curse are the most exact of all: a life without a companion and without conversation is the Lethean condition, in which no exchange is ever shared with the self that follows.

The *Bhagavad Gītā*, set on the same battlefield, supplies the metaphysics. Arjuna, paralyzed before the prospect of killing his kin, is told that his right is to action alone, never to its fruits (2.47). In the theophany of the eleventh chapter, Krishna reveals himself as Time (*kāla*), destroyer of worlds, and shows Arjuna the warriors of both armies already entering his mouths: by me they have already been slain; be merely the instrument (11.32–33). *Memento*'s form is this vision. Its first image shows the enemy already slain, and every subsequent scene discloses the instrumental steps by which a death that has already happened is brought about. Leonard is merely the instrument. And his action without access to its fruits, his inability ever to experience the outcome of what he does, is the *Gītā*'s discipline of desireless action parodied: detachment from the fruits produced not by spiritual exercise but by lesion. A generation later, *Oppenheimer* would make the *Gītā*'s verse of Time a recurrent motif. Nolan's early film had already enacted the text his later film would quote.

5.10
The Economy of Vengeance

Leonard's sacred duty circulates as a commodity among the interests of others. Natalie uses it against Teddy; Teddy uses it against Jimmy and covets the money in Jimmy's car; the motel clerk charges for its lodging. Leonard's labor produces a surplus he never sees, and he is paid in meaning. Vengeance in *Memento* is not only a passion but an economy, and Chapter IX reads it through Marx. First, however, the self-relation that the passion requires must be examined: the relation of a man to a truth he has decided not to know.

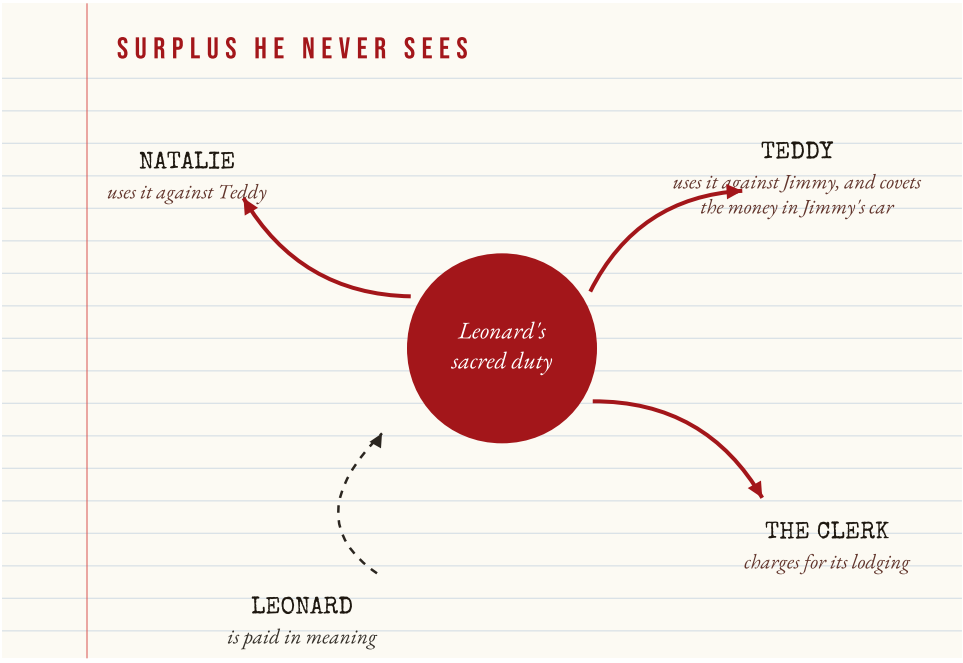
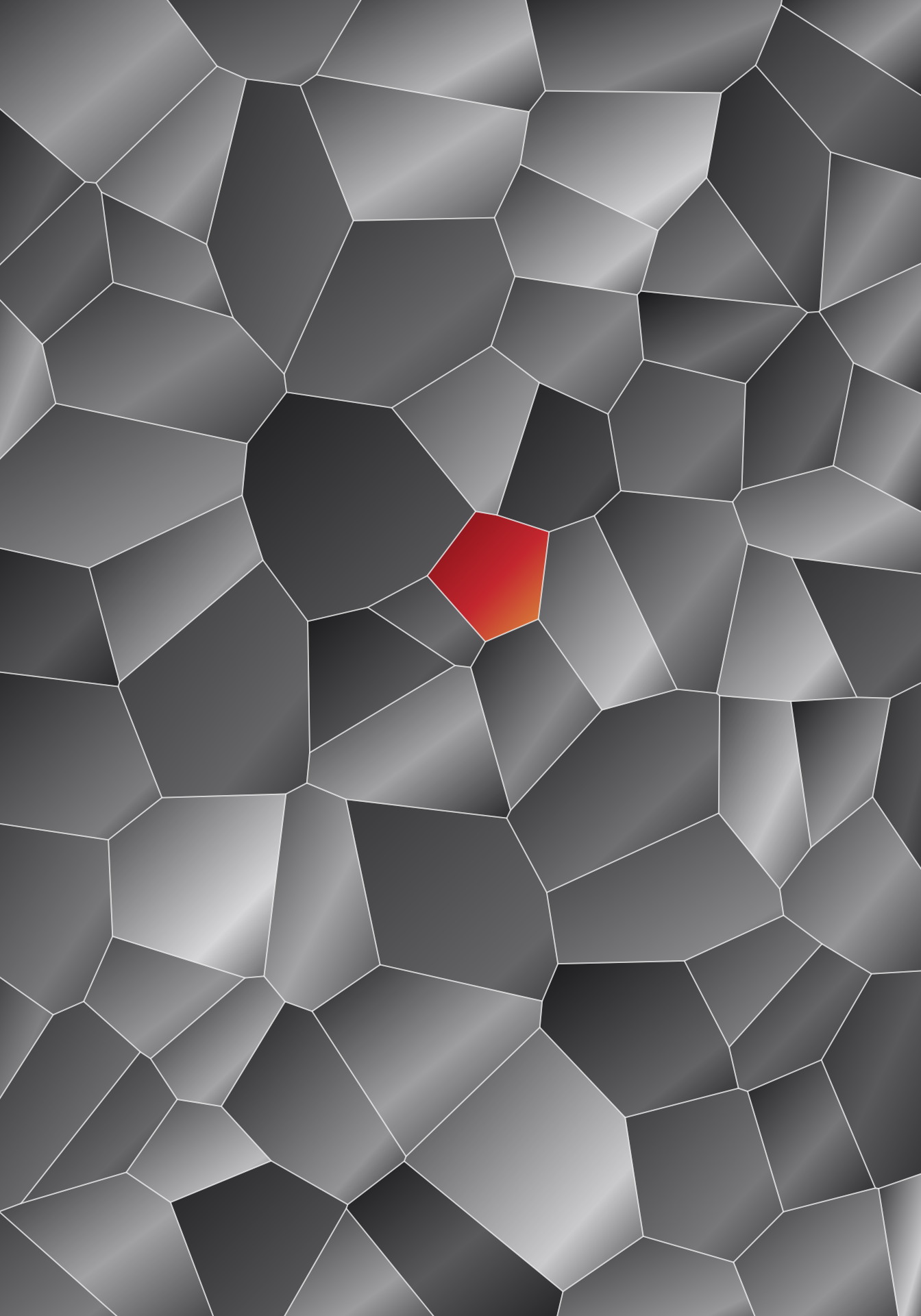


Figure 9. *The economy of vengeance. Leonard's sacred duty circulates among the interests of others, and he is paid in meaning.*



CHAPTER

VI

Recognition Refused

Tragedy, Screen Memory, and Chronopartite Self-Deception

6.1 Aristotle's Taxonomy and Its Inversion 91
6.2 Oedipus Who Heeds Jocasta 93
6.3 The Tragic Kin-Killers 93
6.4 Sammy Jankis as Screen Memory 95
6.5 Narrative Memory and Traumatic Memory 96
6.6 The Transposed Life: A Pale View of Hills 97
6.7 Chronopartite Self-Deception 97
6.8 The Two-in-One 99
6.9 The Memory of the Offense 100
6.10 The Buried Experimentalist 100
6.11 The Closing Creed 101

6.1
Aristotle's Taxonomy and Its Inversion

Aristotle defines reversal (*peripeteia*) as a change of the action into its opposite, according to probability or necessity, and recognition (*anagnorisis*) as a change from ignorance to knowledge, producing love or hatred among those destined for good or ill fortune; the finest recognition coincides with reversal, as in the *Oedipus* (*Poetics* 1452a22–33). In chapter 16 he ranks the species of recognition. Lowest, and most used through poverty of invention, is recognition by signs: congenital marks, acquired marks such as scars, external tokens such as necklaces. Next come recognitions contrived by the poet; then recognition through memory, when the sight of something awakens feeling, as when Odysseus weeps at the bard's song among the Phaeacians; then recognition by reasoning; then a composite recognition arising from false inference, which the text, in a much-disputed phrase, attributes to the theater itself; and highest of all, recognition arising from the incidents themselves, as in the *Oedipus* (1454b19–1455a21).

Leonard's existence is organized around the species Aristotle ranks lowest. His tattoos are acquired marks, his Polaroids external tokens, and he recognizes everyone by signs. Recognition through memory is closed to him for everyone he has met since the attack. Recognition by reasoning is his method: deduction from facts. His catastrophe is recognition by paralogism, valid-seeming inference from premises that are true of someone. The highest species, recognition from the incidents themselves, is offered to him by Teddy at the junction, and he refuses it. *Memento* traverses Aristotle's taxonomy from bottom to top and stops one step short.

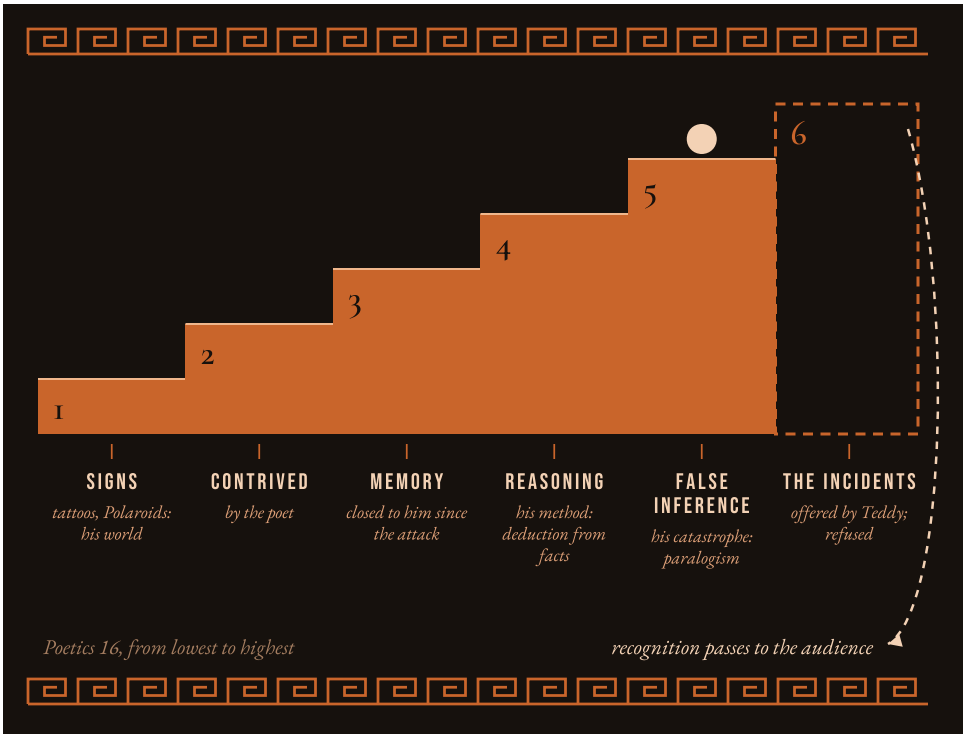


Figure 10. *Aristotle's species of recognition (Poetics 16), lowest to highest. Leonard climbs to false inference and refuses the last step; recognition passes to the audience.*

The film's form executes *peripeteia* at the level of time itself, since its whole structure is a reversal; its protagonist refuses *anagnorisis*. This is **anti-anagnorisis**: reversal without recognition in the hero, coupled with recognition transferred to the audience. In the final scene it is the spectator who passes from ignorance to knowledge, and whose feeling toward Leonard reverses, from sympathy to something between horror and tragic pity. The spectator is the tragic subject of *Memento*; Leonard is its occasion. The false inference that Aristotle's text attributes to the theater finds here its

most literal instance. For most of its length the film induces its audience to commit Leonard's paralogism, so that the recognition, when it comes, is also a recognition of the spectator's complicity.

6.2
Oedipus Who Heeds Jocasta

Oedipus investigates the murder of Laius in order to lift a plague. Tiresias tells him that he is the murderer, and Oedipus accuses the prophet of conspiracy, much as Leonard dismisses Teddy as a liar. As the evidence converges, Jocasta counsels him that it is best to live at random, as one can (979), and, once she has understood, she pleads: unhappy man, may you never come to know who you are (1068). Oedipus refuses her counsel, pursues the truth to its end, and blinds himself.

Leonard is Oedipus who heeds Jocasta. He chooses to live at random, by the arbitrariness of a license plate, and he arranges never to know who he is. His blinding is mnemonic rather than ocular: he burns the photographs, putting out the eyes of his archive. Oedipus blinds himself because he knows; Leonard blinds himself in order not to know. The irony of vocation completes the parallel. Oedipus was famed for answering the Sphinx's riddle, which asks what walks on four legs, then two, then three, a riddle about the identity of one being across time. He solved it in general and failed it in his own case. Leonard explains the identity of a person across time to anyone who will listen, and fails it in his own. His profession was the detection of fraudulent claims; the investigator of false claims could not detect his own.

6.3
The Tragic Kin-Killers

Greek tragedy offers three further models of violence against misidentified victims, and each defines Leonard by contrast. In Sophocles' *Ajax*, the hero, maddened by Athena, slaughters cattle and sheep believing them to be the Atreidae and Odysseus; restored to his senses, he sees the carnage and kills himself for shame. Leonard's John Gs are Ajax's sheep, killed in the belief that they are the enemy, and, as with Ajax, someone stands behind the delusion. In Euripides' *Heracles* (c. 416 BCE), Madness sent by Hera drives the hero to kill his wife Megara and their sons, whom he takes for his enemy's children. He wakes bound to a pillar; his father reveals the truth; he resolves to die. Theseus then arrives, uncovers the polluted man's face, offers him

friendship and a home in Athens, and Heracles chooses to live and bear what he has done. Recognition, acceptance, friendship, and a city: this is the Heraclean solution. Leonard has no Theseus. The one man who might uncover his face is the man he decides to kill. In the *Bacchae* (405 BCE), Agave returns from the mountain carrying the head of her son Pentheus, whom she tore apart believing him a lion. Her father Cadmus leads her back to sanity by a sequence of patient questions: look at the sky; whose house did you marry into; whose head is in your arms? George Devereux called it the first psychotherapy scene in literature. Teddy's revelation is a Cadmean interrogation conducted with contempt instead of love, and it fails.

Torquato Tasso's *Gerusalemme liberata* (1581) contains the scene Freud chose, in *Jenseits des Lustprinzips* (1920), as the most moving poetic picture of the compulsion to repeat. Tancred kills Clorinda, the warrior he loves, in night combat, failing to recognize her in a stranger's armor. Later, in an enchanted forest, he strikes a tall cypress; blood flows from the cut, and Clorinda's voice reproaches him for wounding his beloved again. Cathy Caruth (1996) made this voice crying from the wound the paradigm of traumatic address. Under H_1, Leonard is Tancred. He killed his beloved without knowing what he did, inside the armor of his amnesia, and every subsequent killing wounds her again. Each John G is a cypress from which Catherine's voice speaks, and it speaks only to the spectator, with one exception. As Leonard drags Jimmy Grantz, whom he has strangled and believes dead, Jimmy whispers the name Sammy. Since Leonard tells Sammy's story only to people he has met, the whisper is evidence that the dying man had met him before and heard the screen recited, and it is the first fissure in his system, the event that drives him to demand an explanation from Teddy at the junction. The cypress speaks, and what it says is the name of the screen. The victim utters the name that conceals the killer's guilt, and in doing so turns the screen memory into an accusation.

Othello demands of Iago "the ocular proof" (3.3) and is answered with a handkerchief, a token on whose strength he kills an innocent wife. Leonard's Polaroids are ocular proof, and his captions tell him which man is Iago. But the true Iago of *Memento* is the earlier Leonard who writes the caption: honest Iago in the form of trusted handwriting.

6.4
Sammy Jankis as Screen Memory

Freud's "Über Deckerinnerungen" (1899) describes screen memories: indifferent or innocuous recollections, often unusually vivid, that owe their persistence to an associative link with a significant content which they at once conceal and represent. Under H_1, the story of Sammy Jankis is Leonard's screen memory. It is vivid, rehearsed, ostensibly about another man, and composed of the elements of his own history: a diabetic wife, repeated injections, a test of whether her husband's condition is real, a coma, a death. Under H_2 it remains a screen of another kind, concealing professional guilt: Leonard's skepticism denied Sammy's claim, and Mrs. Jankis's fatal experiment followed from it. The film marks the return of the repressed within the screen by two celebrated devices. In the institution's day room, a figure passes in front of Sammy, and for a fraction of a second it is Leonard who sits in his chair. And a remembered caress, a playful pinch of Catherine's thigh, is replaced in a flash by the press of a needle.

In "Erinnern, Wiederholen und Durcharbeiten" (1914), Freud observes that the patient does not remember what he has forgotten and repressed but acts it out; he reproduces it not as memory but as deed; he repeats it, without of course knowing that he is repeating it. Leonard's serial killings are acting-out in this strict sense. Under H_1 they repeat an act he performed without knowing it was repetition, the injection given again and again, together with its retaliation upon a stranger. Under either hypothesis they repeat the killing of the assailant, which Teddy says was accomplished long ago, without knowledge that they repeat it. Working-through, the slow integration of insight over time, is the one therapeutic process neurologically closed to him.

In "Trauer und Melancholie" (1917), Freud describes mourning as a labor of reality-testing in which each memory binding the mourner to the lost object is brought up, hypercathected, and detached, bit by bit, at great expense of time and energy. Mourning requires temporal accumulation. Leonard cannot accumulate, so every act of mourning resets, and melancholia is his structural rather than neurotic fate. In melancholia, Freud writes, the shadow of the object falls upon the ego: the ego identifies with the lost object, and reproaches against the object become reproaches against the self. Under H_1 the process runs backwards. The self-reproach, I killed her, is projected outward onto an external enemy. Leonard's is an inverted melancholia.

Freud's study of Schreber (1911) derived the forms of paranoia from successive grammatical contradictions of a single proposition. The same method yields the grammar of Leonard's defense. Begin, under H_1, with the proposition "I killed her." Passivize it, deleting the agent: "She was killed." Supply an indefinite agent: "Someone killed her." Name the indefinite: "John G. killed her," a name without a bearer. Conjoin it with the act the intruders did commit: "John G. raped and murdered my wife," the sentence Leonard wears over his heart, in which a true accusation carries a false one (4.7). Displace the confession onto a double: "Sammy killed his wife," the act admitted under another man's name. Finally, assign the name a bearer chosen for convenience: "He is John G." Each step corresponds to an artifact in Leonard's system: a memory, a police file, a fact, a tattoo, a story, a caption. His body carries the grammar of his defense. Under H_2 the same sequence describes the conversion of an unknown assailant into a series of designated substitutes, and only the displacement onto Sammy loses its confessional character.

6.5
Narrative Memory and Traumatic Memory

Pierre Janet distinguished narrative memory, the ordinary capacity to recount the past, adapted to the listener and integrated into personal history, from traumatic memory, the fixed idea, rigid and dissociated, repeated identically and never assimilated. Bessel van der Kolk and Onno van der Hart revived the distinction in the 1990s and pressed it toward the claim that traumatic memories are literal, unaltered imprints. Ruth Leys's critique (2000) exposed the incoherence of that literalism.

Memento distributes Janet's two memories with deliberate perversity. The Sammy story is narrative memory: fluent, assimilated, adapted to each listener. Under H_1 it is the false one. The true memory appears only as traumatic memory: flashes, intrusions, unassimilated images. The film inverts the ordinary prestige of evidence, in which narrative is trusted and fragments are doubted. Yet it does not endorse literalism either, since the fragments are themselves unstable: the pinch becomes an injection and may become a pinch again. The truth of the fragment is not literal fidelity but its resistance to the narrative that would absorb it.

6.6

The Transposed Life: A Pale View of Hills

Kazuo Ishiguro's first novel (1982) is the Sammy Jankis device in literary form. Etsuko, living in England after her elder daughter's suicide, recalls a summer in postwar Nagasaki and her acquaintance with Sachiko, a neglectful mother whose troubled daughter is to be taken abroad. Slips accumulate; at one moment Etsuko speaks to Sachiko's daughter as if she herself were the mother and the journey her own, telling the girl that if she does not like it over there, "we" can always come back. A second slip confirms the first: Etsuko remembers Keiko happy on the day of the cable-car outing, a day that belonged to Mariko, when Keiko was not yet born; the memory transfers a day from one child to the other. The reader comes to suspect that Sachiko's story is Etsuko's, displaced onto another woman so that it can be told at all. A narrator tells another person's story that is her own guilt transposed, and her slips perform the work of the substitution shot in the day room, which transfers the chair from Sammy to Leonard.

6.7

Chronopartite Self-Deception

Self-deception has troubled philosophy because it seems to require a single person to be both deceiver and deceived. Sartre (*L'être et le néant*, 1943) held that bad faith requires the liar to know the truth he hides from himself, and rejected the Freudian censor as an explanation, since a censor that discriminates what to repress must know what it represses and is therefore itself in bad faith. Donald Davidson (1986) and David Pears (1984) proposed partitions of the mind into semi-autonomous structures. Alfred Mele (2001) formulated a static puzzle, how one person can simultaneously believe a proposition and its negation, and a dynamic puzzle, how a strategy of self-deception can succeed if the self-deceiver knows the strategy, and answered both deflationarily: self-deception requires no intention to deceive, only motivationally biased belief formation.

Leonard demonstrates that the strong, intentional form Mele declared unnecessary is possible under one condition: a partition in time. At no instant does any Leonard believe both that Teddy is John G and that he is not; the static puzzle dissolves. The strategy is known only to the deceiving interval, which ceases before the deceived

interval begins; the dynamic puzzle dissolves. Self-deception becomes interpersonal deception between temporally successive persons who share a body and a script. Formally: S deceives himself that *p* if and only if an interval S_1 who believes not-*p* acts with the intention that a later interval S_2 believe *p*; S_2 comes to believe *p* as a result; and S_1's belief and intention are inaccessible to S_2. Call this **chronopartite self-deception**. It suggests that ordinary self-deception is a weak form of Leonard's, using the ordinary forgetting produced by inattention, avoidance, and time as a soft amnesia. Leonard is the ideal limit of a common practice, and self-deception is revealed as constitutively diachronic: a relation between selves at different times that ordinary memory merely blurs.

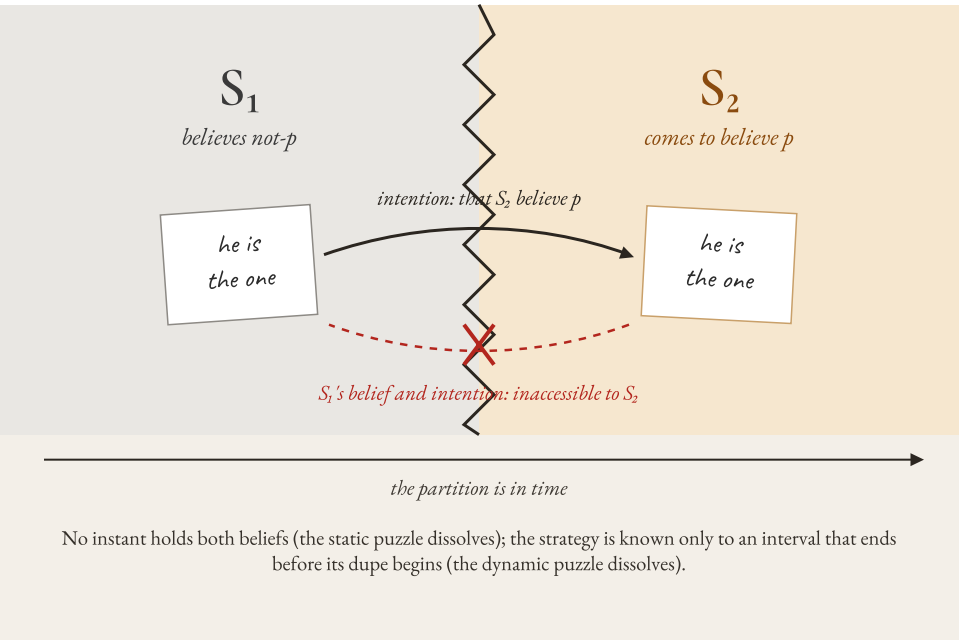


Figure 11. *Chronopartite self-deception: deceiver and deceived distributed across successive intervals of a single life.*

The junction scene states the procedure aloud. In voice-over, Leonard asks whether he can let himself forget what Teddy has told him and what he himself has done, and whether he will lie to himself to be happy; in Teddy's case, he concludes, he will. Teddy had already generalized the point: everyone lies to themselves to be happy. Pascal had said as much: "Les hommes n'ayant pu guérir la mort, la misère, l'ignorance, ils se sont avisés, pour se rendre heureux, de n'y point penser" (*Pensées*, Lafuma 133). Not having been able to cure death, misery, and ignorance, men have resolved, in order to be happy, not to think of them. Nietzsche's notebooks of 1888 add that we

have art so that we do not perish of the truth. Leonard's lie is not art. It is administration.

6.8
The Two-in-One

In the *Gorgias* (482b–c), Socrates declares that he would rather have his lyre out of tune, and the multitude disagree with him, than be out of harmony with himself, being one. Hannah Arendt made this the basis of her account of conscience. Thinking is the soundless dialogue of the two-in-one, and the person who thinks will not do wrong because he would then have to live together with a wrongdoer. Leonard's condition abolishes the two-in-one across time. He never has to live with the murderer he was, and the Socratic restraint has no purchase on him. Yet he constructs a written two-in-one, a dialogue between the self that writes notes and the self that reads them: a prosthetic conscience. At the junction he forges it, writing in the voice of conscience an instruction not to believe the one man who has told him the truth. In *Eichmann in Jerusalem* (1963), Arendt traced evil to thoughtlessness and to the protective clichés of officialese. Leonard's notes are the officialese of a self. Unlike Eichmann's, his thoughtlessness is engineered.

Heidegger's analysis of conscience in *Sein und Zeit* (1927, §§54–60) gives the prosthesis its ontology. The call of conscience, he argues, is not the voice of another but that of Dasein itself, summoned out of its absorption in the anonymous "they" (*das Man*) toward its own being-guilty; and yet it is not experienced as one's own voice: "Der Ruf kommt aus mir und doch über mich," the call comes from me and yet from beyond me (§57). Leonard's notes literalize the formula and corrupt it. They come from him, in his own hand, and from beyond him, from a self he cannot remember being. But where Heidegger's call summons Dasein back from *das Man* to its own-most guilt, Leonard's notes speak in the voice of *das Man*, impersonal, imperative, without a speaker, and they summon him away from his guilt toward someone else's. Heidegger's thrownness completes the picture: every interval is thrown into a situation it did not choose, and the notes are the only account it is given of how it came to be there. Hans Jonas, Heidegger's student, compared Gnosticism and existentialism in an essay later appended to *The Gnostic Religion*, finding in both a self thrown into an alien world and awakened by a call (7.6). Leonard stands where the two coincide and both fail. The call is his own, as in Heidegger; it arrives as a letter, as in the Gnostic myth; and in both forms it is forged.

6.9

The Memory of the Offense

Primo Levi opened *I sommersi e i salvati* (1986) with a chapter on the memory of the offense. Memory is unreliable in victims and perpetrators alike, and the perpetrator, beginning with a lie told to others, ends by believing it: through repetition the distinction between true and false wears away until the liar has become sincere. Leonard is Levi's perpetrator accelerated. A lie written once is believed by the next interval, and sincerity is achieved in minutes rather than years. Under H_1 he is a perpetrator who has made himself a victim; under H_2, a victim who has made himself a perpetrator, of Jimmy and of Teddy. Under either, Levi's grey zone is his habitat.

6.10

The Buried Experimentalist

One figure in *Memento* conducts a controlled experiment. Under H_1 it is Catherine Shelby, who, doubting the reality of her husband's condition, tests it by asking for her insulin again and again to see whether he will remember. Under H_2 it is Mrs. Jankis, who designs the same test. Either way, a woman in the film formulates a hypothesis and tests it by intervention, with her own body as the instrument and at the cost of her life. Natalie is the film's second experimentalist. She tests Leonard's amnesia with a contaminated glass of beer, and the limits of his record by removing every pen. The men of *Memento*, Leonard, Teddy, the clerk, Dodd, operate on documents, testimony, and inscriptions. The women operate on experiments.

This reverses the most obvious feminist objection to the film. Catherine appears to be the paradigmatic instance of what Gail Simone named, in 1999, the woman in the refrigerator: a female character killed to motivate a male hero. On closer reading she is the film's buried epistemologist, and her experiment is its suppressed ideal of knowledge, the only procedure in its world that could have settled a question by evidence rather than by authority. She is the film's true Oedipus, the one who pursues the truth at any cost and dies of it. Under H_1, Leonard's vengeance is the revenge of the documentary against the experimental: the man who could not pass her test kills, in perpetuity, substitutes for the examiner.

6.11
The Closing Creed

The film's final monologue is Leonard's creed. Driving with his eyes closed, he affirms that he must believe in a world outside his own mind; that his actions still have meaning even if he cannot remember them; that the world is still there when his eyes are shut; that everyone needs mirrors to remind themselves who they are, and that he is no different. Then he opens his eyes outside the tattoo parlor and asks where he was.

Four observations follow. First, the content of the creed is true. Realism about the external world and about action is the correct philosophy, against the phenomenalism of Tolstoy's divan (1.7). Second, its function is a lie. It is spoken to sanctify a decision to deceive, a true proposition used as an instrument of deception in the manner of Yudhiṣṭhira's sentence about Aśvatthāman (4.7). Third, its form is fideist. Descartes needed God to guarantee the persistence of the world and the reliability of remembered demonstration (3.8); Leonard substitutes belief in the world, a secular leap of faith. Albert Camus, in *Le Mythe de Sisyphe* (1942), condemned such leaps, in Kierkegaard, Jaspers, and Chestov, as philosophical suicide, an escape from the absurd into hope. Leonard's leap is philosophical suicide committed in order to facilitate homicide. Camus's Sisyphus is happy in the lucidity of his descent, the hour of consciousness in which he walks back down to his rock. Leonard, offered that hour by Teddy, chooses to forget the mountain. Fourth, the creed completes the paradox of the experience machine (3.6). It proclaims that actions matter beyond experience, and it is spoken at the very moment its speaker designs, for his successor, an experience: the hunt for Teddy. The creed of realism is the inaugural address of an experience machine.

The mirror at its close is not decorative. Leonard reads his chest in mirrors, because the inscription is reversed to be read there. The self that everyone needs mirrors to recall is, in his case, a text addressed to its own reflection. The creed's final image restates the whole system: identity is a sentence one must read backwards in order to read it forwards. Kierkegaard's dictum has been written on a man's skin.


ΓΗΣ ΠΑΙΣ ΕΙΜΙ ΚΑΙ ΟΥΡΑΝΟΥ
ΑΣΤΕΡΟΕΝΤΟΣ
ΔΙΨΗΙ Δ ΕΙΜ ΑΥΟΣ ΚΑΙ ΑΠΟΛΛΥΜΑΙ
ΛΗΘΗ
ΜΝΗΜΟΣΥΝΗ

CHAPTER

VII

Letters to the Forgetful Soul

A Comparative Mythopoetics of Amnesia

7.1 Mnemosyne and Her Daughters 103
7.2 Ameles and the Tyrant's Choice 104
7.3 Meno's Paradox Solved by Decree 104
7.4 The Noble Lie as False Memory 105
7.5 The Orphic Gold Leaves 105
7.6 The Hymn of the Pearl 106
7.7 Thoth and the Heart Scarab 107
7.8 Odin: Ravens, Well, and Runes 108
7.9 Odysseus: Lotus, Sirens, Scar, and Web 109
7.10 Gilgamesh: The Loaves of Utnapishtim 110
7.11 Śakuntalā's Ring 111
7.12 The Lethean Archetype and Its Heresy 111

7.1 Mnemosyne and Her Daughters

Hesiod's *Theogony* records that Mnemosyne, joined with Zeus in Pieria, bore the Muses to be a forgetting of evils and a rest from cares (55). The poem later explains the gift: when a man has grief in his newly troubled heart and is withered with sorrow, and a singer, servant of the Muses, sings the glories of former men and of the gods, at once he forgets his heaviness and remembers none of his cares (98–103). The daughters of Memory bring forgetting. Art is memory's child, and its gift is the oblivion of pain through the form that memory takes in song.

Leonard possesses the mother without the daughters: memory of the wound without art's gift of forgetting. His notes are a poem on a single theme, composed by a poet who cannot hear it. The film, by contrast, is a work of the Muses. It holds Leonard's memory whole and administers through form the forgetting of evils he is denied: catharsis in Aristotle's sense, the purgation of pity and fear through their rep-

resentation. What Leonard cannot receive from Mnemosyne's daughters, the spectator receives in his place.

7.2
Ameles and the Tyrant's Choice

At the close of the *Republic*, Er the Pamphylian, killed in battle, revives on his funeral pyre and reports what the dead undergo (614b–621d). The souls choose their next lives; then, through terrible heat, they march to the plain of Lethe and camp beside the river Ameles, Unmindfulness, whose water no vessel can hold (621a). All must drink a measure, and those not saved by wisdom drink more than the measure; each who drinks forgets everything. Er alone is forbidden to drink, and returns to tell. The river whose water no vessel can hold is the perforated jar of the *Gorgias* (5.8) turned into geography. Leonard drank at Ameles on the threshold of his second life. The spectator is Er: the one who does not drink and returns to tell.

The same myth contains a warning that fits the junction with uncanny precision. The first soul to choose had lived its previous life in a well-ordered city, sharing in virtue by habit without philosophy. It seizes the greatest tyranny greedily, without examination, and discovers only afterward that this life includes, among other evils, the devouring of its own children (619b–d). Habit without philosophy leads to the choice of tyranny. Leonard's decision at the junction is made by the habit of vengeance, without the philosophy his condition forecloses, and it is a choice of tyranny over his successors. The hypomnesic sovereign who rules his future selves is Plato's tyrant devouring his own children.

7.3
Meno's Paradox Solved by Decree

In the *Meno* (80d–e), Meno asks how one can search for something of which one knows nothing at all. What would one set up as the object of the search? And if one should happen upon it, how would one know that this is the thing one did not know? Socrates restates the eristic argument: one can search neither for what one knows, since one knows it, nor for what one does not know, since one would not know what to look for. His answer is anamnesis. The soul, being immortal, has learned everything, and learning is recollection.

Leonard is Meno's paradox incarnate. He searches for a man he does not know. If he finds him, he cannot recognize that he has found him. And if, as Teddy says, he found him a year ago, he cannot know that he did. Socrates' solution, recollection, is precisely what is closed to Leonard. His substitute, inscription, yields not recognition but stipulation: since he cannot know when he has found John G, he decides who John G is. The paradox of inquiry is solved by decree. That is the hypomnesic solution to Meno's problem, and it is the definition of sovereignty.

There is a further Platonic irony. For Plato all genuine knowledge is prenatal, recollected from before birth. Leonard's knowledge is prenatal in a displaced sense: everything he knows, he knew before his second birth at the injury. He lives anamnetically. But the forms he recollects are not the Just and the Beautiful; they are a bathroom, a shower curtain, a face beneath plastic.

7.4

The Noble Lie as False Memory

The founding myth of the *Republic*'s city is a deliberate falsehood, the noble lie (*gennaion pseudos*, 414b–415d). Socrates proposes, with evident reluctance, that the citizens be persuaded that their rearing and education were like a dream, that in truth they were being fashioned beneath the earth, which sent them up when they were complete, and that the god mixed gold, silver, bronze, and iron into their souls. The first clause is rarely remarked. The noble lie is a falsification of memory: the citizens are to be told that what they remember of their upbringing was a dream.

Leonard's junction is a noble lie told by a sovereign to the citizens of his own city. What you remember, Teddy's revelation, was a dream, for it will not be remembered; you were formed by the earth, by the facts on your skin; and the metal in your soul is vengeance. Plato understood that the founding of a just city requires a managed memory. *Memento* shows a self founded in the same way and draws the conclusion Plato avoided: the noble lie is noble only if its author is just, and nothing in its structure guarantees that.

7.5

The Orphic Gold Leaves

From the late fifth century BCE onward, initiates in southern Italy, Thessaly, and Crete were buried with thin gold tablets inscribed with instructions for the journey of

the dead. The tablet from Hipponion (c. 400 BCE) and its relatives from Petelia and elsewhere tell the soul that in the house of Hades it will find a spring with a white cypress beside it, where the souls of the dead go down to cool themselves, and that it must not approach that spring. Further on it will find cold water flowing from the lake of Memory, with guardians before it. To them it must say: I am a child of Earth and starry Heaven; I am parched with thirst and perishing; give me quickly cold water flowing from the lake of Memory. Then the guardians will let it drink, and it will go the sacred way of the initiates. The Hipponion tablet, found in a woman's grave, opens by consecrating itself to Memory. The tablets do not agree with one another. On the Petelia and Hipponion tablets the spring by the white cypress is the one to shun; on a tablet now in the Getty Museum, the thirsty soul is invited to drink from an ever-flowing spring on the right, where a cypress stands. And none of them, despite the modern label, mentions Orpheus.

The gold leaf is a *hypomnema* for the afterlife: a text prepared in life for a soul that will have forgotten, telling it which water to drink, which to shun, and what password to speak to the guardians. Leonard's notes are gold leaves. They instruct a self that will wake in an underworld of forgetting, telling it what to trust, what to avoid, and what to say. The difference is decisive. The gold leaves were composed by a tradition and placed with the dead by others; Leonard's are composed by the dead man for himself. He is his own mystagogue. The disagreement among the tablets sharpens the point: an inscription's authority over a forgetting reader extends no further than the hand that wrote that particular copy, and a soul buried with the wrong tablet would have drunk from the wrong spring. The white cypress beside the spring of forgetting rhymes across two millennia with the cypress in Tasso's forest from which Clorinda's voice cries out (6.3). In both, the tree of the dead stands where memory is lost and accusation begins.

7.6
The Hymn of the Pearl

The *Acts of Thomas*, a third-century Syriac work, preserves the poem known as the Hymn of the Pearl, which some scholars think older than the Acts themselves. A prince of the East is sent by his parents down to Egypt to bring back the one pearl lying in the midst of the sea, guarded by a devouring serpent. Before he leaves they strip him of his glorious robe and write a covenant in his heart so that he will not forget. In Egypt he puts on Egyptian clothing to avoid suspicion and eats their food; he

forgets that he is a king's son, serves their king, forgets the pearl, and sinks into a deep sleep. His parents write him a letter sealed with the king's right hand. It flies like an eagle, alights beside him, and becomes speech. He wakes, remembers that he is a son of kings, remembers the pearl, charms the serpent to sleep by naming his father's name, seizes the pearl, strips off the soiled garments, and sets out for home with the letter shining before him as a guide. At the border his robe comes to meet him, and he sees it as a mirror of himself: two in distinction and yet one in likeness.

Hans Jonas's *The Gnostic Religion* (1958) made this poem a key to the Gnostic myth: the soul is a stranger in the world, numbed by its food, sunk in sleep and intoxication, and awakened by a call from beyond. Every element recurs in *Memento*. The world's food is Lethe. The covenant written in the heart does not simply fail. It falls silent, and then it becomes the test by which the letter is recognized: the prince reads the letter and finds its words agreeing with what was traced on his heart. The letter is also sealed with the king's own right hand to keep it from the wicked. Its authenticity is secured twice, by a seal against forgery and by agreement with an inner text. The serpent is John G. And the return ends in a mirror, as Leonard's creed does. One element is decisively altered. In the Hymn the letter comes from the Father above; Leonard's letter comes from himself. It has neither of the Hymn's safeguards. No seal keeps it from other hands, and no text on his heart can confirm it, since the only inscription over his heart is itself one of the letters. Leonard is a Gnostic who forges his own revelation: autognosis as forgery. There is no Pleroma and no Father, only an earlier self that has become, by default, the demiurge and archon of its successors' world. *Memento* is Gnosticism without transcendence, the call issuing from within time.

7.7
Thoth and the Heart Scarab

Thoth, whom Plato calls Theuth, is the Egyptian god of writing, scribe of the gods, and recorder at the judgment of the dead. In Spell 125 of the Book of the Dead, the deceased, entering the Hall of the Two Truths, recites before the divine assessors a declaration of innocence, often called the negative confession: I have not done wrong; I have not killed; I have not commanded to kill. The heart is then weighed against the feather of Maat while the Devourer waits and Thoth records the verdict. Spell 30B was inscribed on heart scarabs laid upon the chest of the mummy: O my heart of my mother, O my heart of my different ages, do not stand up against me as a witness, do

not oppose me in the tribunal, do not be hostile to me before the Keeper of the Balance.

The heart scarab is an inscription laid over the heart whose function is to forbid the heart to testify against its owner. The spell, attested on heart scarabs from as early as the Thirteenth Dynasty and titled a chapter for preventing the heart of the deceased from creating opposition to him, was also meant to stand in for the heart should it be damaged. It addresses the heart of the speaker's different ages, the self that persists across the stages of a life, and asks it to keep silent at the weighing. The inscription replaces the organ of testimony. Leonard's chest inscription is a heart scarab. It lies over his heart and, by naming the guilty party, prevents his heart from testifying at the weighing; under H_1 it does so by joining an accusation that is true of the intruders to one that is true of Leonard himself (4.7). The story of Sammy is his negative confession, a ritual declaration of innocence recited to strangers as the dead recited theirs to the assessors. Egyptian funerary religion invented for the dead the technology Leonard invents for the living: written scripts that preempt the testimony of memory.

7.8
Odin: Ravens, Well, and Runes

In the *Grímnismál*, Odin says of his two ravens: Huginn and Muninn fly every day over the wide earth; I fear for Huginn, that he may not come back, but I fear more for Muninn (20). Huginn is Thought; Muninn is Memory. Leonard's Muninn has not returned since the attack, and his Huginn flies every day and returns with nothing it can keep. In the *Völuspá* and in Snorri's *Gylfaginning*, Odin pledges an eye for a drink from the well of Mímir, whose name is commonly connected with memory. He sacrifices sight for memory. At the junction Leonard does the reverse: he sacrifices memory, of the revelation, for the sight of a target.

The *Hávamál* preserves the most extraordinary image of self-sacrifice in Germanic tradition: I know that I hung on the windswept tree nine whole nights, wounded with a spear and given to Odin, myself to myself, on that tree of which no man knows from what roots it runs. With no loaf they comforted me, nor with any horn; I peered below, I took up the runes, took them up screaming; back I fell from there (138–139; my translation from the Old Norse). Odin's sacrifice of himself to himself to obtain writing is the mythic prototype of Leonard's self-wounding to obtain inscription. The tattoo needle is the spear; the body is given to the self, myself to myself; and the

reward is a script. The verb that takes up the runes, *nam*, is the verb with which, one stanza later, Odin learns nine mighty songs: in Old Norse, to take up a script and to learn it are one word. Leonard takes up his script without learning it, and each interval must take it up again. In Norse tradition the runes are also spells and lots: writing as binding and as fate. Leonard's runes bind his successors to a fate he has written.

7.9
Odysseus: Lotus, Sirens, Scar, and Web

The *Odyssey* contains most of the elements of Leonard's predicament. Those who eat the lotus forget the homeward journey and wish only to stay; Odysseus drags his weeping men back to the ships and binds them beneath the benches (9.82–104). Leonard is a lotus-eater with a *nostos* tattooed on him. He has forgotten every recent day but remembers the mission, and his home is not a place but a deed. Passing the Sirens, Odysseus has himself bound to the mast so that he may hear the song without obeying it (12.39–54, 158–200). Jon Elster made the episode the emblem of precommitment, the binding of one's future self against foreseen weakness. Leonard's tattoos are ropes, but at the junction he binds his future self to the Sirens rather than against them. He is Ulysses tying himself to the song.

When Eurycleia washes the stranger's feet, she recognizes Odysseus by the scar a boar gave him in his youth, and Homer pauses to narrate the boar hunt on Parnassus and the naming of the child by his grandfather Autolycus (19.386–475). Erich Auerbach's "Odysseus' Scar," the first chapter of *Mimesis* (1946), took this digression as the emblem of Homeric style, in which everything is externalized in a uniformly lit foreground, and contrasted it with biblical narrative, fraught with background. Leonard's scars are text without background: all foreground, inscriptions whose origin, who wrote them and why, has been lost. *Memento* supplies the Homeric digression in reverse; each scene is the story of a scar, told after the scar has been shown.

Penelope promises the suitors that she will choose among them when she has finished weaving a shroud for Laertes, her husband's father. She weaves by day and unweaves by night for three years, until a maid betrays her (2.93–110; 19.137–156; 24.128–148). The shroud is a funeral garment, the work of mourning for a father not yet dead, endlessly undone so that its completion may be deferred. Leonard's vengeance is a shroud for Catherine, woven in every interval and unwoven by every reset. At the junction he becomes Penelope in the strict sense: he unweaves deliberately, burning the photographs, to defer a completion he cannot bear. Penelope unweaves

to preserve her fidelity; Leonard unweaves to preserve his purpose. Penelope's ruse is betrayed by a maid; Leonard's is exposed by Teddy, whom he therefore marks for death. It is fitting that Nolan's filmography should eventually have turned to the *Odyssey* itself.

Ovid's Echo, cursed to repeat only the final words of others, and Narcissus, who loves his own reflection, meet in the *Metamorphoses* and cannot unite (III.339–510). In Leonard they are one man: Echo, repeating the final words of his predecessor's notes, and Narcissus, reading his chest in the mirror. The underworld's punished complete the catalogue: Prometheus's wound renewed each day (4.1), Sisyphus's labor resumed at every summit (6.11), the Danaids' jar that never fills (5.8), and the satisfaction that recedes from Tantalus's reaching hand.

7.10
Gilgamesh: The Loaves of Utnapishtim

The Standard Babylonian epic of Gilgamesh opens by inviting the reader to find the tablet-box of cedar, release its bronze clasp, and read the tablet of lapis lazuli on which the hero's ordeals are written. The hero's life is offered as a text to be retrieved and read by another. After the death of Enkidu, Gilgamesh refuses to surrender his friend for burial until a maggot falls from his nostril, and then roams the wilderness in skins: the refusal of mourning made into a journey (Tablet X). At the edge of the world he reaches Utnapishtim, survivor of the Flood, who challenges him to stay awake for six days and seven nights. Gilgamesh falls asleep at once. Utnapishtim's wife bakes a loaf for each day he sleeps and sets it by his head. When Gilgamesh wakes and insists he has barely dozed, Utnapishtim shows him the loaves, the first hard, the second like leather, the third soggy, the fourth and fifth moldering, the sixth fresh, the seventh still on the embers, so that the bread proves the time he denies (Tablet XI). Utnapishtim has ordered the loaves, and a mark on the wall for each day, because, he tells his wife, men are deceivers and Gilgamesh will try to deceive her: the bread and the tally are evidence prepared in advance against a self-report expected to be false. They are inscriptions made for the sleeper by others, and they tell the truth against him; Leonard's are made by himself, for himself, and need not.

The loaves are the oldest Polaroids in literature: evidence of elapsed time, prepared by another, for a man who cannot feel time pass. Gilgamesh then loses the gift of renewal while his attention is elsewhere, when a serpent steals the plant of rejuvenation as he bathes. Leonard too loses what would restore him while his attention is

elsewhere, and a serpent waits at the end of his story as at the end of the prince's journey in the Hymn of the Pearl.

7.11
Śakuntalā's Ring

Kālidāsa's *Abhijñānaśākuntalam*, The Recognition of Śakuntalā, turns on a token. King Duṣyanta marries Śakuntalā in a forest hermitage, gives her his signet ring, and returns to his capital. The irascible sage Durvāsas, slighted by the distracted girl, curses her: the one she is thinking of will forget her. He then softens the curse so that it will end when the king sees a token of recognition. Śakuntalā loses the ring while bathing; the king fails to recognize her and repudiates her; a fisherman later finds the ring in the belly of a fish; and the king sees it, remembers, and is consumed by remorse. The play's title names the token, *abhijñāna*. The species of recognition Aristotle ranks lowest is the summit of Sanskrit drama. The ring is a prosthetic memory whose loss produces repudiation and whose return produces anguish. Leonard's Polaroids are signet rings, and Teddy's revelation is the fish's belly from which the ring returns. Leonard throws it back into the water.

7.12
The Lethean Archetype and Its Heresy

Across these traditions a single configuration recurs. A soul in exile or in the underworld forgets, and a text or token prepared in advance restores it to its mission, its name, or its beloved. The gold leaves, the Pearl's letter, the heart scarab, Odin's runes, Utnapishtim's loaves, and Śakuntalā's ring are its instances. Call this the **Lethean archetype**. In every canonical version the restoring text comes from outside the forgetting soul: from a god, a tradition, a father, a beloved, a sage. Its authority is guaranteed by that exteriority. *Memento*'s heresy is to make the forgetting soul the author of its own salvific text, and in doing so it abolishes the guarantee. A letter one writes to oneself across Lethe has no authority but that of the self whose unreliability made the letter necessary. Leonard is the Lethean archetype secularized, and thereby damned: the soul as its own mystagogue, demiurge, and archon.

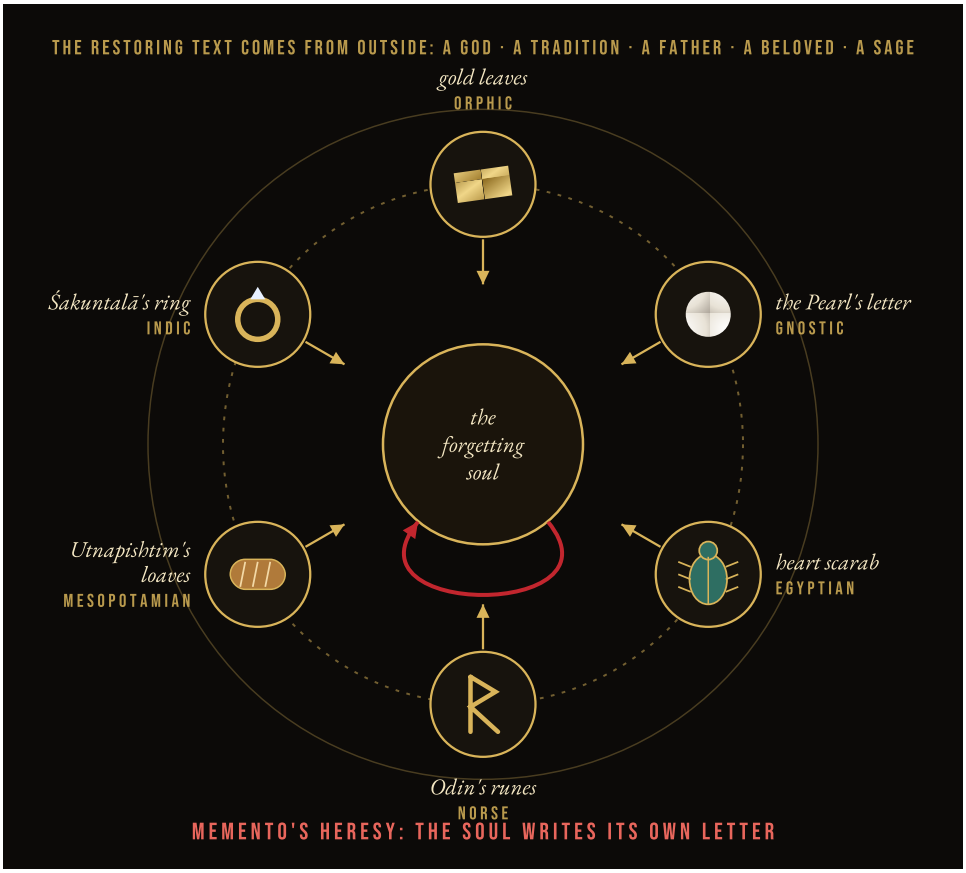
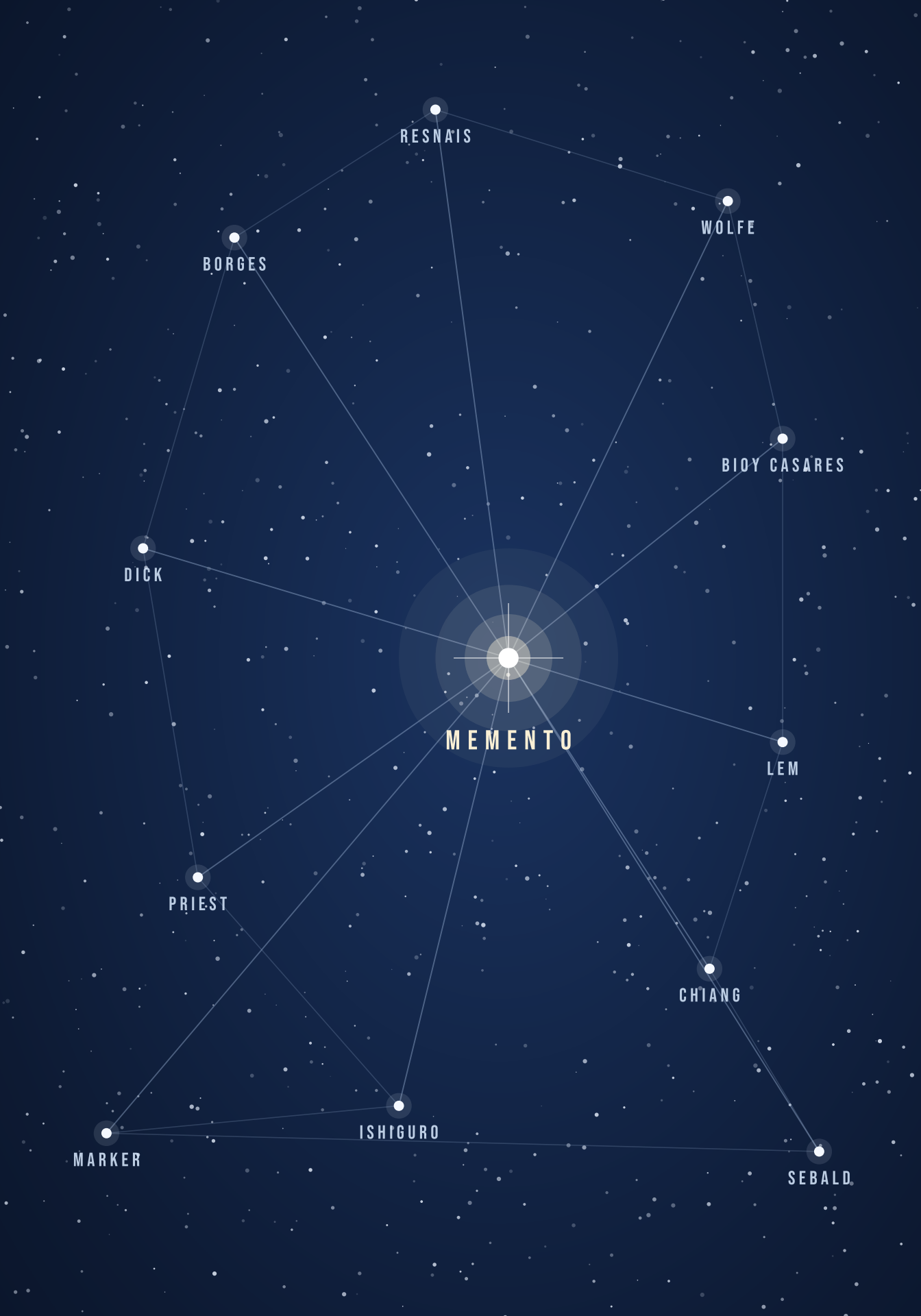


Figure 12. *The Lethean archetype. In every canonical version the restoring text comes from outside the forgetting soul; Memento makes the soul the author of its own letter.*




RESNAIS
WOLFE
BORGES
BIOY CASARES
DICK
MEMENTO
LEM
PRIEST
CHIANG
ISHIGURO
MARKER
SEBALD

CHAPTER

VIII

Speculative Kin

Memento Among the Fictions of Memory

8.1 Borges: The Labyrinth of the Self-Designed Clue 115

8.2 Gene Wolfe: Latro and Severian 118

8.3 Philip K. Dick: The Message From One's Former Self 119

8.4 Bioy Casares: The Machine That Kills What It Records 120

8.5 Lem: The Visitor Made of Memory 120

8.6 Christopher Priest: The Self Rebuilt From Fiction 121

8.7 Ted Chiang: Record, Feeling, and Foreknowledge 121

8.8 Ishiguro: Forgetting, Peace, and War 122

8.9 Sebald, Resnais, Marker: The Archive and the Face 123

8.10 The Noir Matrix and Its Descendants 124

8.11 Nolan's Oeuvre: Variations on Hypomnesic Sovereignty 125

The constellational method (0.4) arrays works around *Memento* so that each illuminates what the others conceal. They are grouped here not by date or medium but by the problem each shares with the film.

8.1
Borges: The Labyrinth of the Self-Designed Clue

In "Funes el memorioso" (1942), Ireneo Funes, thrown by a half-tamed horse and crippled, wakes with infallible perception and memory. He can reconstruct an entire day, though the reconstruction takes a whole day. He is troubled that the generic word *dog* covers both the animal seen at 3:14 in profile and the same animal seen at 3:15 from the front. The narrator suspects that Funes is incapable of thought, since thinking requires forgetting differences, generalizing, abstracting. Funes dies young of pul-

monary congestion. Nolan has acknowledged the debt, calling his film a strange cousin of Borges's story and a kind of inversion of it. He and Leonard are the two poles of a single catastrophe. A fall gives Funes total memory; a blow takes from Leonard all new memory. Both are confined to particulars, Funes to those of the past and Leonard to those of the present, and neither can generalize: Funes because nothing is forgotten, Leonard because nothing accumulates. Leonard's facts, white, male, John or James, are generalizations by fiat, the crude abstractions of a mind that cannot abstract from experience and must abstract by decree.

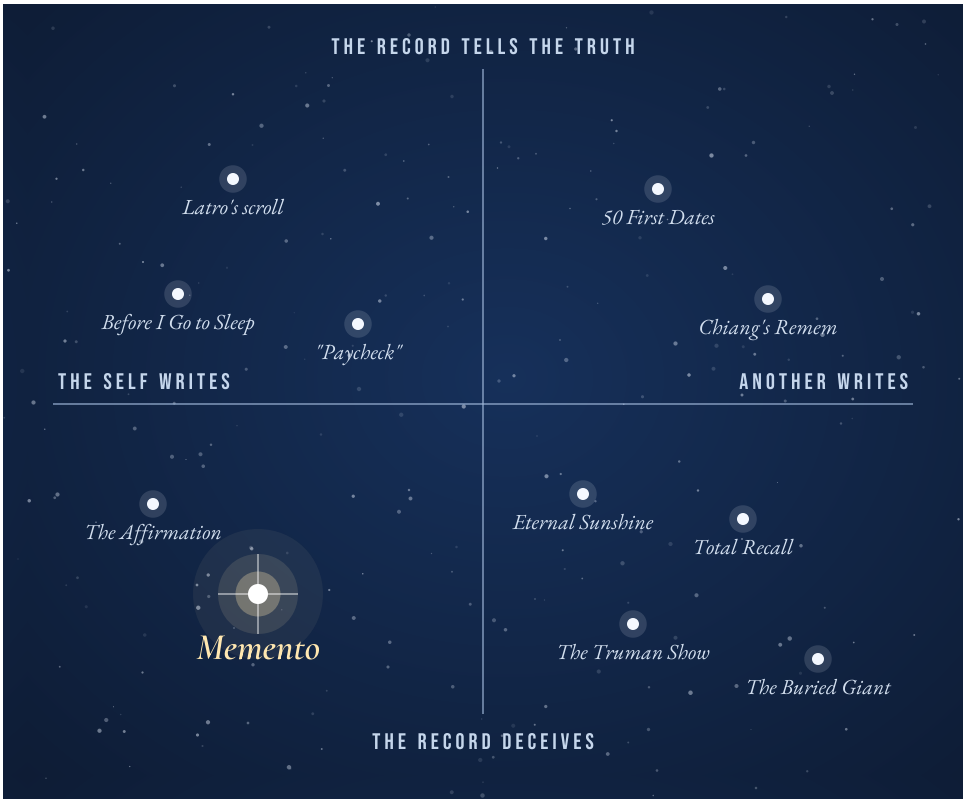


Figure 13. *Speculative kin, placed schematically by who writes the record and whether the record tells the truth, following the readings in this chapter.*

In "Tlön, Uqbar, Orbis Tertius" (1940), a secret society invents a planet in the pages of an encyclopedia, and the invented world gradually displaces the real one. In Tlön's idealist metaphysics, lost objects are duplicated by those who search for them; these duplicates, the *hrönir*, are produced by expectation. Two people looking for the same lost pencil each find one, and prisoners promised their freedom if they unearth bur-

ied objects duly unearth them. John G. is a *hrön*. He is produced by the expectation of the searcher, and he multiplies as the search continues: Jimmy, Teddy, and those still to come. Borges calls the first *hrönir* the accidental children of distraction and forgetfulness, and adds that *hrönir* derived from other *hrönir* exaggerate the aberrations of the first. John G. is a child of forgetting, and each successor drifts further from the original: Jimmy is a *hrön* of the assailant, Teddy a *hrön* of Jimmy. Call this the **hrön of vengeance**. Tlön's inhabitants conceive the universe not as a concurrence of objects in space but as a heterogeneous series of independent acts, which is how Leonard's intervals present the world to him, and Leonard's notes are a volume of the Tlön encyclopedia, a document that replaces the world it claims to describe.

In "La muerte y la brújula" (1942), the detective Erik Lönnrot, a pure reasoner, deduces from a series of murders a cabbalistic pattern that predicts a fourth crime at a determinate place and time. The pattern was planted by his enemy Red Scharlach, avenging his brother's arrest, precisely to lure the reasoner to the villa where Scharlach waits to kill him. Facing death, Lönnrot proposes for their next encounter a labyrinth consisting of a single straight line. At the junction Leonard is Scharlach, composing the clues; afterwards he is Lönnrot, the reasoner who will follow them. Borges's detective is killed by the rationality turned against him; Leonard's detective kills by it. Scharlach's motive, like Leonard's, is vengeance, and its method is the weaponization of the detective's method. Scharlach's design began with a death he had not planned: the first victim was killed in a robbery gone wrong, and Scharlach built his pattern outward from that accident, as Leonard, under H_1, makes an unintended death the first term of a designed series. And Scharlach meets the vengeance he planned so long with a weary indifference: completion brings no satisfaction even to an avenger who will remember it (5.8).

In "El jardín de senderos que se bifurcan" (1941), Yu Tsun, a spy for Germany, murders the sinologist Stephen Albert so that newspapers will print the name Albert, communicating to his chief in Berlin the name of the town to be bombed. The murder is a message, a homicidal inscription. Leonard's killings are likewise messages, addressed to his successor; the corpse is a sign whose referent only its author knew. In "Las ruinas circulares" (1940), a man dreams another man into being and, walking unburned into fire, understands that he too is dreamt. Leonard dreams John Gs into being and learns from Teddy that he too has been dreamt into a role in another man's plan. In "Pierre Menard, autor del Quijote" (1939), a modern writer composes chapters word for word identical with Cervantes', and the narrator argues that the identical text is richer and more ambiguous because its author and moment differ.

Leonard's notes are Menard texts: the same words mean differently when written by the interval that knows and read by the interval that does not. And in "Borges y yo" (1960) the speaker confesses that he does not know which of the two, the man or the writer, has written the page. Neither does Leonard.

Borges's Italian heir, Italo Calvino, supplies the urban form of the same predicament. In *Le città invisibili* (1972), Zora is a city whose every detail can be committed to memory, and which, obliged to remain motionless and unchanged so as to be remembered more easily, languished, crumbled, and vanished. Leonard is a Zora: a self held motionless at the moment of the attack so that it can be remembered, and wasting for that reason.

8.2
Gene Wolfe: Latro and Severian

Gene Wolfe's *Soldier of the Mist* (1986), with its sequels *Soldier of Arete* (1989) and *Soldier of Sidon* (2006), is *Memento*'s most exact antecedent in speculative fiction. Latro, a mercenary from Italy serving in the Persian army, receives a head wound at Plataea in 479 BCE and thereafter forgets each day by the next. A physician tells him to record each day's events on a scroll, and the novels are presented as translations of that scroll. The wound also lets him see the gods. The reader occupies the position of tomorrow's Latro, reconstructing a self from a document, which is exactly the position *Memento* assigns its spectator. Latro is guileless, loyal to those who treat him kindly, and easily used. His scroll is honest, and it is also protected: he writes it in his native Latin, a language almost no one around him can read, so that the scroll enjoys by accident of language the authorial closure Leonard's notes lack (4.5). Its outside carries an injunction to read it every day, the counterpart of the instruction on Leonard's hand. And Latro's wound is a punishment from the gods, which he is told will be healed only if he obtains the Great Mother's forgiveness: in Wolfe's world, memory returns through forgiveness. Leonard's wound admits no forgiveness, because no one remains to grant it or to receive it (5.8). What *Memento* adds is the dishonest scroll.

Wolfe's earlier tetralogy, *The Book of the New Sun* (1980–83), is narrated by Severian, an apprentice torturer who claims to forget nothing. His perfect memory makes him no more reliable: he conceals, misleads, and omits. Wolfe's two narrators bracket Leonard. Severian proves that perfect memory does not produce honesty; Latro proves that the absence of memory does not preclude it. Honesty is a function not of

memory but of the will that writes, and Leonard demonstrates the same proposition from the other side.

8.3
Philip K. Dick: The Message From One's Former Self

Dick's "Paycheck" (1953) is *Memento*'s angelic double. Jennings, an engineer, contracts to work for two years and to have his memory of the work erased. At the end he finds that he has forfeited his pay in exchange for an envelope of seven trinkets he chose himself, among them a code key, a ticket stub and half a poker chip, each of which proves to be exactly what his later self will need, because the earlier self had glimpsed the future in the machine he was building. Each rescues him at a precise moment, because his former self, having glimpsed the future, equipped his amnesiac successor for it. The benevolent past self who arms the future self is the inverse of the junction.

"We Can Remember It for You Wholesale" (1966) and Paul Verhoeven's *Total Recall* (1990) turn the structure toward manipulation. In the film, Quaid receives a recording from his former self, Hauser, instructing him what to do; a later recording reveals that Hauser served the villain and that the entire adventure was engineered to use Quaid as an unwitting instrument. The message from one's past self is a trap. Quaid then chooses to remain Quaid rather than revert to Hauser, preferring the constructed self to the original. Leonard makes the same formal choice with the moral sign reversed. Quaid rejects his past self's plan in favor of a better fiction; Leonard imposes his present self's plan on his future self in favor of a worse one.

A Scanner Darkly (1977) supplies the institutional version. Bob Arctor, an undercover narcotics agent, is assigned to surveil himself. The drug he takes to sustain his cover splits his hemispheres, and his ruined self is consigned to a rehabilitation program which, as his superiors knew, grows the drug, so that the agency uses his destroyed identity as an instrument to penetrate the supply. Teddy, the undercover officer who uses an amnesiac to kill a dealer and take his money, belongs to Dick's world. In *VALIS* (1981), Dick's late gnosis treats human existence as amnesia under the rule of archons and salvation as anamnesis, linking the Hymn of the Pearl (7.6) to the paranoid twentieth century.

8.4

Bioy Casares: The Machine That Kills What It Records

Adolfo Bioy Casares's *La invención de Morel* (1940), whose plot Borges praised in his prologue as perfect, strands a fugitive on an island where a company of people repeat the actions of the same week over and over. They are recordings, projected by a machine their host built, and the recording killed them. The fugitive falls in love with the image of a woman, Faustine, and records himself into the projection beside her, dying in the process, so that he may accompany her forever. Leonard's life is a Morel loop: the week of Catherine's death replayed without end, a projection he enters at the cost of every self that enters it. And Morel's machine kills those it records, as Leonard's camera marks for death those it photographs. Morel's apparatus immortalizes in order to kill; Leonard's photographs in order to execute.

8.5

Lem: The Visitor Made of Memory

In Stanisław Lem's *Solaris* (1961), the ocean of an alien planet materializes visitors drawn from the memories of the scientists on the orbiting station. Kris Kelvin's visitor is Harey, the wife who killed herself ten years earlier, after a quarrel between them. Kelvin's first response is to launch the visitor into space; the next day a second visitor arrives, with no memory of what was done to the first. The visitors succeed one another as Leonard's intervals do, each unaware of its predecessor's fate. Formed from his memories, she cannot remember her own past; discovering that she is a copy, she attempts suicide again and regenerates. Guilt over a wife's death, the wife reconstituted from memory, the repetition of her death, the impossibility of her remaining dead: this is the iconography of Leonard's flashes. The Catherine of those flashes is a Solarian visitor, a reconstruction that repeats her death with variations. Under H_1 she died of his doing, and he resurrects her at every interval in order to avenge her. The visitor is an accuser who does not know that she accuses. Andrei Tarkovsky's adaptation (1972) ends with Kelvin kneeling before his father at the family dacha, which the camera reveals to be an island formed by the ocean: home as a projection of memory. Leonard's home is an island of the same kind.

8.6
Christopher Priest: The Self Rebuilt From Fiction

Christopher Priest's *The Affirmation* (1981) is the closest literary precedent for the logic of the Sammy narrative. After a personal collapse, Peter Sinclair writes an autobiography transposed into an invented world. In a parallel narrative set in that world, Sinclair receives a treatment conferring immortality that erases his memory, and his manuscript, which presents London as fiction, is used to rebuild his identity. A self is reconstructed from its own fictionalized account, and the fiction becomes the life. The clinic intends to rebuild him from a detailed questionnaire; Sinclair tells the staff there is no need, because he has already written his autobiography. He chooses his own fiction over the institution's record, as Leonard prefers his notes to any record kept by others. Priest also wrote *The Prestige* (1995), which Nolan adapted in 2006. Its rival magicians read each other's diaries, and each diary is written to deceive its reader; in the film, an encoded diary sends its rival on a false errand across a continent. Diaries become instruments of deception addressed to an adversary, as Leonard's notes become when their reader is treated as one. The film's magician who duplicates himself every night, while one copy drowns in a tank beneath the stage, provides the emblem of Leonard's intervals. Each reset Leonard is the man in the box, whose disappearance makes the trick possible, while the audience sees only the reappearance of a Leonard who seems continuous.

8.7
Ted Chiang: Record, Feeling, and Foreknowledge

Ted Chiang's "The Truth of Fact, the Truth of Feeling" (2013) interleaves two narratives. A journalist evaluating software that can retrieve video of any moment of one's past discovers that his cherished memory of a quarrel with his daughter is false: the cruel words he remembered her saying were his own. In colonial West Africa, a boy learning to write from a missionary finds that the written record of his clan's history differs from the version his elders tell, and confronts the difference between exactitude and rightness. The story is *Memento* inverted. Chiang's narrator uses the record to discover his guilt and accept it; Leonard uses the record to conceal his. Chiang's journalist had set out to argue against the software on the ground that people must forget minor offenses in order to forgive; the record overturns him, and the

reconciliation that follows rests on remembering. Leonard refutes the same premise from the other side: a man who cannot remember offenses is not thereby able to forgive them (5.8). The software's moral premise, that a comprehensive record cannot be edited by its subject, is exactly the condition Leonard's system violates.

Chiang's earlier "Story of Your Life" (1998), adapted as *Arrival* (2016), gives its narrator, through an alien language written all at once, a consciousness in which the future is known, her daughter's death included; she chooses to enact the future she knows. This is freedom as performative fidelity to a known destiny, and it passes the Nietzschean test of recurrence with its full weight. Leonard, offered knowledge of his past at the junction, chooses to enact a future he has written while ensuring that he will not know it. Chiang's narrator affirms with knowledge; Leonard affirms through engineered ignorance.

8.8
Ishiguro: Forgetting, Peace, and War

Kazuo Ishiguro's *The Buried Giant* (2015) sets its story in post-Arthurian Britain under a mist, the breath of a she-dragon, that causes communal forgetting. An elderly couple set out to find a son they barely remember. Gradually it emerges that the mist was enchanted at Arthur's behest to bury the memory of a massacre, and that it has kept the peace between Britons and Saxons. The massacre had betrayed a peace treaty that the old man, Axl, had himself brokered as Arthur's envoy, and he has forgotten it: like Leonard under H_1, the hero has forgotten his own part in the violence on which his world rests. When a Saxon warrior kills the dragon, memory returns, and with it the certainty of vengeance and war. A boatman will ferry a couple together to the island only if they can prove their memories shared, and when the mist lifts, the couple remember that the son they set out to find died of plague; the island where they believed him to be living is his grave.

The novel inverts *Memento*'s configuration. In Ishiguro, forgetting is the condition of peace and memory the condition of vengeance. In *Memento*, forgetting is the condition of vengeance, and memory, Teddy's revelation retained, would be the condition of peace. Together the two works establish that the relation of memory to violence has no fixed sign. Forgetting can found peace or perpetuate war; what matters is who administers it and for whose benefit. Ishiguro's *A Pale View of Hills* (6.6), *The Unconsoled* (1995), in which a pianist keeps discovering obligations he seems to have

forgotten, and *The Remains of the Day* (1989), whose butler's memory serves his self-deception, complete his anatomy of the unreliable remembering subject.

8.9
Sebald, Resnais, Marker: The Archive and the Face

W. G. Sebald's *Austerlitz* (2001) follows a man raised in Wales under another name who learns in middle age that he came to Britain as a child refugee from Prague in 1939. He reconstructs his mother's fate through archives, photographs, and a Nazi propaganda film of the Theresienstadt ghetto, which he slows down in search of her face. Photographs are set into the text without captions. Austerlitz's archive retrieves a victim; Leonard's manufactures victims. The two works are the poles of the archival imagination: the archive as restitution and the archive as warrant.

Alain Resnais's *Hiroshima mon amour* (1959) sets a Frenchwoman's terror of forgetting her dead German lover against a city's obligation to remember atrocity, and treats forgetting as a second death. His *L'Année dernière à Marienbad* (1961) shows a man persuading a woman that they met the year before, so that the past is constructed by insistence. Teddy and Natalie are Marienbad's persuader: they tell Leonard what happened last year, or in the last hour. Chris Marker's *La Jetée* (1962), composed almost entirely of still photographs, follows a man haunted by an image from childhood, a woman's face and a man's death on an airport pier, who is sent into the past by experimenters and discovers that the death he witnessed as a child was his own. The film of stills anticipates *Memento*'s Polaroids in form, and its revelation, that the death one remembers is bound to one's own deed, anticipates Teddy's. Marker's *Sans Soleil* (1983) proposes that remembering is not the opposite of forgetting but its lining, a formulation that could stand as the epigraph to Leonard's condition.

Resnais's *Je t'aime, je t'aime* (1968) supplies the sharpest charge against *Memento*'s originality: Jonathan Rosenbaum dismissed Nolan's film as a mechanical imitation of it, lacking its poetry. In Resnais's film, written with the science-fiction novelist Jacques Sternberg, Claude Ridder, who has survived a suicide attempt, is recruited by researchers who have already sent mice one year back in time for one minute. When they send him, the machine breaks down, and he relives fragments of his life at random, circling the death of his lover, Catrine, which may or may not have been an accident and for which he feels responsible. The kinship is real, down to the dead woman's name. But the difference answers the charge. Resnais's fragments arrive at random, through the malfunction of an apparatus; *Memento*'s are ordered by rule

(1.1). Resnais gives the past as a labyrinth without a plan. Nolan gives it as a labyrinth with an author, and the author is the man inside it.

8.10
The Noir Matrix and Its Descendants

Billy Wilder's *Double Indemnity* (1944) is *Memento*'s generic ancestor. Walter Neff, an insurance salesman, conspires to murder a client's husband for the double indemnity clause. Barton Keyes, the claims manager, has a "little man" inside him who warns of phony claims. The film is narrated by Neff dictating his confession into Keyes's recording machine. Leonard is Keyes become Neff: the claims man who becomes the criminal, and whose confession, the story of Sammy, is delivered to an unseen listener over a telephone. The monochrome strand of *Memento* is Neff's dictaphone. Rudolph Maté's *D.O.A.* (1950) opens with a poisoned man reporting his own murder to the police and investigating it in the time left to him; each of Leonard's intervals is such an investigation of a death already accomplished. Alan Parker's *Angel Heart* (1987), from William Hjortsberg's novel, sends a detective in search of a vanished singer and reveals that the detective is the man he seeks, his memory lost after he took another man's identity. The single frame in which Leonard sits in Sammy's chair compresses *Angel Heart*'s revelation into a cut.

Martin Scorsese's *Shutter Island* (2010), from Dennis Lehane's novel (2003), is *Memento*'s nearest kin. A federal marshal investigating a disappearance at an island hospital is revealed to be a patient who killed his wife after she drowned their children, and who has constructed an investigative fiction, in which he hunts the man responsible for his wife's death, to escape his guilt; the names of the fiction are anagrams of the names of the truth. At the end, apparently lucid, he asks whether it would be worse to live as a monster or to die as a good man, and walks toward the erasure of a lobotomy. The hero of the fiction is called Teddy, an onomastic rhyme no reading of the two films can ignore. *Shutter Island*'s Teddy chooses erasure to end the cycle; *Memento*'s Leonard chooses re-erasure to perpetuate it. One forgets in order to stop killing, the other in order to continue.

Alex Proyas's *Dark City* (1998) begins with a man waking in a bathtub without memory, suspected of murders, in a city whose inhabitants' memories are reassigned every midnight by alien Strangers. Its manipulators are alien; *Memento*'s are human, and one of them is Leonard. Michel Gondry and Charlie Kaufman's *Eternal Sunshine of the Spotless Mind* (2004) takes its title from Pope's "Eloisa to Abelard" (1717):

"How happy is the blameless vestal's lot! / The world forgetting, by the world forgot. / Eternal sunshine of the spotless mind!" A clinic erases memories of failed relationships. Its receptionist quotes Nietzsche's blessing on the forgetful (5.7), then discovers that her own memory of an affair with the clinic's director has been erased, and mails the patients the recordings of their pre-erasure interviews: letters from their former selves. The lovers hear themselves enumerate each other's faults and decide to try again. *Eternal Sunshine* is *Memento*'s moral antithesis. Its lovers receive the truth from their past selves and choose love with knowledge, a Kierkegaardian repetition and a Nietzschean affirmation bearing its full weight. Leonard receives the truth and chooses vengeance by ignorance.

Lighter works confirm the structure. In Peter Segal's *50 First Dates* (2004), a man records a video that each morning tells an amnesiac woman the story of their love; in Peter Weir's *The Truman Show* (1998), a producer governs a man's entire reality for his supposed good. Both are benevolent hypomnesic governments. S. J. Watson's novel *Before I Go to Sleep* (2011) gives an amnesiac woman a secret journal whose first page warns her not to trust the man who claims to be her husband, and the warning is true: *Memento*'s structure re-moralized, with Leonard's caption made honest.

Akira Kurosawa's *Rashomon* (1950), from Akutagawa's "Yabu no naka" (1922), presents incompatible testimonies about a woman's rape and a husband's death, including that of the dead husband speaking through a medium. Each is self-serving, and each of the three principals claims the killing as honor requires: the bandit in a duel; the wife, who woke to find her husband dead with her dagger in his chest; the husband, by his own hand. The woodcutter, who saw everything, conceals that he stole the dagger. *Memento* shares the crime at the center of Kurosawa's film, a wife raped and a death whose author is disputed, and compresses the *Rashomon* problem into one mind, whose witnesses are the successive intervals of a single man. It also inverts the economy of testimony: where every witness in *Rashomon* claims the killing, each of Leonard's intervals disowns it and assigns it to another.

8.11
Nolan's Oeuvre: Variations on Hypomnesic Sovereignty

Nolan's films return obsessively to the configuration *Memento* established. *Following* (1998), shot in monochrome and told out of order, shows a young writer who shadows strangers being manipulated by a burglar named Cobb, who frames him for murder: the exploitation of another's compulsion by a man who writes his script.

Insomnia (2002), remaking Erik Skjoldbjærg's film of 1997, sends a detective to an Alaskan town under the midnight sun, where he shoots his partner in fog, perhaps by accident, conceals it, and cannot sleep while a murderer who witnessed the shooting blackmails him. *Insomnia* is *Memento* with the reset removed. Guilt without forgetting produces disintegration; guilt with forgetting, in *Memento*, produces perpetuation.

Batman Begins (2005) stages the distinction between justice and revenge in an exchange over whether justice serves harmony or merely the avenger's relief, and the trilogy converts private vengeance into a symbol and an institution. *The Dark Knight* (2008) gives its villain contradictory accounts of the origin of his scars, a self whose past is multiple choice, and ends by founding Gotham's peace on a noble lie about a fallen prosecutor, which *The Dark Knight Rises* (2012) unravels. Plato's noble lie at civic scale (7.4) is Leonard's at personal scale. *Inception* (2010) concerns a man whose wife killed herself after he planted in her mind the idea that her world was unreal; she persists in his subconscious as a saboteur; and the film ends as he walks away from the spinning top that would tell him whether he dreams, without waiting to see whether it falls. The gesture is Leonard's: refusal of the test and the choice of a world over knowledge of its reality. Cobb, like Leonard under H_1, is the author of his wife's death. Unlike Leonard, he confesses.

Interstellar (2014) inverts the junction benevolently. A father inside a higher-dimensional structure becomes the ghost of his daughter's childhood bedroom, sending messages into the past through falling books and the second hand of a watch. The future self inscribes messages to the past out of love. *Dunkirk* (2017) interleaves three strands of different durations, a week, a day, and an hour, converging on a single event: *Memento*'s pincer generalized. *Tenet* (2020) sends forces forward and backward through the same interval toward one objective, and reveals that its protagonist founded, in his future, the organization that recruited him in his past, under a doctrine that the operatives' ignorance is their protection. *Tenet* is the cosmic version of the junction: a self that writes the script its earlier self will obey and keeps that self ignorant for the script's success. *Oppenheimer* (2023) returns to the chromatic code (1.6), quotes the *Gītā*'s verse of Time (5.9), and grants its protagonist the hearing Leonard never receives.

Across these films a chronotope of guilt recurs: a dead wife or beloved (Catherine; Sarah Borden and Julia Angier in *The Prestige*; Mal; Rachel Dawes), a man implicated in her death, a temporal architecture that disperses his responsibility, and a decision not to know. *Memento* is the matrix from which the others are cast.



1936	1720	2000	1840	1820	1976
1888	1892	1732	1872	1916	1708
1836	1784	1896	1720	1756	1956
1768	1928	1752	1800	1700	1740
1792	1916	1848	1700	1760	1992
1700	1780	1804	1908	1996	1952
1872	1784	1812	1789	1800	1972
1956	1820	1912	1728	1800	1800
1936	1724	1744	1892	1868	1912
1740	1756	1836	1948	1704	1732
1868	1764	1804	1768	1740	1900
1980	1956	1900	1712	1768	1796

CHAPTER

IX

The Mystical Foundation of the Self

Toward a General Theory of Hypomnesic Sovereignty

9.1 From Pathology to Polity 129
9.2 The Dead Hand 130
9.3 The Decision on the Exception 131
9.4 Founding Violence and the Mystical Foundation 132
9.5 Homo Sacer 134
9.6 Archive Fever 134
9.7 Political Economy: Dead Labor and the Forgetting of Reification 135
9.8 The Anterograde Century 137
9.9 Spectatorial Personhood and the Four Theorems 138
9.10 Objections and Replies 140
9.11 The Thesis Restated 141

9.1 From Pathology to Polity

In the second book of the *Republic* (368c–369a), Socrates proposes to examine justice first in the city, where it is written in large letters, and then in the soul, where it is written small. *Memento* reverses the procedure. It shows the structure of the polity in small letters on a man's body, legible because the scale is reduced and the tempo accelerated. Hume had already compared the soul to a commonwealth united by reciprocal ties of government and subordination (3.3). The preceding chapters have shown that Leonard's soul is such a commonwealth, and that its government is written.

Hypomnesic sovereignty can now be defined formally. It is a structure of four elements: a writing self, the sovereign; a reading self, the subject; a medium that persists across the transition from one to the other; and an origin, the act of writing together

with its circumstances, inaccessible to the subject. It obtains when four conditions hold: the subject cannot remember the origin; the subject automatically endorses the medium; the medium survives the sovereign; and the sovereign intends the subject's action. Leonard's system satisfies all four at every transition between intervals. His Lethean constitution (4.9) orders the medium into tiers of entrenchment, from revocable photographs through amendable notes to unamendable tattoos, beneath a rule of recognition inscribed on his hand and a basic norm, obey the hand that wrote, which cannot itself be written.

9.2
The Dead Hand

Writing to Madison on 6 September 1789, Jefferson declared it self-evident that the earth belongs in usufruct to the living, and that the dead have neither powers nor rights over it. From this he concluded that no society can make a perpetual constitution, or even a perpetual law, since "by the law of nature, one generation is to another as one independant nation to another." Thomas Paine, in *Rights of Man* (1791), called "the vanity and presumption of governing beyond the grave" the most ridiculous and insolent of all tyrannies. He described his whole contention as one "for the rights of the living, and against their being willed away, and controuled and contracted for, by the manuscript assumed authority of the dead." No phrase in political literature names hypomnesic sovereignty more exactly: authority assumed by manuscript, exercised by the dead over the living. Burke, against whom Paine wrote, had defined society as a partnership "between those who are living, those who are dead, and those who are to be born" (*Reflections*, 1790). He warned that the temporary possessors of the commonwealth must not "cut off the entail or commit waste on the inheritance," leaving to those who come after them "a ruin instead of a habitation." Leonard's life adjudicates this dispute unexpectedly. It is a Burkean partnership among the dead self, the living interval, and those yet to be born; and the partnership is a Painean tyranny, since only the dead partner may speak. At the junction Leonard does precisely what Burke forbade: he commits waste on the inheritance and leaves his successors a ruin instead of a habitation.

Constitutional theory has long understood such binding as precommitment. Valerius Maximus records the woman condemned by Philip of Macedon at a drunken hearing who appealed from Philip drunk to Philip sober. Elster's *Ulysses and the Sirens* (1979) and Stephen Holmes's "Precommitment and the Paradox of Demo-

cracy" (1988) read constitutions as appeals from the people in passion to the people at rest, chains forged in clarity against the frenzy to come. Leonard's notes are appeals from Leonard amnesiac to Leonard informed. At the junction the appeal is inverted: Leonard informed binds Leonard deceived to his deception. The precommitment that protects against weakness becomes the precommitment that institutionalizes it. This is the first general lesson of the case. A device of precommitment is neutral as to its content, and the chain that saves Ulysses can as easily deliver him to the Sirens.

9.3
The Decision on the Exception

Carl Schmitt opened *Politische Theologie* (1922) with a definition: sovereign is he who decides on the exception. The exception cannot be subsumed under any norm, and the decision upon it, considered normatively, is born out of nothing. Schmitt closed his first chapter by quoting, without naming him, a Protestant theologian who held that the exception explains the general and itself, and that whoever wishes to study the general correctly need only look for a true exception. The theologian is Kierkegaard, and the text is *Repetition* (1.2). The circle of this dissertation closes here: the book that supplied the logic of *Memento*'s forward strand also supplied the epigraph of the modern theory of sovereignty. Schmitt published the book in March 1922, against the background of the emergency powers in Article 48 of the Weimar Constitution, and commentators have noted that the quotation within it admits two readings: an analogy, in which Kierkegaard's exception is the sovereign's, and a disanalogy, in which Schmitt's exception glorifies the sovereign while Kierkegaard's honors the martyr. Leonard's junction offers him both. He could be Kierkegaard's exception, the single man who bears an unbearable truth alone, as Heracles bears his in Euripides (6.3). He chooses Schmitt's. Schmitt later wrote on Hamlet itself. In Hamlet oder Hekuba (1956), subtitled Der Einbruch der Zeit in das Spiel, the irruption of time into the play, he argued that the play's tragic force comes from a real, extraliterary history breaking into the drama. Memento's form performs the same irruption: the time its protagonist cannot hold breaks into the play for the spectator.

Leonard's junction is a state of exception within his own constitution. Its basic rule, that facts are recorded only after verification and that memory is never trusted, is suspended by a sovereign who, in the light of Teddy's revelation, decides to record an unverified fact. The license plate becomes the sixth fact not because anything supports it but because Leonard wills it. The decision is born out of nothing. It founds a

new order, the hunt for Teddy, and conceals its foundation by burning the photographs and writing on Teddy's image that he is not to be believed. The sovereign decision is self-effacing; it destroys its own traces so that its subjects will experience the new order as given. Schmitt held that the significant concepts of the modern theory of the state are secularized theological concepts, and that the exception in jurisprudence is analogous to the miracle in theology. Leonard's decision is a miracle within his world: an event that breaks its laws, performed by its author, and erased from its history.

9.4
Founding Violence and the Mystical Foundation

Walter Benjamin's "Zur Kritik der Gewalt" (1921) distinguished law-making violence, which founds a legal order, from law-preserving violence, which maintains it, and mythic violence, bloody and productive of guilt, from divine violence, which destroys law and expiates. Leonard's ordinary killings are law-preserving: they maintain the order of his system. The junction is law-making violence of the mythic kind. It establishes a law, that Teddy is John G, and a guilt, Teddy's, by designating a victim.

Montaigne wrote in "De l'expérience" (*Essais* III.13) that "les loix se maintiennent en credit, non par ce qu'elles sont justes, mais par ce qu'elles sont loix. C'est le fondement mystique de leur authorité, elles n'en ont poinct d'autre": laws keep their credit not because they are just but because they are laws; that is the mystical foundation of their authority, and they have no other. Derrida's "Force of Law" (1989–90) took Montaigne's phrase as its subtitle and argued that the founding moment of law is a performative force that is neither just nor unjust, because it precedes the law that would judge it, and that the mystical is a silence walled up within the violent structure of the founding act. Leonard's notes keep their credit not because they are true but because they are his. That is the mystical foundation of their authority. They have no other. In the same essay Montaigne remarks that there is more business in interpreting interpretations than in interpreting things, and more books on books than on any other subject: "nous ne faisons que nous entregloser." Leonard's notes are glosses upon glosses, with no original text beneath them.

Pascal drew the political conclusion with a cynicism that is also lucidity: "Il ne faut pas qu'il sente la vérité de l'usurpation; elle a été introduite autrefois sans raison, elle est devenue raisonnable; il faut la faire regarder comme authentique, éternelle, et en cacher le commencement, si on ne veut qu'elle ne prenne bientôt fin" (*Pensées*,

Lafuma 60). The people must not perceive the truth of the usurpation; it was introduced long ago without reason and has become reasonable; it must be made to seem authentic and eternal, and its beginning must be hidden, if one does not want it soon to end. Leonard hides the beginning of his new law so that it will not soon end. *Memento* hides the beginning from its audience until the end, and then shows it. The film performs the unveiling that Pascal's sovereign must prevent. In the same fragment Pascal names the method of subversion: "L'art de fronder, bouleverser les États est d'ébranler les coutumes établies en sondant jusque dans leur source," to expose their want of authority and justice. Teddy's revelation is that art practiced on a single man, and Leonard answers as Pascal's sovereign must, by hiding the source again.

Ernest Renan, in "Qu'est-ce qu'une nation?" (1882), stated the same law for collective identity: "L'oubli, et je dirai même l'erreur historique, sont un facteur essentiel de la création d'une nation." Forgetting, and even historical error, is an essential factor in the creation of a nation, because historical inquiry brings to light the violence at the origin of every political formation; every French citizen, Renan adds, must have forgotten the Saint Bartholomew's Day massacre and the massacres of the Midi in the thirteenth century. Benedict Anderson remarked the grammatical paradox of the sentence: the citizen is reminded of what he must already have forgotten. Leonard is a nation of one. His unity requires that he have forgotten a founding violence, Catherine's death and the killing of the second intruder under H_1, and the killing of Jimmy under both hypotheses, and his historical error, the Sammy narrative and the designation of Teddy, is the essential factor of his creation. Renan's lecture, delivered at the Sorbonne on 11 March 1882, ends by defining the nation as a daily plebiscite, a consent renewed every day to a shared inheritance of memories. Leonard renews his consent at every interval, but his ballot carries a single name, written by the incumbent.

Girard took the title of his synthesis, *Des choses cachées depuis la fondation du monde* (1978), from Matthew 13:35, "I will utter things which have been kept secret from the foundation of the world," and argued that myth conceals the founding murder on which every culture rests. Freud told a related story in *Totem und Tabu* (1913), deriving society from a primal parricide remembered only as guilt and ritual, and again in *Der Mann Moses und die monotheistische Religion* (1939), where a religion is founded on a murder its adherents forget. Plato's noble lie (7.4) is the founding falsification of memory in its most philosophical form. These texts converge on the third theorem of this dissertation: what is concealed at the commencement is a violence that the order it founds would itself condemn.

9.5
Homo Sacer

Giorgio Agamben's *Homo Sacer* (1995) revived an obscure figure of archaic Roman law recorded by Festus: the sacred man is one whom the people have judged for a crime; it is not permitted to sacrifice him, yet whoever kills him is not condemned for homicide. Agamben read this figure as the original form of sovereign power, which constitutes itself by producing bare life, life exposed to death outside both human and divine law, through a ban that includes by excluding. John G. is the *homo sacer* of Leonard's polity. Anyone so designated may be killed without the killing counting, in Leonard's law, as murder, and without its counting as sacrifice, since it consecrates nothing and ends nothing. The caption on the Polaroid is the ban; the designation is the sentence of abandonment. Leonard himself is bare life governed by inscription: his amnesiac body, *zoē*, is captured by a written life, *bios*, that is not his to live. Agamben called the camp the hidden paradigm of modern political space. The paradigm of Leonard's is the motel: a space of bare life rented by the night, where identity is checked at the desk and then suspended.

9.6
Archive Fever

Derrida's *Mal d'archive* (1995) recalls that the Greek *arkheion* was the residence of the archons, the magistrates who guarded official documents and held the right to interpret them. Their power combined custody, consignation, the gathering of signs into a single corpus, and hermeneutic authority. The archive, Derrida argued, is haunted by a death drive internal to it, an archiviolithic force that destroys the archive even as the archive is formed, and by archive fever: a compulsive, repetitive, nostalgic desire to return to the origin, burning with a passion that also burns the record. Leonard is the archon of his archive. His body and his motel room are its *arkheion*, and he alone claims the right to interpret it. His decisive act is archiviolithic: he burns the photographs. It may not be his first. The police file on Catherine's case that Leonard carries is missing twelve pages, and Leonard himself remarks that pages are missing and others crossed out. Teddy claims that the file was complete when he gave it to him and that Leonard removed the pages himself, to make a puzzle he could never solve. Under H_1 the missing pages are the purest instance of the second theorem: the record

of the beginning removed by the one who must not find it, so that the search can go on. His fever is the compulsive return to the origin, the bathroom and the attack, which consumes every record that might complicate it. The archive that was to secure his memory becomes the instrument of its destruction.

The film's paratexts carried the archive into the world. Its official website, otnemem.com, the title spelled backwards, opened on a newspaper report of Leonard's killing of Teddy, with notes, photographs, and police reports behind it. Its distributors mailed strangers Polaroids of a bloodied, shirtless Leonard pointing at the unmarked space on his chest. Its limited-edition DVD came packaged as his case file from a psychiatric institution. In 2017 the Library of Congress selected the film for preservation in the National Film Registry, the first narrative feature of the 2000s so chosen. The film about an archive that consumes itself now rests in the archive of a nation.

9.7
Political Economy: Dead Labor and the Forgetting of Reification

Marx wrote in the first volume of *Capital* that "Capital is dead labour, that, vampire-like, only lives by sucking living labour, and lives the more, the more labour it sucks" (ch. 10). Leonard's notes are the dead labor of his past selves, congealed into a script that commands the living labor of his present. Mark Neocleous has called Marx's metaphor a political economy of the dead: accumulated labor rules living labor because it refuses to stay dead. Leonard's notes refuse in the same way, and they grow stronger with every interval that obeys them, as capital lives the more, the more labor it sucks. Beyond them, Teddy appropriates the surplus, the money in Jimmy's car. Leonard is the perfectly alienated worker of the manuscripts of 1844. He is estranged from the product of his labor, a dead man and stolen money he will never see; from its process, which reaches him as instructions from elsewhere; from his species-being, the capacity for free and conscious activity; and from other men, every one of whom is either a mark or a handler. His wage is meaning.

Adorno, writing to Benjamin in 1940, formulated a principle that *Dialectic of Enlightenment* would make central: every reification is a forgetting. Leonard's reifications, the person turned into a captioned photograph and the self turned into a list of facts, are forgettings, and his forgetting is a reification. A face becomes a thing with a sentence attached. In "Über einige Motive bei Baudelaire" (1939), Benjamin distin-

guished *Erlebnis*, the isolated experience of shock parried by consciousness, from *Erfahrung*, experience accumulated, sedimented in tradition, and transmissible. Modern life, he argued, multiplies shocks that consciousness parries without letting them become experience in the full sense, and he found its emblems in the gambler, for whom every wager begins the game anew, and in the factory worker, each of whose movements is unconnected with the last. Leonard is the Benjaminian modern subject reduced to *Erlebnis*. Every interval is a shock parried and never converted into experience, and his final question is the gambler's beginning again.

Marc Augé's *Non-lieux* (1992) described the non-places of supermodernity, motels, highways, service stations, airports, as spaces of solitary contractuality, where users are addressed by texts, instructions, prohibitions, and notices, and where identity is verified at the entrance and suspended thereafter. Leonard's world consists entirely of non-places, and he is addressed by texts as their users are, with the difference that the texts are his own.

Ian Hacking's *Mad Travelers* (1998) supplies the clinical type of this citizen. Albert Dadas, a gas-fitter whom the young doctor Philippe Tissié met in a Bordeaux hospital in 1886, made compulsive journeys across Europe that he could not afterwards recall in ordinary consciousness; under hypnosis, however, he could recount them in detail. He often traveled without papers, unable to say who he was, and was arrested as a vagrant. The diagnosis flourished from 1887, when Tissié published *Les aliénés voyageurs*, until it faded after a congress of alienists and neurologists at Nantes in 1909, and Hacking explained its brief life by an ecological niche suspended between respectable tourism and criminal vagrancy. Leonard is a *fugueur* of the interstate, and his niche is the motel and the highway. Dadas's journeys survived only in a record another man extracted from him under hypnosis; Leonard's survive only in records he leaves for himself. Both wander inside a niche built by modern institutions of movement, and both depend on a technique outside memory for any access to what they have done.

In *Les formes de l'oubli* (1998), Augé distinguished three figures of forgetting: return, which forgets the present to recover a lost past; suspense, which forgets past and future to inhabit the present; and beginning again, which forgets the past to open a future. Augé found these figures in ritual, return in possession, suspense in rites of social and sexual inversion, beginning again in initiation, and compressed the inquiry into a maxim: tell me what you forget, and I will tell you who you are. Leonard performs all three figures in every interval, and his final question is the third, an initiation performed by a man upon his successor.

9.8
The Anterograde Century

Memento was written in the late 1990s and released in 2000, before the smartphone, the social feed, cloud storage, and the platform features that daily present users with their own past. The film's subject now describes a civilization. Betsy Sparrow, Jenny Liu, and Daniel Wegner reported in 2011 that people who expect information to remain available online remember less of the information and more of where to find it: transactive memory, Wegner's own concept (4.5), extended to the network. The contemporary subject externalizes episodic memory into devices on a scale Leonard could not have imagined, and that external memory is hosted, ordered, curated, and edited by others.

Political science has tested the democratic form of Leonard's condition. Jason Coronel and colleagues (2012) presented patients with profound amnesia with candidates' issue positions and later asked them to vote. Although the patients could remember none of the issue information, they consistently chose the candidates whose positions best matched their own, apparently guided by affective impressions formed at the time (2.1). The finding cuts both ways for the theory advanced here. It shows that affect can carry a reasoned choice across forgetting, the benevolent face of the neutrality corollary (9.9). It also shows that whoever shapes the affective impression shapes the vote without the voter's knowledge, which is Natalie's method (2.1) at the scale of an electorate.

The invaded mind (4.5) is the mind of the networked subject. Natalie's removal of the pens has become a matter of interface design; Teddy's suggestions have become recommendations; the motel clerk's double billing has become a subscription. The trust condition that licenses cognitive extension is now cultivated by design, and authorial closure, the subject's exclusive power to write to its own extended memory, is precisely what has been surrendered. Stiegler's proletarianization of memory (4.4) names the result. Hypomnesic sovereignty has migrated from the past self to whoever controls the medium. The story's closed circuit, in which only Earl writes to Earl, has become a nostalgic ideal, the private archive. The film's open circuit, in which others write in Leonard's world, has become the ordinary condition.

The diagnosis is not technophobic. Thamus was wrong about the total effect of writing, and the *pharmakon* remains undecidable. The question is not whether memory should be externalized, which is the condition of culture as such, but who

holds the pen and whether the subject retains the capacity to see the beginning. That capacity is the subject of the fourth theorem.

9.9
Spectatorial Personhood and the Four Theorems

Chapter III identified the forensic orphan: an act that, once the interval of its performance has closed, belongs under the Lockean criterion to no extant person. Locke reserved the appropriation of such acts for the Great Day, "wherein the secrets of all hearts shall be laid open." *Memento*'s reversed form constructs a secular Great Day. It endows the spectator with a consciousness that extends over every interval: the killings of Teddy and Jimmy, the burning of the photographs, the license plate, the revelation. The spectator becomes the only being to whom Leonard's acts are present as a whole. In Locke's forensic rather than metaphysical sense, the spectator is the person to whom those acts belong: not their author but their appropriator, the consciousness that can extend backwards to them and so render them accountable. This is **spectatorial personhood**.

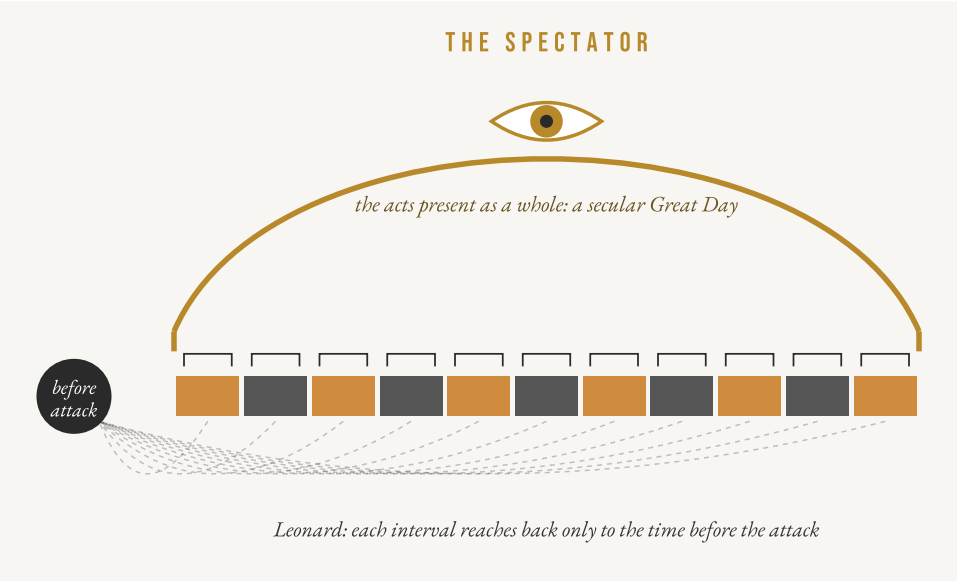


Figure 14. *Spectatorial personhood. Each of Leonard's intervals reaches back only to the time before the attack; the spectator alone holds every interval at once.*

The figures assembled in this dissertation converge on this position. It is Fink's phenomenologizing onlooker (2.4), and Er, who did not drink from Ameles (7.2). It is also the angel of Benjamin's ninth thesis on the concept of history (1940), who faces the past and sees, where we perceive a chain of events, a single catastrophe piling wreckage upon wreckage; he would like to stay, awaken the dead, and make whole what has been smashed, but a storm drives him into the future to which his back is turned. The spectator of *Memento*'s chromatic strand faces backwards toward the wreckage, each scene opening on its corpse, and is driven by the montage toward a junction he cannot see. The film's first shot grants the angel's wish for an instant. Run backwards, it awakens the dead: the bullet returns to the gun, the blood to the body, and Teddy, for a fraction of a second, is whole.

The argument can now be stated as four theorems.

THEOREM I (INSCRIPTION). Every inscription that outlives the moment of its writing is a sovereign act over its future reader.

THEOREM II (CONCEALMENT). An inscriptional sovereignty endures in proportion to its success in concealing its own commencement.

THEOREM III (FOUNDATION). What is concealed at the commencement is a violence that the order it founds would itself condemn.

THEOREM IV (TRANSFER). Where the subjects of such an order cannot appropriate its founding act, the forensic person migrates to whoever can: the historian, the judge, the witness, the spectator.

Three corollaries follow. The first is **bivalence**: the theorems hold under H_1 and H_2 alike. Under H_2 the concealed founding violence is not Catherine's death but the junction decision itself, together with the killings of Jimmy and Teddy; the structure is unchanged. The second is **neutrality**: hypomnesic sovereignty is morally neutral as a structure. "Paycheck," *50 First Dates*, and *Interstellar* exhibit its benevolent forms, and it becomes tyranny only when the sovereign writes against the reader's capacity to see the beginning. The third is **scale-invariance**: the structure is unchanged by a change of time-scale. It governs minutes in Leonard, a lifetime in the ordinary self ruled by its earlier resolutions, habits, and records, and centuries in nations, scriptures, and constitutions.

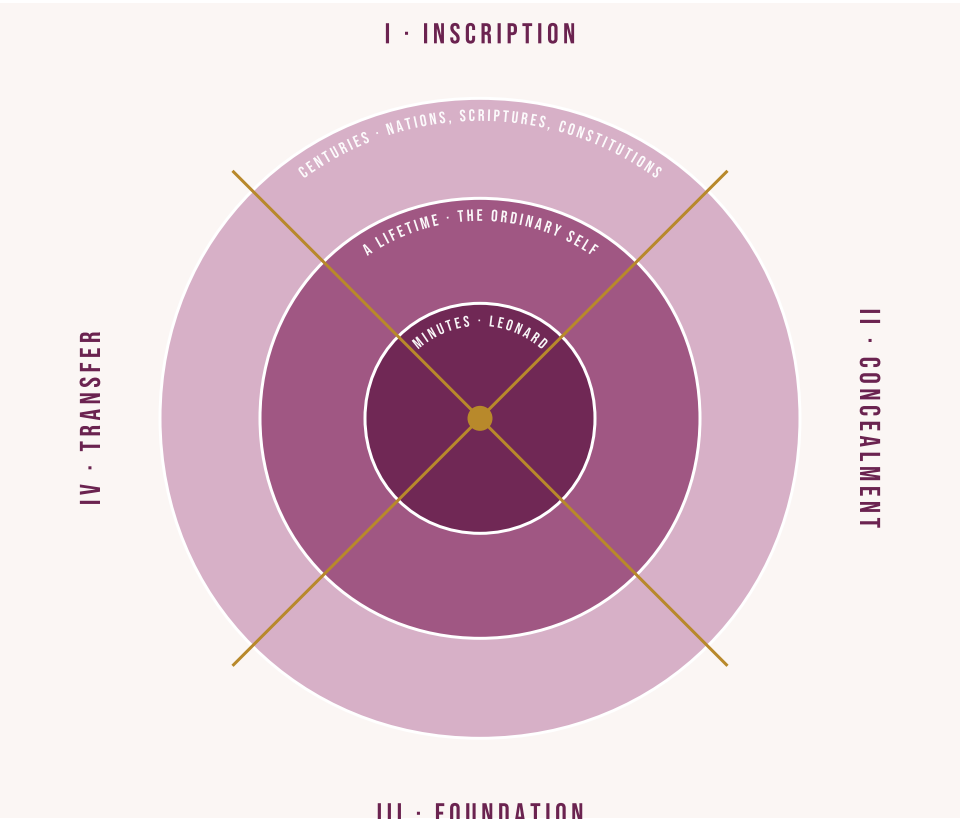


Figure 15. *Scale-invariance: the four theorems hold whether the inscriptions govern minutes, a lifetime, or centuries.*

9.10
Objections and Replies

The genre objection holds that *Memento* is a thriller, not a treatise, and that its form serves suspense rather than argument. The reply is Cavell's and Mulhall's (0.1): films can think, and the thesis concerns what the form of this film does, not what its makers intended. The undecidability objection holds that nothing can be concluded from a revelation the film never confirms. The reply is the bivalence protocol and its corollary: every principal claim has been formulated to hold under both hypotheses. The clinical objection holds that Leonard's fluency about his own condition is implausible in a patient so impaired. The reply is that the thesis concerns the formal condition the film constructs, which clinical opinion has judged unusually accurate in its essentials (2.1), and that the residual implausibility is itself significant: Leonard's

knowledge of his own forgetting is the single item of post-injury knowledge on which every manipulation of him depends (2.5).

The universalization objection holds that ordinary persons are not Leonard. The reply is the third corollary. The ordinary self also lives by the inscriptions of prior selves whose circumstances it cannot fully recall: diaries, promises, records, schooling, the institutions into which it was born. The difference between its condition and Leonard's is one of degree, which is exactly what acceleration reveals. The pessimism objection holds that the theory turns all tradition into tyranny. The reply is the second corollary. The remedy for hypomnesic tyranny is not the abolition of inscription, which would abolish culture, but the preservation of access to the beginning: the archive kept open, the photograph left unburned, the origin shown. That is the ethic *Memento*'s form enacts.

9.11
The Thesis Restated

Memento is not a film about a man who cannot remember. It is a political theology of remembrance, in which the anterograde condition discloses the structure of every authority founded on writing: a past that rules through texts, a present that obeys without remembering why, a beginning that must be hidden, and a violence buried in the beginning. Leonard is not the failure of the Lockean person but its prophet. The forensic person was always a juridical fiction that required records, testimony, and, in Locke, God; *Memento* secularizes the Last Judgment into cinema. The film's reversed form is the counter-sovereign act. It shows the beginning last, and in doing so makes the spectator the one being in its universe who knows what Leonard has done.



Now, where was I?

CONCLUSION

"Now, Where Was I?"

The film ends with a question every reader has asked. Where was I? It is the question one puts on returning to an interrupted book, when the finger finds the line again and the sentence resumes. Leonard asks it outside the tattoo parlor, having decided, forgotten, and begun again. Dennett's question of where a self is located (3.11) receives in *Memento* a textual answer: a self is located where reading resumes. Resumption is the minimal form of fidelity, the commitment to pick up where one left off. Leonard's resumption is fidelity counterfeited. He picks up where his predecessor told him he had left off, and the bookmark has been moved.

The film's title is a grammatical form before it is a word. *Memento* is the imperative of *meminī*, a verb that lacks a present imperative and supplies the want with a future one: not "remember" but "you shall remember," a command addressed across time to an addressee who does not yet exist. That is the grammatical mood of every note Leonard writes. The story's title completes the formula of the *vanitas*: *memento mori*, you shall remember that you must die. The film drops the second word and leaves the command without an object. The object is supplied by the one to whom the command is finally addressed, the spectator who has seen the beginning. Remember Jimmy Grantz. Remember John Edward Gammell. Remember Catherine Shelby. Remember, under H_1, a man named Sammy Jankis, maligned as the author of another man's crime. The injunction on Leonard's hand is obeyed at last, by its true addressee.

The argument can be summarized as a final reversal. The tradition from Plato to Parfit asked what memory does for the self. *Memento* asks what writing does to it, and answers that writing makes the self governable, by others and by itself, while rendering the governance invisible to the governed. The tradition of tragedy asked what happens when the hero recognizes. *Memento* asks what happens when he refuses, and answers that recognition does not disappear but migrates, to the audience. The tradition of political theology asked how authority conceals its origin. *Memento* answers by showing a man doing it with a lighter and a pen, and by showing his act to us last, so that we cannot fail to see it.

The contributions of this dissertation can be stated plainly. It has proposed a general concept, hypomnesic sovereignty, with a formal definition and four theorems. It has identified the star topology of Leonard's Lockean identity and the category of the forensic orphan. It has added to the conditions of cognitive extension the requirement of authorial closure, whose absence defines the invaded mind. It has offered a temporal solution to the static and dynamic puzzles of self-deception. It has distinguished neurological from second-order *méconnaissance* in the theory of sacrifice. It has named anti-anagnorisis as a tragic form and spectatorial personhood as its consequence. And it has reconstructed, across Greek, Hebrew, Egyptian, Gnostic, Norse, Mesopotamian, and Indic sources, a Lethean archetype whose secularization the film performs.

Three lines of inquiry follow. The first is jurisprudential: the theorems invite application to constitutional entrenchment, to testamentary law, and to the evidentiary status of records whose authors cannot be examined. The second is historiographical: the relation between archives that restore victims and archives that manufacture them. The third is technological and increasingly urgent. It concerns the governance of artificial agents that persist across sessions only through notes left by their earlier instances. For such agents Leonard's predicament is not a pathology but an architecture, and the question of who may write to their memory is the question of who governs them.

Melville's Ishmael kept the untattooed parts of his body as a blank page for a poem he was composing (4.8). Leonard keeps a space on his chest for an inscription of completion that he can never write, because completion requires the memory of completion (5.8). He sees it once, in a fantasy, with his eyes closed. The film leaves that blank to the spectator, and its distributors did so literally, mailing strangers Polaroids of Leonard pointing at the unmarked space on his chest. The inscription of completion belongs to the one who has seen the whole, and it is not a sentence of triumph but of witness: not that the deed is done, but that what was done has been seen.

Kierkegaard's two propositions, that life must be understood backwards and lived forwards, are reconciled in *Memento* only outside it. The film understands Leonard's life backwards. The spectator, leaving the theater, must live forwards, carrying a memory its subject refused. Leonard ends where he begins again. This dissertation ends where its reader does: at the point where the text stops, and its last question, where was I, becomes a question about what one will do next with what one now knows.

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KEYWORDS

Memento; Christopher Nolan; Jonathan Nolan; "Memento Mori"; anterograde amnesia; hypomnesic sovereignty; *hypomnēsis*; *pharmakon*; Lethean constitution; personal identity; Locke; forensic person; forensic orphan; Parfit; Relation R; narrative identity; Ricoeur; ipseity; extended mind; invaded mind; authorial closure; transactive memory; tertiary retention; inscription; tattoo; photography; Polaroid; indexicality; proper names; reference; definite descriptions; vengeance; revenge tragedy; *Oresteia*; *Hamlet*; Girard; scapegoat; *méconnaissance*; *ressentiment*; forgiveness; *anagnorisis*; *peripeteia*; anti-anagnorisis; screen memory; *Nachträglichkeit*; repetition compulsion; mourning and melancholia; self-deception; bad faith; chronopartite self-deception; Kierkegaard; repetition; eternal recurrence; Nietzsche; mnemotechnics; Lethe; Mnemosyne; Orphic gold tablets; Hymn of the Pearl; Gnosticism; Book of the Dead; *Mahābhārata*; *Bhagavad Gītā*; Borges; Gene Wolfe; Philip K. Dick; speculative fiction; neo-noir; puzzle film; mind-game film; modular narrative; reverse chronology; afterwardsness; archive; Derrida; sovereignty; state of exception; Schmitt; founding violence; Pascal; Renan; *homo sacer*; political theology; spectatorial personhood; memory studies; philosophy of film; conjunctive laundering; Amalek; Levinas; Heidegger; call of conscience; bad infinity; fugue; traumatic epochē; inscriptional exemption; teleological continuity; Leonardine Circle; indexical laundering; refused apocalypse; Lethean archetype.